14 October 2026

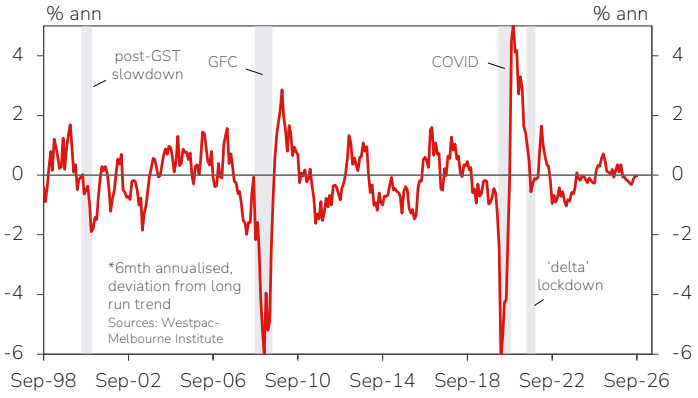
WESTPAC-MI LEADING INDEX BULLETIN

Latest insights into economic momentum

Key points

- Index growth rate holds at –0.03% in September, unchanged from August.
- Momentum is a touch below trend heading into late 2026/early 2027.
- Mixed detail suggests the economy lacking a clear direction.

Westpac-MI Leading Index



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Leading Index still tracking a touch below trend

Matthew Hassan
Head of Australian Macro-Forecasting

The six-month annualised growth rate in the Westpac–Melbourne Institute Leading Index, which indicates the likely pace of economic activity relative to trend three to nine months into the future, held at –0.03% in September, unchanged from August.

The Leading Index continues to show moderately improved momentum compared to the middle of the year, with the latest reads pointing to growth holding at or slightly below trend heading into late 2026/early 2027. Growth appears to be stabilising at a slow pace rather than stalling. That said, both the latest fuel prices and the RBA's September interest rate increase are still working their way through to the economy with impacts likely to take some of the gloss off growth near term. Overall, Westpac expects annual growth to come in at 1.5% for calendar 2026, a below-trend result.

The Leading Index growth rate has firmed slightly over the last six months, rising from –0.16% back in March to –0.03% in September. The component detail shows mixed moves over the period. Four components have contributed more positively with reduced drags from the Westpac-Melbourne Institute Unemployment Expectations Index (adding +0.23ppts to the Index growth rate); the Westpac-Melbourne Institute Consumer Expectations Index (adding another +0.15ppts); and the S&P/ASX200 (+0.15ppts) combining with a modest lift in growth in US industrial production (adding +0.12ppts). These positives have been partially offset by modest drags from four previously stable components: dwelling approvals (–0.34ppts); monthly hours worked (–0.08ppts); commodity prices, measured in AUD terms (–0.07ppts) and the yield spread (–0.05ppts).

Overall, the component mix speaks to a lack of direction. Indeed, despite some large shocks over the last year, the Leading Index growth rate has been relatively contained since early 2025, holding in a narrow –0.3% to +0.5% range. This compares to history which, outside of the COVID and GFC shocks, has seen growth rates move between a much wider –1.9% to +1.6% range. Of course, the apparent stability, which is evident across all components of the index, may not last but for now it suggests the economy has been stuck in a bit of a holding pattern over the last two years.

The Westpac-Melbourne Institute Leading Index of Economic Activity is designed to assist in identifying turning points in the economy. The index combines variables that reflect different aspects of the economy into a single index that generally produces a more reliable cyclical indicator than any single component taken individually. The Leading Index of Economic Activity provides advance information on the state of the economy and gives early warnings of cyclical turning points.

***Please note that this will be the last Westpac press release for the monthly Westpac-Melbourne Institute Leading Index. We will continue to publish regular bulletin updates through our westpaciq.com.au website.*

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Australian Business Conditions and Confidence, September

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By Luka Belobrajdic
Economist, Westpac

14:15 October 13 2026

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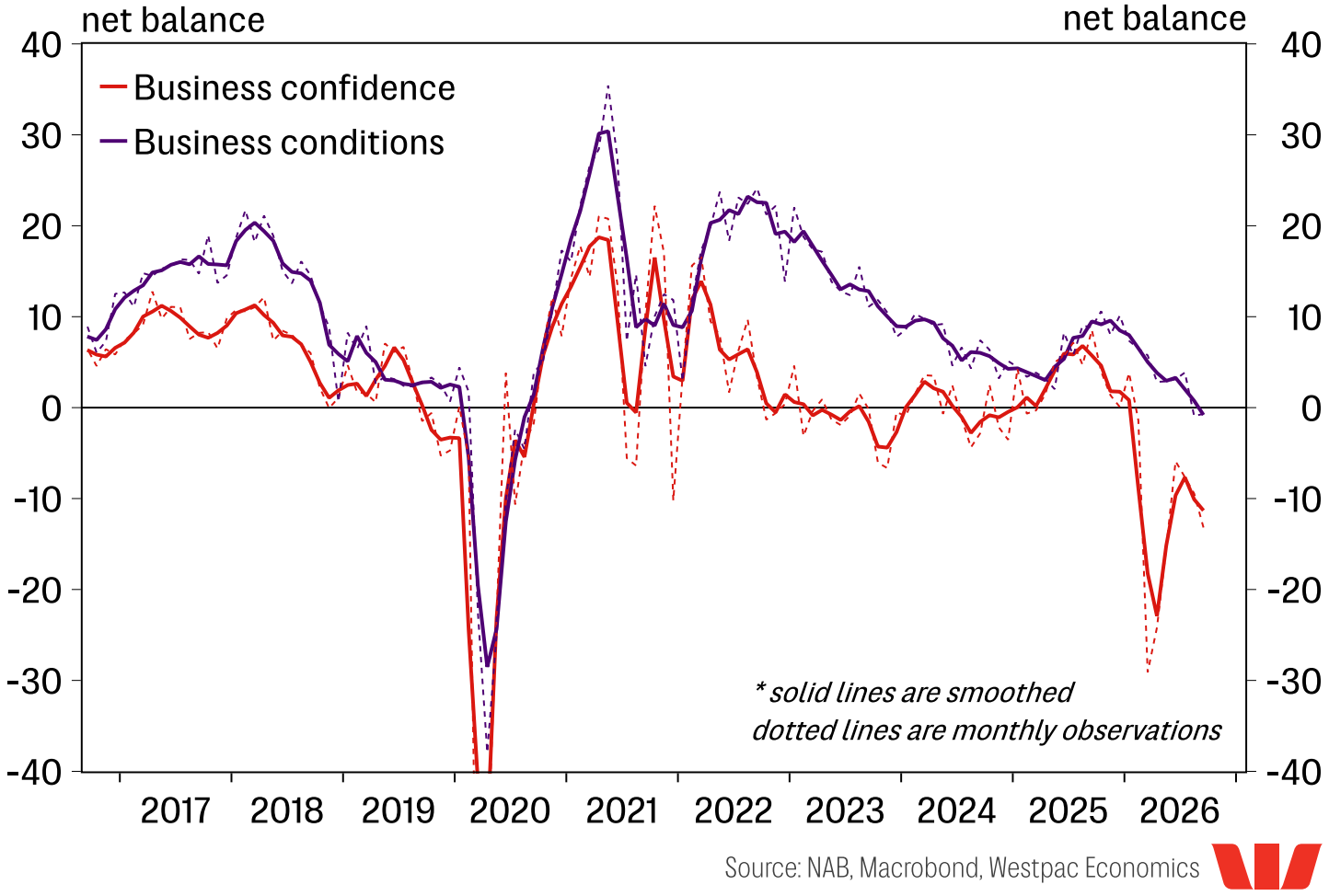
Confidence posts its sharpest fall since the start of the Middle East conflict as elevated fuel prices and higher interest rates weigh on business sentiment, while conditions hold steady at weak levels. Conditions unchanged at -1 / Confidence -4pts to -13.

The September NAB Business Survey was in the field from 23 to 30 September, capturing ongoing global uncertainty, still-rising fuel costs and, at least in part, the RBA's September rate hike. Business confidence continued to deteriorate, recording its sharpest fall since March and the onset of the Middle East conflict. The index declined 4pts to -13 and, while remaining above the lows recorded earlier this year, is now at its weakest level since May. At 18pts below its long-run average, the result underscores the deep pessimism that continues to weigh on businesses. This broadly mirrors the pessimism evident in the Westpac-Melbourne Institute Consumer Sentiment Index, where elevated fuel prices and higher interest rates have coalesced in a similarly weak assessment of the outlook.

The headline business conditions index held steady in negative territory at -1, albeit rising 0.25pts on an unrounded basis. While encouraging that conditions have not deteriorated further, the index has now remained at -1 (rounded) for two consecutive months, its weakest level since the height of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020. At 7pts below its long-run average, the result points to continued pressure across the business sector.

Business conditions and confidence



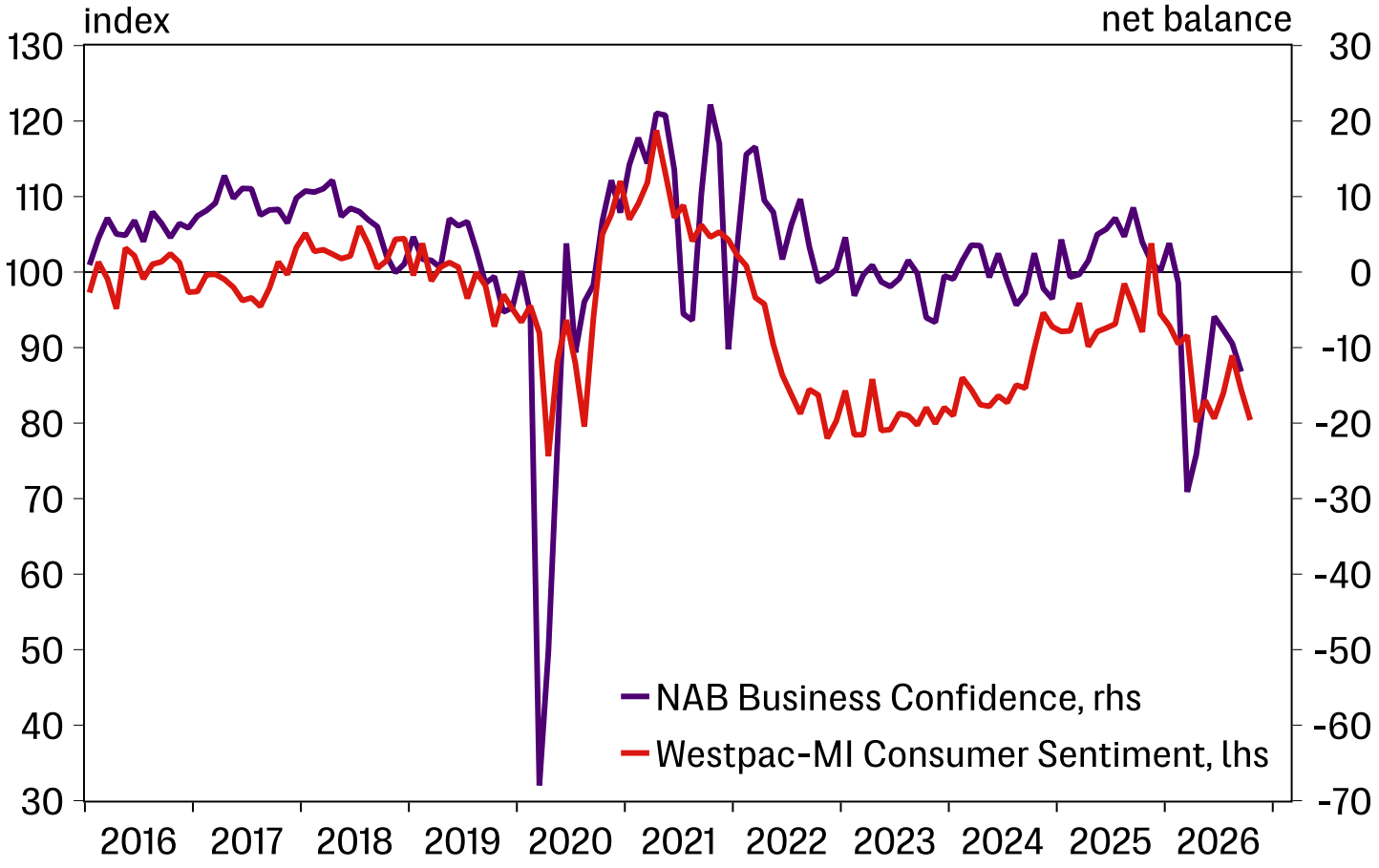
Source: NAB, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Across the major sub-components, employment moved into negative territory, falling 3pts to -1 and sitting 4pts below its long-run average. This marks the first outright negative reading since November 2020 and provides further evidence of the gradual easing in labour market conditions. Against the backdrop of compressed margins, the result may also indicate firms are becoming increasingly cautious around hiring decisions. By contrast, trading conditions rose 1pt to 4, although they remain 8pts below their long-run average. The relative resilience in trading conditions is broadly consistent with

Westpac DataX Card-Tracker data, which suggests nominal spending remained resilient, albeit slowing, through the September quarter despite ongoing headwinds facing consumers. Profitability recorded the strongest improvement across the major components, rising 3pts to -5, although the sub-index remains deeply subdued at 10pts below its long-run average.

Capacity utilisation edged 0.2ppt lower to 82.3%. While the monthly decline provides a tentative signal of easing capacity pressures, utilisation remains 0.9ppt above its long-run average and continues to trend higher on a three-month average basis. Capital expenditure continued to recover from its mid-year weakness, rising 3pts to 7. While still below the highs recorded in the first quarter, the sub-index is now trending higher on a three-month average basis, pointing to some stabilisation in investment intentions.

Consumer vs Business Confidence

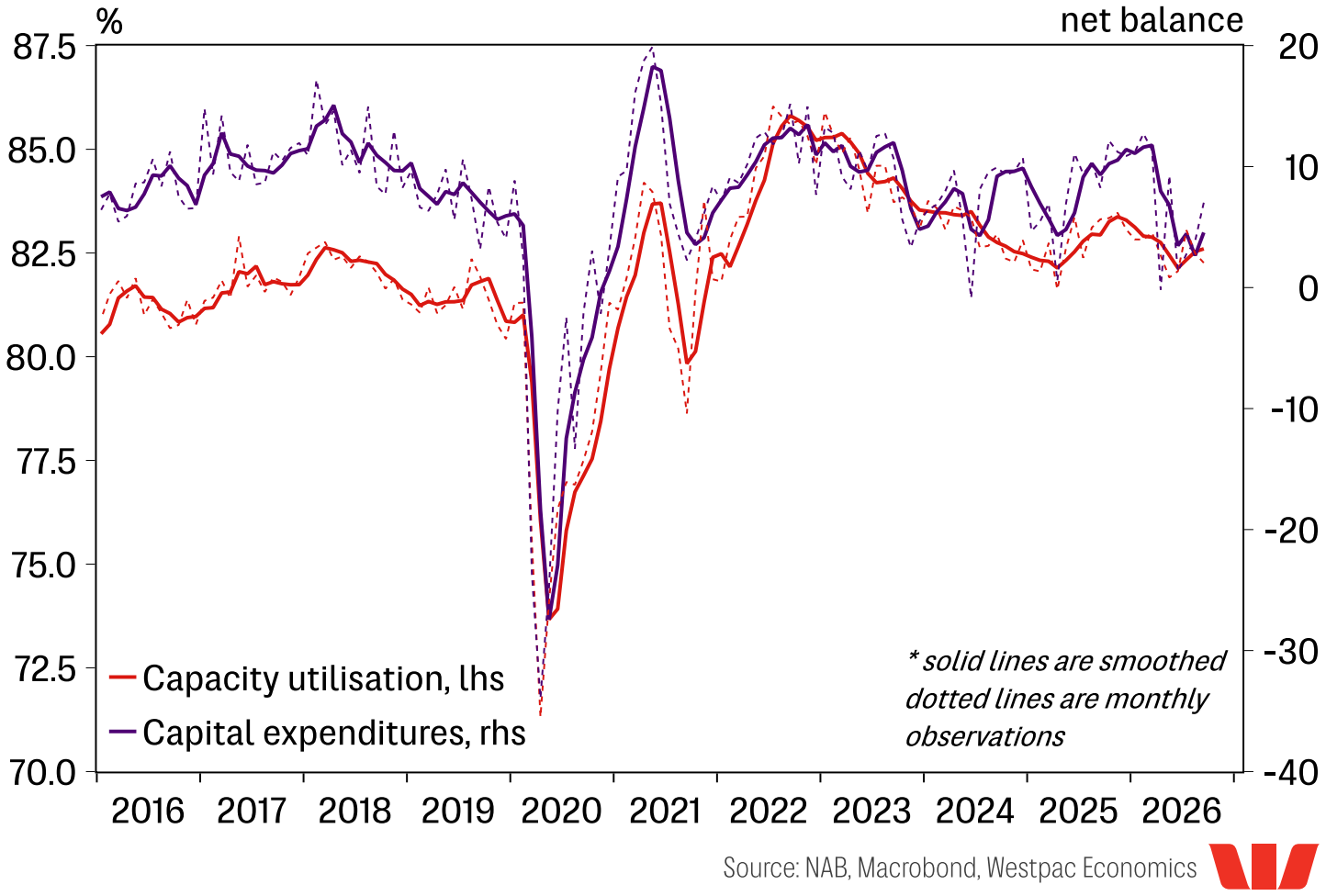


Source: NAB, Melbourne Institute of Applied Economic & Social Research, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Cost growth was comparatively subdued in September, although purchase cost pressures remain elevated. Purchase cost growth edged 0.1ppt higher to 2.4%qtr, sitting 1.1ppt above its long-run average and continuing to weigh on margins. By contrast, labour cost growth eased 0.1ppt to 1.7%qtr, although it remains 0.5ppt above its long-run average. Final product price growth was unchanged at 0.8%qtr, 0.2ppt above its long-run average. The widening gap between purchase cost and final product price growth suggests firms continue to absorb a meaningful share of higher input costs, consistent with profitability remaining deeply below average. Looking ahead, the October survey will provide an early indication of how the card surcharging ban is affecting business costs and the extent to which these are passed through to final prices.

Among other indicators, forward orders declined 1pt to -1, pointing to continued caution around the demand outlook. Inventories, by contrast, rose 4pts (rounded) to 7, some 5pts above their long-run average. In combination with weak forward orders, the inventory build points to a degree of slack emerging across the business sector.

Capacity utilisation and capital expenditures



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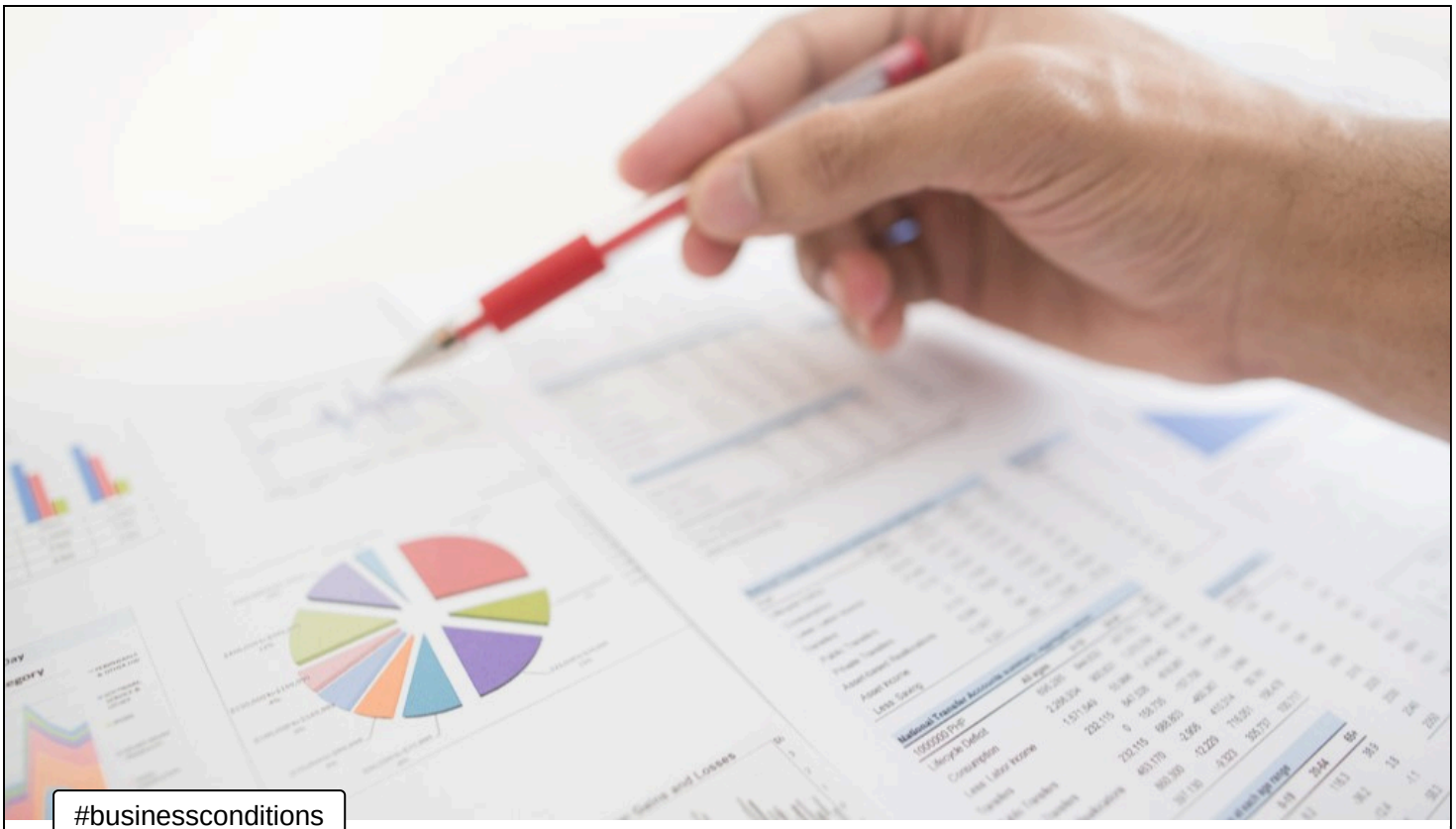

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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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19 December 2025

NOVEMBER CPI PREVIEW AND ANALYSIS

Complete Montly CPI will take some time to understand

Key points

- The October monthly CPI was flat in the month, broadly as we expected but stronger than market expectations. For more information see "Electrical noise is far from static".
- The impact on our inflation profile was marginal. The December quarter CPI remains 0.6%qtr/3.6%yr, while the Trimmed Mean edged up from 0.7%qtr/3.1%yr to 0.8%qtr/3.2%yr.
- Our November monthly CPI estimate is 0.4% for the month, leaving the annual pace unchanged at 3.8%yr.
- The introduction of the complete monthly CPI is a significant enhancement to our analysis of price formation in the Australian economy. However, with many series having only a short history, it will take time to fully understand some of the finer details.
- For now, we will continue to place greater emphasis on the quarterly measures of core inflation.

Breakdown: Dec Quarter CPI & Monthly CPI

	Dec	Sep	Oct	Nov
	Qtr fcs	Mth	Mth	Mth fcs
Item	% qtr	% mth	% mth	% mth
Food	**0.2**	**–0.3**	**0.2**	**0.2**
of which, bread & cereals	0.2	–0.3	0.1	0.2
of which, meat & seafood	2.2	0.4	1.0	0.6
of which, dairy & related prod.	1.1	0.7	–0.5	0.7
of which, fruit & vegetables	–3.8	–4.0	0.5	–0.2
of which, food products nec	0.7	0.6	–0.5	0.3
of which, non–alcohol bev.	–1.0	–0.8	–0.4	0.2
Alcohol & tobacco	**1.3**	**1.2**	**0.0**	**0.7**
of which, alcohol	–0.4	–0.4	–0.4	0.9
of which, tobacco	4.6	5.2	1.0	0.1
Clothing & footwear	**0.6**	**–0.6**	**2.2**	**–2.9**
of which, garments	0.1	–3.0	2.6	–1.6
Housing	**0.8**	**0.8**	**–0.8**	**2.2**
of which, rents	0.7	0.2	0.2	0.3
of which, house purchases	1.4	0.7	0.4	0.4
of which, electricity	–0.9	–0.4	–10.2	16.0
of which, gas & other fuels	–0.6	2.3	–3.7	3.2
H/hold contents & services	**0.2**	**2.1**	**2.0**	**–0.2**
Health	**–0.2**	**0.0**	**0.0**	**0.0**
Transportation	**1.0**	**0.1**	**0.3**	**0.6**
of which, auto fuel	1.7	0.5	–0.9	2.3
Communication	**–0.1**	**–0.2**	**–0.2**	**–0.1**
Recreation	**1.0**	**2.2**	**–0.2**	**–1.1**
of which, holiday travel	1.5	4.8	–1.0	–2.6
Education	**0.1**	**0.0**	**0.0**	**0.0**
Financial & insurance services	**0.3**	**0.3**	**0.2**	**0.0**
CPI: All groups	***0.6***	***0.5***	***0.0***	***0.4***

Sources: ABS, Westpac Banking Corporation

"... monthly volatility in some of the series is quite baffling ..."

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We will continue to focus on the quarterly prints

Justin Smirk
Senior Economist

No surprise in the October CPI

The new complete monthly CPI gained 3.8% in the year to October, coming in a touch softer than Westpac's estimate of 3.9%yr but a bit stronger than the market estimate of 3.6%yr. So while the market and other commentators may have been surprised by the result it was broadly within our expectations and as such has had just a marginal impact on our inflation profile.

The October CPI was flat in the month, a touch softer than Westpac's published near-cast of 0.1% on the back of a larger than expected decline in electricity (–10.2%) which was only partially offset by a smaller than expected decline in auto fuel (–0.9%) and an unexpected bump up in garments (+2.6%).

The Trimmed Mean (TM) lifted 0.3% in the month of October, the same monthly increase it has seen for the previous two months and down from the 0.5%mth increase in July but stronger than the 0.2%mth prints from March to June.

This saw the annual pace of the TM increase to 3.3% from 3.2% in September. This month the TM excluded the annual rise in electricity; alongside other large price rises and falls. Due to the short history of many series in the monthly CPI, the annual pace of monthly TM inflation can only be calculated back to April 2025. Before then the ABS notes that the annual pace is calculated from the quarterly CPI data.

For more information on the October monthly CPI see "Electrical noise is far from static".

Monthly CPI points to some momentum

Following the October CPI we have seen some minor revisions to the various components in our December quarter CPI estimate with the upward revisions, such as transport via auto fuel and motor vehicles, being offset by downward revisions to recreation, alcohol & tobacco and utilities in particular. This has left our December CPI estimate unchanged at 0.6%qtr.

As our Chief Economist, Luci Ellis, has noted that inflation did see a bump in the September quarter and again in the month of October. However, the main sources of the surprise have had little to do with domestic demand or labour market pressures. Rather, a sizeable part of the bump looks to have been from administered prices and noise. Since the release of the data, the RBA has recognised this issue but at the post RBA Board Decision Media Conference in December, the Governor communicated that the Bank is more worried about upside risks to inflation than first thought.

We agree that some of this momentum will continue into the December quarter as highlighted by our upward revision in our

Revision to the December quarter CPI estimate

	Nov 2, 2025		Dec 12, 2025	
Item	**% qtr**	**contrib**	**% qtr**	**contrib**
Food	**0.4**	**0.07**	**0.2**	**0.04**
of which, Fruit & vegetables	–2.8	–0.06	–3.8	–0.08
Alcohol & tobacco	**1.9**	**0.13**	**1.3**	**0.09**
of which, Tobacco	5.0	0.10	4.6	0.09
Clothing & footwear	**–0.3**	**–0.01**	**0.6**	**0.02**
Housing	**1.0**	**0.22**	**0.8**	**0.18**
of which, Rents	0.4	0.03	0.7	0.05
of which, House purchases	1.3	0.10	1.4	0.11
of which, Utilities	2.0	0.09	0.2	0.01
H/hold contents & services	**0.2**	**0.02**	**0.2**	**0.02**
Health	**–0.2**	**–0.01**	**–0.2**	**–0.02**
of which, Pharmaceuticals	–1.6	–0.02	–1.4	–0.01
Transportation	**–1.3**	**–0.15**	**1.0**	**0.11**
of which, Car prices	–0.2	–0.01	0.1	0.00
of which, Auto fuel	–4.0	–0.13	1.7	0.06
Communication	**0.3**	**0.01**	**–0.1**	**0.00**
Recreation	**1.8**	**0.22**	**1.0**	**0.12**
of which, Audio visual & comp.	–1.4	–0.03	–0.4	–0.01
of which, Holiday travel	4.6	0.28	1.5	0.10
Education	**0.0**	**0.00**	**0.1**	**0.00**
Financial & insurance services	**0.4**	**0.02**	**0.3**	**0.02**
CPI: All groups	**0.6**	**–**	**0.6**	**–**
CPI: All groups % year	**3.6**	**–**	**3.6**	**–**

Sources: ABS, Westpac Banking Corporation

Westpac inflation profile

		Dec–25	Mar–26	Jun–26	Sep–26
CPI	Index	144.4	145.5	146.5	147.5
	(%qtr)	0.6	0.8	0.7	0.7
	(%yr)	3.6	3.4	3.4	2.7
Trimmed mean	(%qtr)	0.8	0.6	0.6	0.6
	(%yr)	3.2	3.1	3.0	2.6
	(6mth ann'd)	3.7	2.7	2.4	2.4

Source: ABS, Westpac Economics.

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December quarter TM estimate to 0.8%qtr/3.2%yr from our earlier estimate of 0.7%qtr/3.1%yr.

For the December quarter, price changes that are included in the TM go from a low of –0.26% to a high of 1.66%. Readers will remember that the TM is calculated from seasonally adjusted price changes and not the original estimates so if unaffected by regular seasonal price shifts. We estimate that the most significant components to be trimmed off the top in the quarter are: electricity (2.7%); other services for motor vehicles (2.5%); tobacco (2.1%); and automotive fuel (1.7%). Trimmed off the bottom are: other non-durable household products (–0.39%); garments for women (–0.92%); international holiday travel (–0.97%); vegetables (–1.16%) and wine (–1.27%).

However, we do not expect this momentum to continue through 2026. As Luci noted in her article "RBA on hold in 2026, risks on both sides" we expect inflation to keep easing, due to the lagged impact of past restrictive policy and the unwind of earlier government support measures. We believe that many commentators have overlooked these lags. Monetary policy typically takes a year or more to fully affect jobs and prices, so current outcomes reflect the peak cash rate from a year ago and we expect to see further labour market softening. Strong hiring across the care economy has masked some of that restrictiveness, as has public infrastructure spending, but these supports are now fading along with last year's tax-cut boost. We believe that even with the 75bps in rate cuts this year, policy remains mildly restrictive, and given usual lags, this will keep showing in the data through 2026.

Taking a look at some of the recent larger moves in monthly prices can highlight many of the issues Luci raises. Taking the seasonally adjusted data, smoothing it with a three month average then calculating the change over three months (so we have three months on three months percentage change) we find at the top end of the list some price increases you would not expect to continue at the same pace.

For example at the top are: lamb & goat (8.1%, highly seasonal); accessories (8.1% with jewellery prices surging on the back of record high gold prices); audio visual & computing services (6.0% due to Netflix subscriptions); beef & veal (3.7%, highly seasonal); coffee & tea (3.6% noting global coffee prices have passed their peak and are already significantly lower); water & sewerage (2.3% IPART decision was for a 13.8% increase for Sydney Water in October); property rates & charges (2.3% administered prices); and electricity (1.2%, reflecting unwinding of cost of living rebates). Offsetting some of these increases was falling prices for: men's footwear (–2.0%); vegetables (–2.0% seasonal); eggs (–1.5%, reflecting the unwinding of the price spike associated with an outbreak of bird flu); and major household appliances (–1.2%).

Core inflation still to moderate through 2026

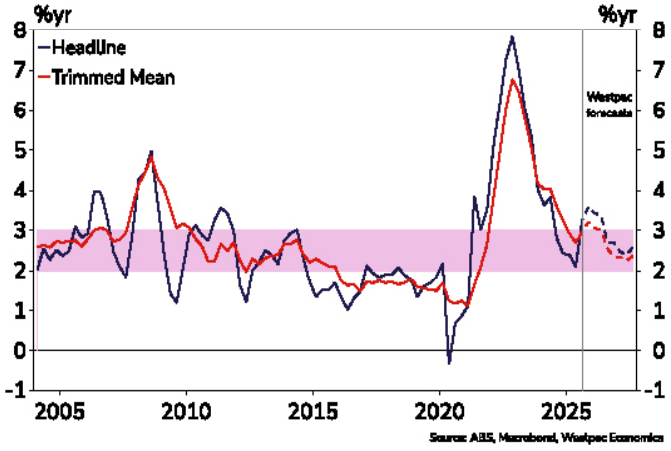
We are projecting headline inflation to get back to the RBA's target band, but not until later in 2026. We now see core inflation back below the midpoint of the 2–3% range at the end of the year. We had thought this might be achieved by the third quarter but now expect current momentum to continue

Breakdown: Monthly CPI Annual Pace

	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov fcs
	Mth	Mth	Mth	Mth
Item	**% yr**	**% yr**	**% yr**	**% yr**
Food	**3.0**	**3.2**	**3.2**	**3.1**
of which, bread & cereals	2.1	1.9	0.7	0.6
of which, meat & seafood	2.9	3.4	3.8	4.2
of which, dairy & related prod.	1.3	2.6	3.0	2.8
of which, fruit & vegetables	1.2	0.7	1.8	0.0
of which, food products nec	4.1	4.3	3.8	0.0
of which, non–alcohol bev.	4.9	5.4	4.8	4.7
Alcohol & tobacco	**6.0**	**5.5**	**4.4**	**4.9**
of which, alcohol	3.1	2.2	1.6	2.1
of which, tobacco	12.6	13.5	11.6	11.6
Clothing & footwear	**4.3**	**3.8**	**5.4**	**5.4**
of which, garments	3.1	1.4	3.6	3.0
Housing	**4.5**	**5.7**	**5.9**	**6.3**
of which, rents	3.7	3.8	4.2	3.9
of which, house purchases	0.7	1.5	1.7	2.7
of which, electricity	24.6	33.9	37.1	30.1
of which, gas & other fuels	4.1	6.5	3.8	3.8
H/hold contents & services	**1.7**	**1.8**	**2.1**	**2.1**
Health	**4.1**	**4.2**	**4.0**	**4.2**
Transportation	**0.9**	**2.3**	**2.7**	**3.0**
of which, auto fuel	–1.7	2.8	1.9	3.4
Communication	**1.8**	**1.6**	**0.8**	**0.7**
Recreation	**1.4**	**1.8**	**3.2**	**2.0**
of which, holiday travel	1.1	2.0	3.0	1.6
Education	**5.4**	**5.4**	**5.4**	**5.4**
Financial & insurance services	**2.9**	**2.5**	**2.5**	**2.5**
CPI: All groups	***3.2***	***3.6***	***3.8***	***3.8***

Sources: ABS, Westpac Banking Corporation

Trimmed Mean to lower half of the RBA's target



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for a bit longer. However, it is worth noting that our estimate of the six month annualised pace of the TM is down to 2.4%yr by June 2026.

Electricity to boost November CPI

Westpac is estimating a 0.4% increase in the November monthly CPI which will hold the annual pace flat at 3.8%yr. The seasonally adjusted estimate is 0.5% in the month suggesting it is a stronger than usual estimate.

Boosting the November estimate is: a 16% surge in electricity (as the impact of the last round of rebates fades); a 3.2% jump in gas & other household fuels; and a 2.3% bump in auto fuel (based on reported pump prices). Partially offsetting these gains is a –2.6% decline in holiday travel & accommodation and a –2.9% drop in clothing & footwear.

Take care with the Monthly CPI

Many series in the monthly CPI only date back to early 2024 so seasonal adjustment is somewhat problematic. Some series did have a longer monthly history coming from the previously published monthly CPI indicator and it appears the ABS may have used some of this to seasonally adjust the data. However, we caution that some of the new data has a different history to the old data and as such, we expect it is going to take some time to understand the seasonal behaviour of the new data.

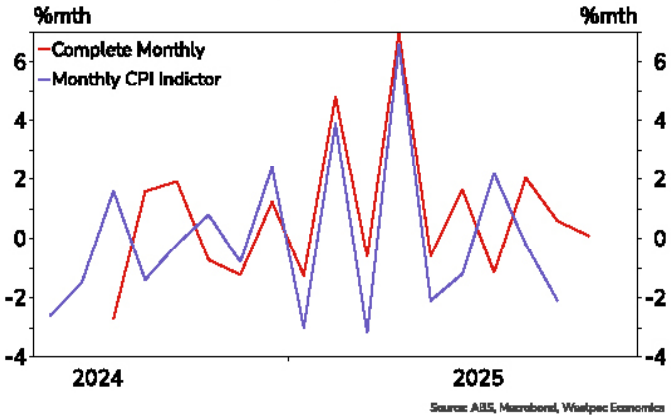
For example, for male garments there is some difference with the reported monthly change compared to the old CPI Indicator series but this appears to be only marginal. However, for women's, the difference can be significant with even a reversal of the sign of change in some recent months. And for some series with a short history and no monthly indicator data to compare to some of the adjustment appears to be a little arbitrary, as you can see in the chart right which compares the children's garments index in original and seasonally adjusted terms. The only adjustment made to the series was in June 2025 when a –3.2% change was adjusted to a flat print. Why? We are yet to uncover.

You can also see where the ABS has turned to smoothing processes to seasonally adjust short data series. In the chart over the seasonally adjusted series looks as if has been generated by applying a Henderson Trend to the original children's footwear series.

As such, we expect it is possible there will be significant adjustments made to the seasonally adjustment process as data is collected which could result in significant revisions to seasonally adjusted series including the Trimmed Mean and the Weighted Median.

Womens Garments Monthly

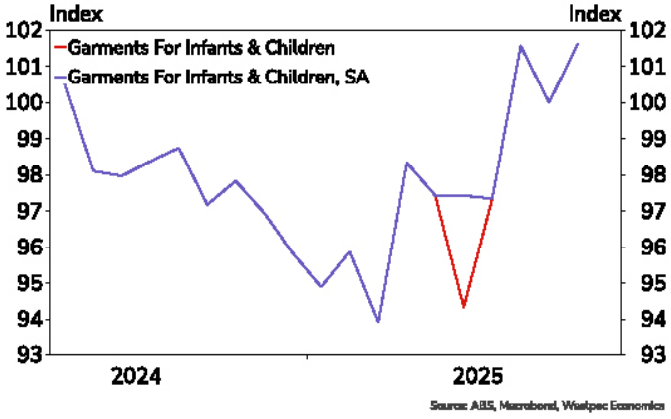
Monthly Indicator vs. Monthly Complete CPI



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Childrens Garments Monthly CPI

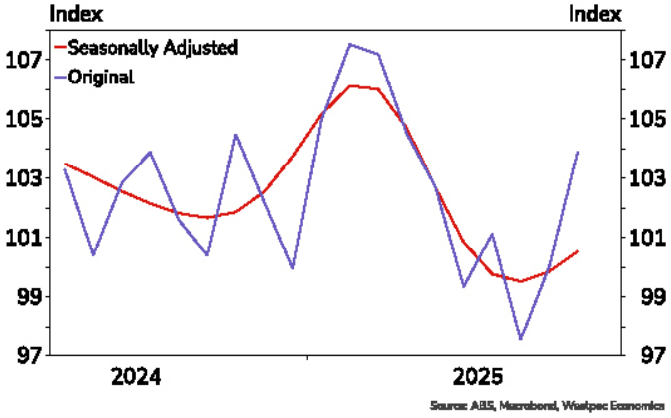
Original vs Seasonally Adjusted



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Monthly CPI Childrens Footwear

Original vs. Seasonally Adjusted



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Cliff Notes: searching for signal

#cliffnotes #rba #australia #inflation #us #fomc #ecb #aud #usd

By Sian Fenner, Ryan Wells & Illiana Jain

13:33 October 02 2026

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Key insights from the week that was.

In Australia, this week's main event was the RBA Monetary Policy Board's (MPB) decision to raise the cash rate by 25bps to 4.60%. This outcome was universally expected given Governor Bullock had already communicated that upside risks to inflation had materialised – the conditionality established by the MPB back in August for considering another rate hike.

Governor Bullock made explicit note of three upside risks. The Middle East conflict was emphasised as the risk that had "materialised", given the re-escalation and renewed surge in crude oil and refined product prices over recent months. The RBA's liaison warns this could lead to further pass-through of costs and more persistent inflation pressures. On top of this, domestic capacity pressures and the data centre/AI investment boom were also noted as upside risks that the MPB remain alert to.

In a video update mid-week, Chief Economist Luci Ellis explains why the bar for a follow-up rate hike in November is low. We now expect a 25bp increase in November, provided there is no sudden resolution of the Middle East conflict beforehand, or some other event that significantly lowers the outlook for energy-related costs.

Subsequently, the August CPI revealed that underlying (trimmed mean) inflation rose 0.2% (3.4%yr), which was slightly below the market's expectation but spot on Westpac's forecast. As usual, the monthly detail was mixed, but the key drivers of underlying inflation remain centred on housing-related components, particularly rents and new dwelling purchases. Headline inflation remained volatile, with the unwind of the fuel excise cut causing another spike in fuel prices. We have maintained our forecast for a 0.9% lift in trimmed mean inflation in Q3, and with upside risks building for Q4, a follow-up rate hike in November appears most likely.

Regarding the current growth pulse, household spending surprised with a flat reading in August. Services spend fell back following recent strength that was driven by major sporting events, but this was offset by an increase in goods spend, particularly in fuel and electric vehicles. Together with our latest card data for early September, the consumer spending pulse is shading a touch softer. However, another solid outcome for business investment could once again be on the cards for Q3. August's goods trade data showcased another significant spike in data centre-related equipment imports, up $4.3bn, similar in scale to Q1. While clearly import-driven, our modelling suggests that the local economic impact of such investment is likely to be around half of the total investment.

Before moving offshore, a final note on housing. Cotality's latest update revealed that dwelling prices fell another 1.1% nationally in September. While Sydney and Melbourne have led the correction to date, the fact that the other capitals are also reporting price declines clearly indicates that the correction is deepening and broadening, as higher interest rates collide with the tax policy changes announced in May's budget. Sentiment effects indeed remain at play, as evinced by the continued pull-back in investor credit growth. Westpac anticipates a peak-to-trough decline of around 7%, with tight on-market supply limiting the extent of the correction. For more, see our latest Housing Pulse.

Offshore, there was plenty of data to dissect.

In the US, inflation eased in August despite ongoing strength in household demand and higher energy prices. Headline PCE inflation rose 0.3%mth and 3.4%yr, while core PCE increased 0.2%mth and 3.0%yr. Encouragingly for the FOMC, the share of PCE components rising by more than 3% over the past year, a measure frequently cited by Fed Chairman Kevin Warsh, declined to 45% from 49%, suggesting some easing in broad-based inflation pressures. At the same time, household spending remained robust, increasing 0.9%mth, equivalent to around 0.6%mth in real terms. That said, personal income growth was soft, rising 0.2% in the month, signalling households opted to draw down savings.

The ISM manufacturing survey was stronger than the headline suggested. While the index edged down 0.1pt to 54.5, manufacturing has now expanded for nine consecutive months. There were some signs of capacity constraints emerging, with production softened in the month but backlogs up 4.6pts to 56.4, suggesting that firms struggled to keep pace with demand. New orders rose 1.6pts to 55.3, primarily due to domestic demand as new export orders eased, backlogs increased. Firms responded by lifting employment, 1.5pts to 52.7. Against this backdrop manufacturers saw a renewed acceleration in cost pressures, with the prices paid index jumping 6.8pts to 77.9. Firms cited higher steel and aluminium prices, elevated energy costs, rising freight charges and ongoing semiconductor shortages, with every major industry reporting higher input costs during the month.

The past week's data will have done nothing to bridge the clear divide across the FOMC, as evident in this week's busy Fedspeak. Some participants argued for further rate hikes, citing strong inflation, diminished supply capacity and policy that is not yet restrictive. Others counselled patience, pointing to progress on inflation and that September's hike buys time to assess upcoming data. The one thing both agree on is that inflation will be the primary determinant of the timing and extent of further rate hikes. Our view remains that one further hike is likely this cycle to bring policy closer to neutral.

In China, policymakers announced another round of targeted support measures aimed at stabilising growth and supporting the struggling property sector. The PBOC lowered rates on its Pledged Supplementary Lending facility by 25bps to 1.5% and expanded quotas for targeted lending programs. Authorities also introduced subsidies for eligible first-home buyers. The subsidy applies to homes with a floor area of 120m² or less and a value below CNY1.5mn, with support capped at 1ppt of mortgage costs, up to CNY10,000 and for a maximum term of five years. The measures complement reforms announced in August to improve developer financing conditions and support housing completion. However, weak credit demand and confidence remains a significant constraint, suggesting policy transmission is still limited.

The September PMI data pointed to a modest improvement in activity, although the details were less convincing. Manufacturing returned to expansionary territory, rising 0.9pts to 50.1, supported by stronger production and new orders. Much of the improvement, however, reflected a rebound in prices, with the raw materials price index rising 7.6pts and producer prices increasing 6.2pts. Labour market conditions remained weak, with the employment index falling a further 0.6pts and remaining below 50 for almost four years. Conditions in the non-manufacturing sector also improved, with the services PMI lifting from 49.0 to 50.2, driven largely by stronger construction activity. Input and output prices moved higher, selling prices returned back above 50, export orders improved to 48.5 and employment increased 0.5pts, although at 45.9 it remains firmly in contractionary territory. Overall, the surveys suggest activity is stabilising and policy support is gaining some traction, but weak labour demand, subdued credit growth and soft domestic demand indicate the recovery remains fragile.

In Japan, the September Tankan survey delivered another constructive signal on the economy and reinforced the case for further policy normalisation. Business conditions improved by 2pts for large manufacturers and 5pts more broadly, while profitability indicators strengthened and capital expenditure intentions remained elevated. Large manufacturers expect fixed investment to increase by 11.6% in FY2026, while large non-manufacturers expect investment growth of 11.2%, pointing to

continued confidence in the medium-term outlook.

Capacity indicators improved further across both manufacturing and non-manufacturing sectors, with measures of excess production capacity becoming less negative and indicating that demand remains sufficiently strong to keep pressure on existing capacity. Labour shortages also intensified, with employment conditions becoming more negative across most industries and firm sizes, pointing to a progressively tighter labour market. Inflation expectations remained anchored around 2%, providing further evidence that Japan is moving towards a more sustainable inflation environment. Overall, the survey was consistent with an economy operating close to capacity and supports the view that a December rate hike remains a realistic possibility.

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Australia's Trade in Goods Account, August

#trade #australia

By Ryan Wells
Economist, Westpac

13:19 October 01 2026

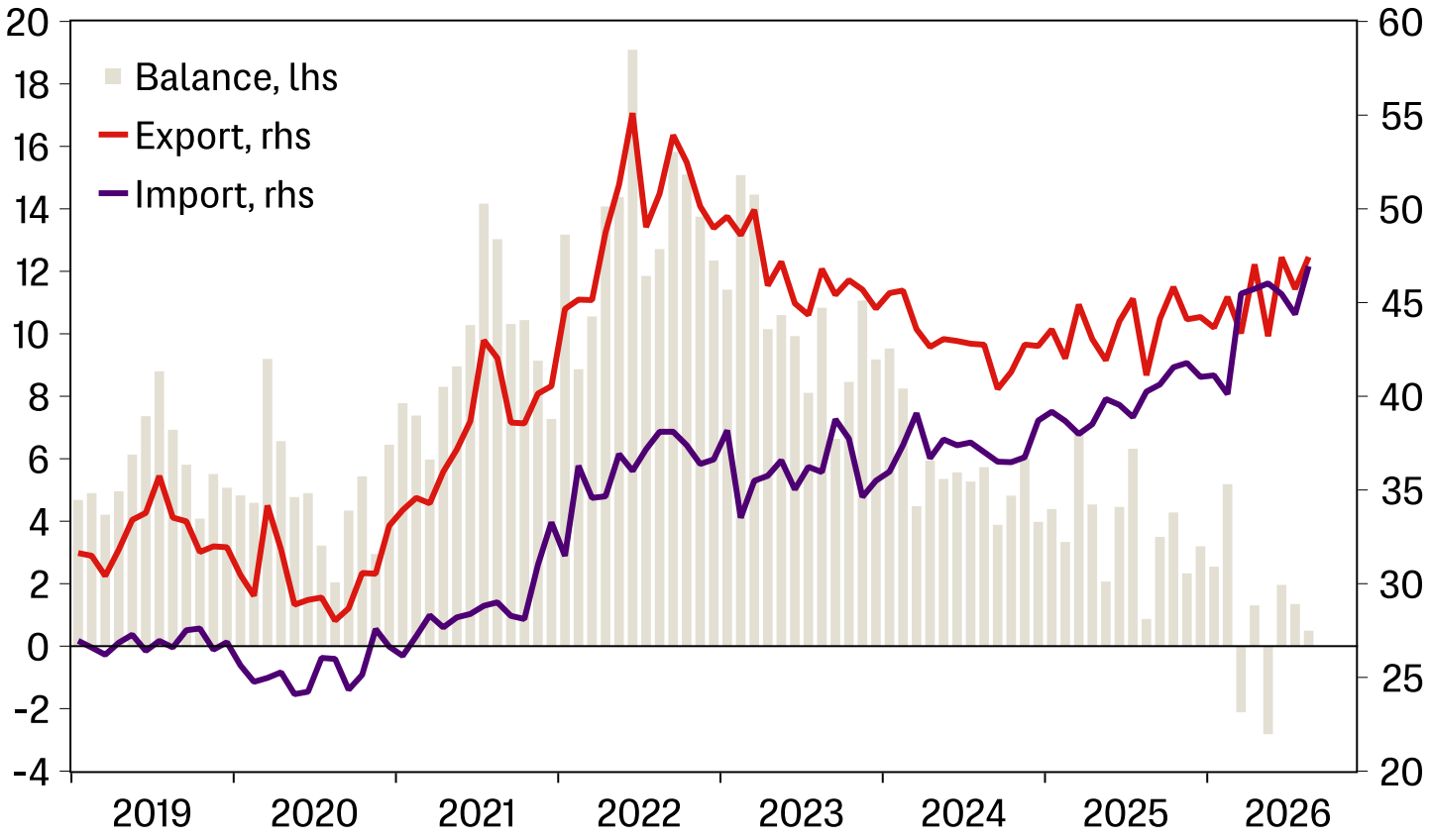
Share

Another surge in data centre-related equipment imports in August, alongside continued volatility in gold trade. Trade balance: $0.5bn surplus. Export values: 3.7%mth. Import values: 5.8%mth.

Australia's goods trade surplus narrowed to $0.5bn in August from $1.4bn in July (revised down from $1.9bn previously). This result was significantly lower than expected – the market consensus was for a broadly stable reading, while Westpac had a slight widening pencilled in. Over the past six months or so, the trade balance has been oscillating between small deficits and surpluses, largely coinciding with significant month-to-month volatility in the trade mix. The chief culprit behind this volatility has been trade in non-monetary gold, among other components.

Goods Trade Balance

Value, $bn

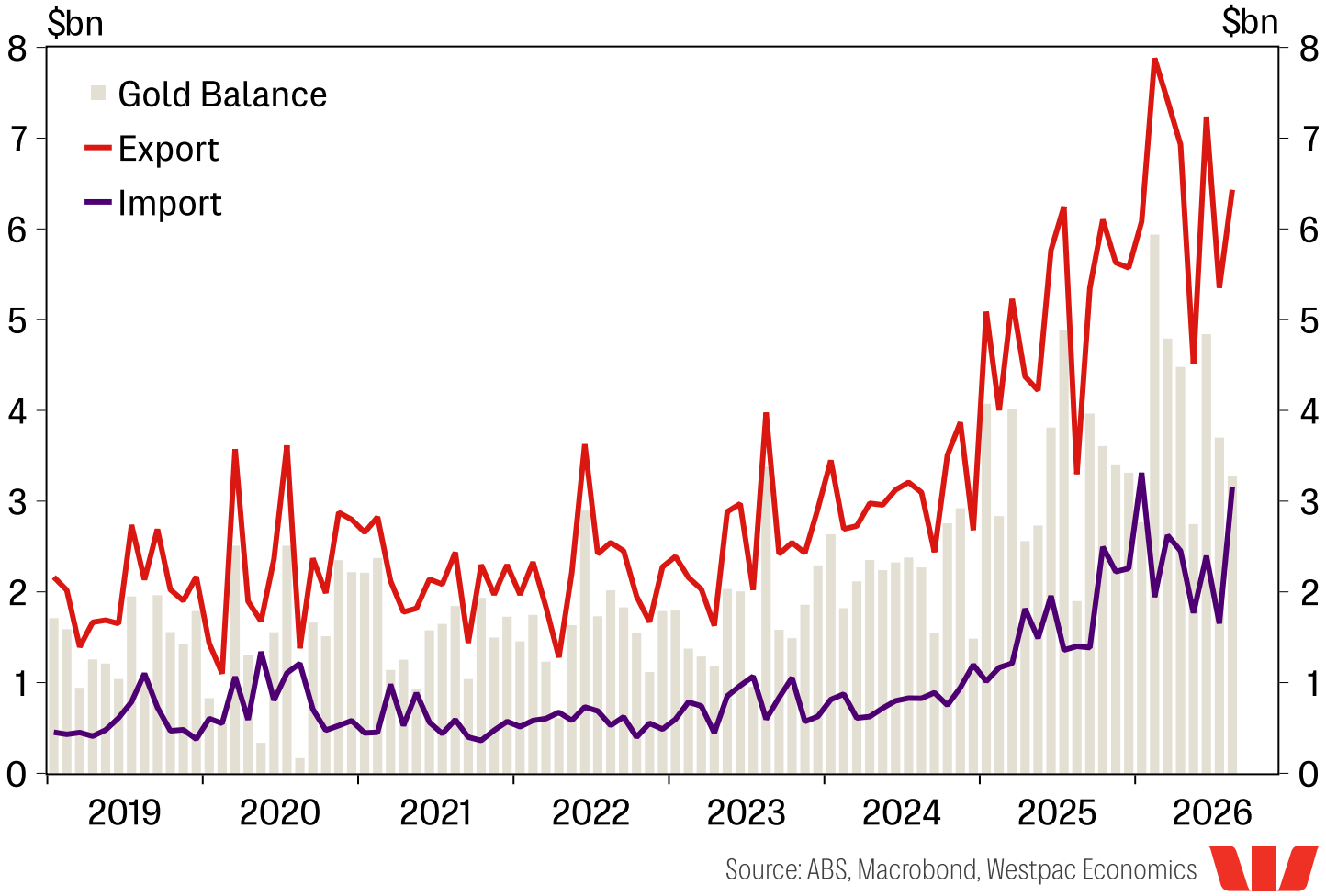


Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Before discussing the detail, it is once again worth noting the results for gold up front. In August, non-monetary gold exports jumped 20%, while imports surged 91%. Excluding gold, the trade figures have been much more stable, closer to a deficit of $2-3bn per month over the past three months, down from larger deficits around the start of the year.

Export earnings rose 3.7% in August, bouncing back from a 3.6% decline in July. The trend for exports so far this year looks a bit more positive, but again, this is tricky to read given the volatility present in the data. Excluding gold, export earnings were up 1.6% in August. This was largely supported by a 4.7% lift in coal and a 2.8% increase in LNG, with further detail provided by the ABS suggests that an increase in both volumes and prices contributed. However, iron ore (–1.5%) and rural goods (–1.0%) weighed on earnings in the month.

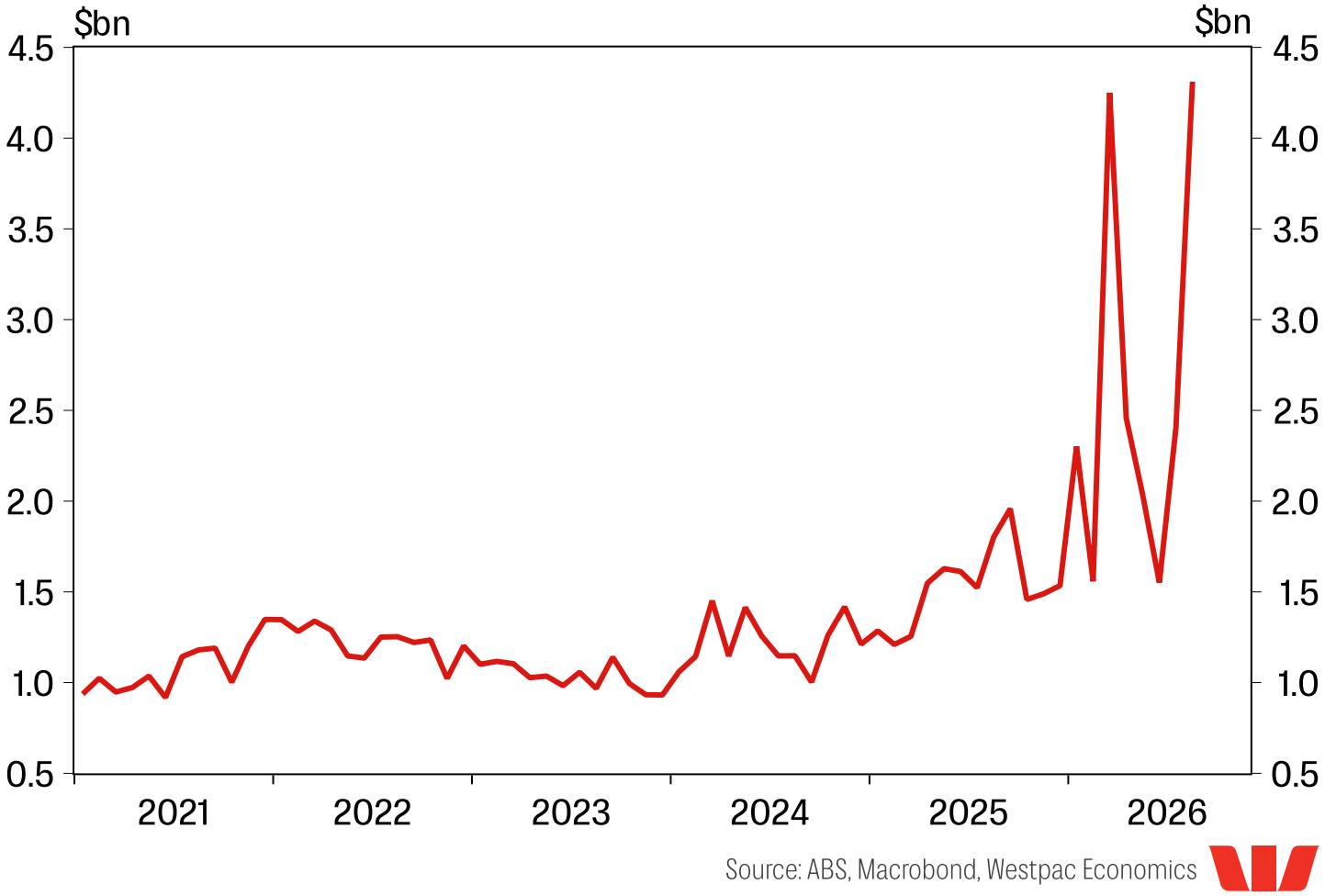
Gold Trade (Values)



The import bill meanwhile increase by 5.8% in August. Once again, a surge in automatic data processing (ADP) equipment imports – which capture the investment upswing related to data centres – were in the spotlight, surging 79% in the month up to $4.3bn. There were also an increase in other capital goods imports centred on telecommunications equipment (+12%) and civil aircraft (+30%) – large in their own right but dwarfed by the surge in ADP imports in the month.

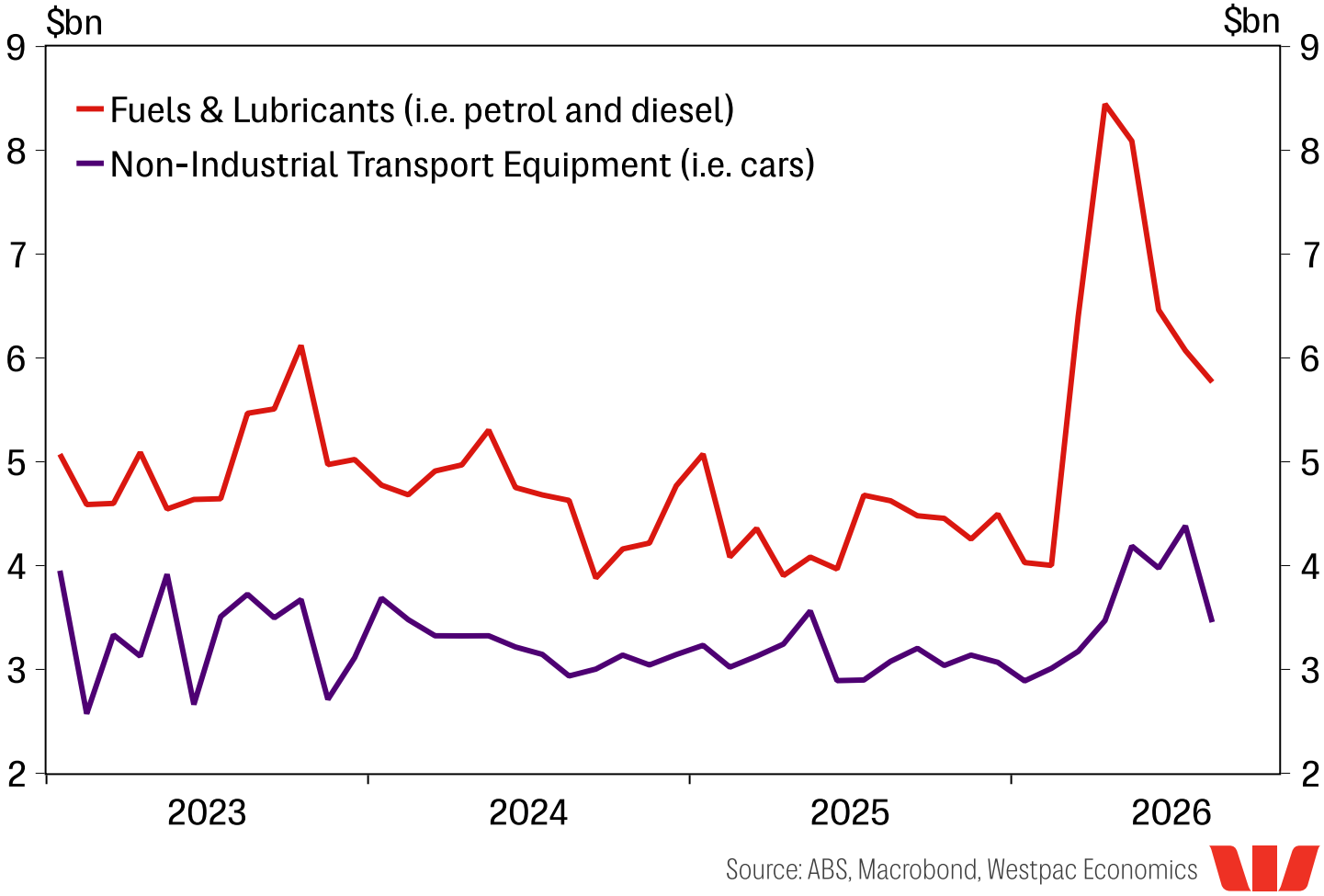
Our latest estimates have the total pipeline for data centres at around $175bn over the coming decade, with much of that being front-loaded. It is natural to expect month-to-month volatility in ADP equipment imports as these large and lumpy data centre projects are worked through, but it is worth highlighting that August's jump closely resembles the surge from March, when imports also surged to around $4.3bn. Given the scale of the increase in August, Q3 is shaping up to be another quarter where data centre investment will play a significant role in driving growth – while it is true that the data centre build-out is import-intensive, our modelling suggests that once spending enters Australia, the local economic impact is likely to be around half of the total investment.

ADP equipment imports



Elsewhere across the import basket, while gold imports also surged, it was effectively offset by a decline in consumer imports of non-industrial transport equipment (i.e. cars), down 21.2% in August following the surge from May to July. While still tentative at this stage, it suggests that the momentum in EV purchases, which played a significant role in the consumer spending story in Q2, may be starting to wane. Additionally, a further pull-back in fuel imports (–5.0%) in August has extended the downward trend in recent months, following the initial surge in oil prices in March and April after the war in the Middle East began. However, with the conflict re-escalating recently and margins on refined fuel products widening, we could see this trend reverse over the coming months.

Goods Imports – Cars & Fuel



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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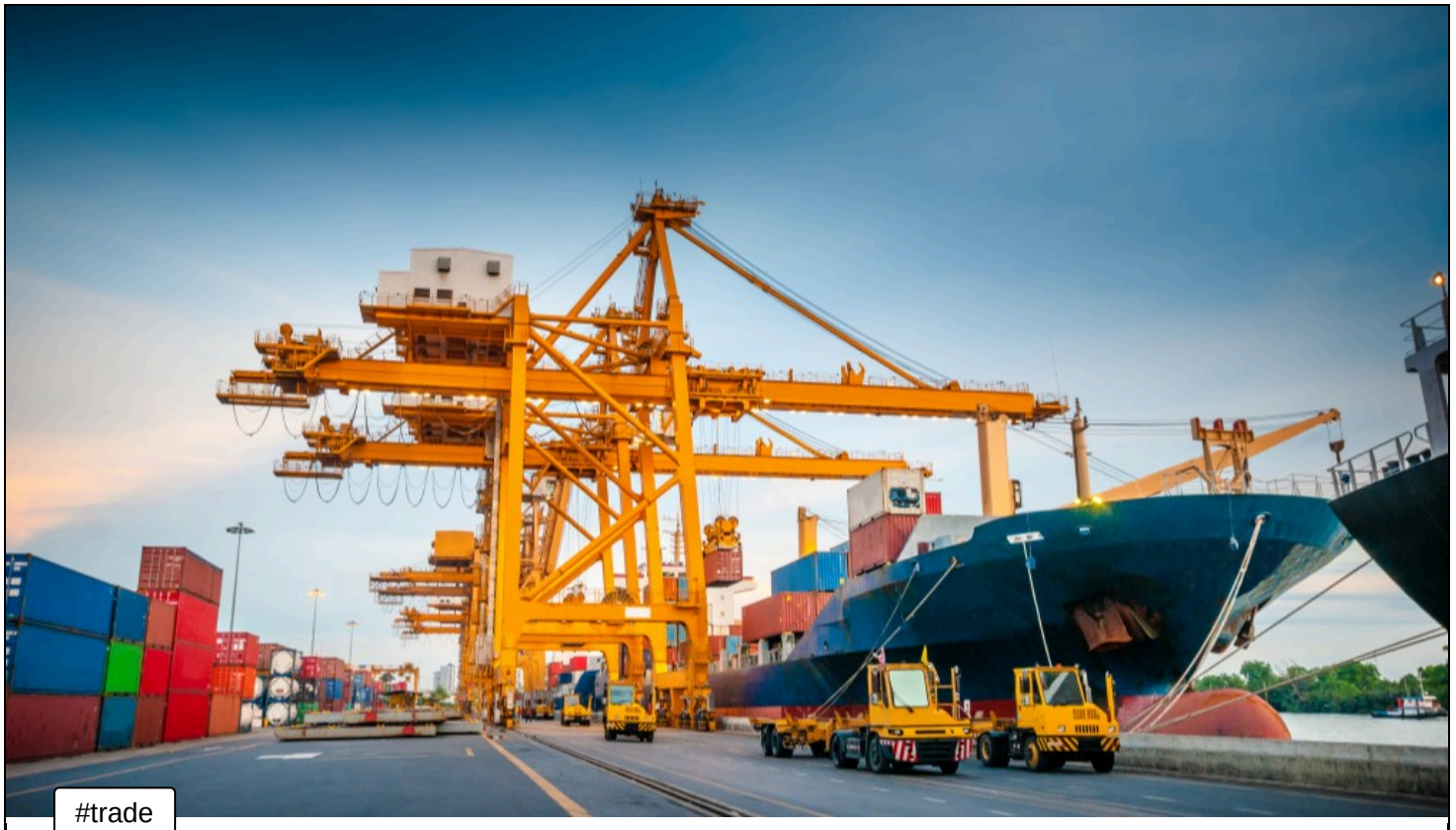

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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

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- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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25 September 2026

WESTPAC NOWCAST Q3 2026: FIRST ESTIMATE

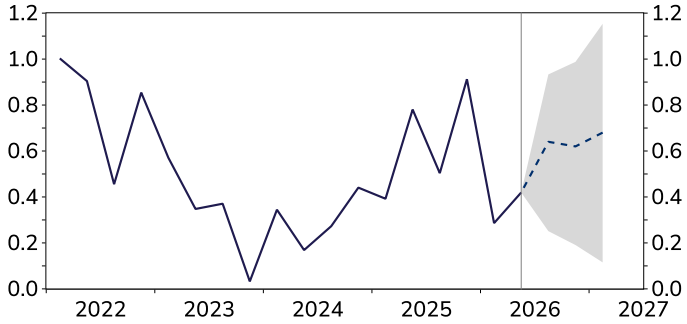
Growth picks up despite headwinds

Key points

- Westpac-Now points to GDP growth of around 0.6%qtr in Q3 2026 (with a 70% confidence interval of 0.29%qtr to 0.91%qtr) and 2.3%yr. This is a step up from the 0.4%qtr and 2.1%yr recorded in Q2 2026 (see here) and implies that economic momentum has strengthened.
- Our Monthly Activity Index has stabilised after declining sharply since November 2025 and is now showing signs of improvement in July. This provides further evidence the economy is proving more resilient than initially feared. Rather than deteriorating further, activity appears to be weathering the impacts of the Middle East conflict and higher interest rates relatively well.
- The RBA is unlikely to be comfortable with this combination of improving conditions and firmer economic momentum. Growth at 2.3%yr would be close to our estimate of 'trend', but it is above the RBA's estimate at a time when the Bank is trying to engineer a period of below-trend growth to ensure inflation returns to target.
- Overall, the results are consistent with our view that the economy is being supported by powerful business investment tailwinds, centred on data centres and renewable energy (see here). This investment surge is largely unrelated to the domestic business cycle or interest rates and is increasingly offsetting weakness elsewhere in the economy.

GDP Growth*

Quarterly % growth.



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

*Dotted line shows Westpac-Now central estimates. Quarter ahead (or Q3 2026) relies on the actual Westpac monthly activity index to July 2026. Beyond the quarter ahead, estimates rely on projections of the Westpac monthly activity index generated using internal model dynamics. Confidence intervals reflect empirical out of sample forecasting errors.

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Economic momentum building

Pat Bustamante
Senior Economist

In November 2025, we introduced Westpac-Now (Westpac Nowcast (Westpac-Now): The Upswing Accelerates | Westpac IQ), a real time measure of current activity in the Australian economy. Westpac-Now draws on more than 60 high frequency economic and financial variables, using advanced statistical techniques to provide a timely pulse check on economic momentum. It is the first Australian model to incorporate internal banking data, enhancing its predictive power.

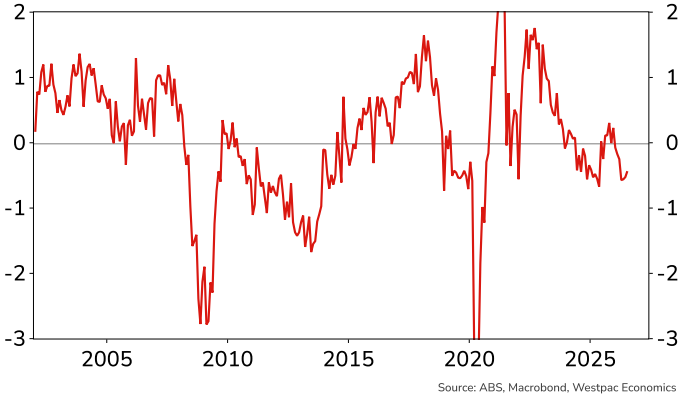
This note provides the first estimate of GDP growth for the September quarter 2026, using domestic and international data released up to and including the August Labour Force Survey (released 24 September 2026). Future updates will be published monthly (see Appendix A for the release schedule).

Westpac Monthly Activity Index: Activity improves as momentum builds

After weakening sharply through late 2025 and early 2026, the Westpac Monthly Activity Index is beginning to recover. While activity levels remain subdued, recent readings suggest the economy has moved beyond the period of broad-based deterioration seen earlier in the year. On a rolling three-month basis, the Index has continued to improve, consistent with improving momentum.

Westpac Monthly Activity Index

Index. Axis truncated for covid.



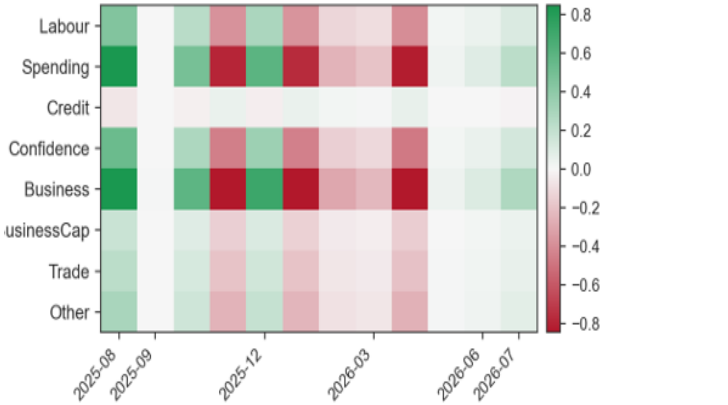
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

The weakness through late 2025 and early 2026 reflected a broad-based deterioration across confidence, spending, business activity and labour market indicators as households and businesses adjusted to a renewed inflation challenge followed by interest rates moving higher once again. More recent data suggest these conditions have begun to stabilise and, in some cases, improve. Business and consumer confidence, household spending, and labour market indicators have generally proven more resilient than expected given the headwinds facing the economy.

This improvement is evident in our heatmap, where the intensity and breadth of negative readings have moderated noticeably. While pockets of softness remain, particularly in interest-sensitive areas of the economy, fewer indicators are showing deteriorating momentum and a growing number are now contributing positively to activity. Business-related indicators remain among the strongest contributors, consistent with the substantial support currently being provided by investment in data centres, renewable energy and related infrastructure.

Our indicator heatmap decomposes changes in the Monthly Activity Index into group-level contributions, allowing us to assess which components are driving movements in activity. For ease of interpretation, indicators are grouped into broad categories (see the Appendix for further details). For example, the labour market category includes both official ABS Labour Force Survey outcomes and timelier survey-based measures of labour demand and job advertisements.

The Common Activity Factor Heatmap by Groups



Westpac-Now: Resilient growth amid rising headwinds

Recall that Westpac-Now is a refined indicator that combines our Monthly Activity Index with advanced econometric techniques to estimate GDP growth. As previously noted, the fit is not expected to be exact. Measured GDP includes components that are not well captured by high-frequency activity indicators, such as imputed rents for owner-occupiers, housing related ownership transfer costs, public and business inventories, and depreciation.

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To bridge monthly and quarterly data, we use a MIDAS framework, allowing us to combine mixed-frequency inputs and incorporate partial information for the current quarter when producing GDP forecasts.

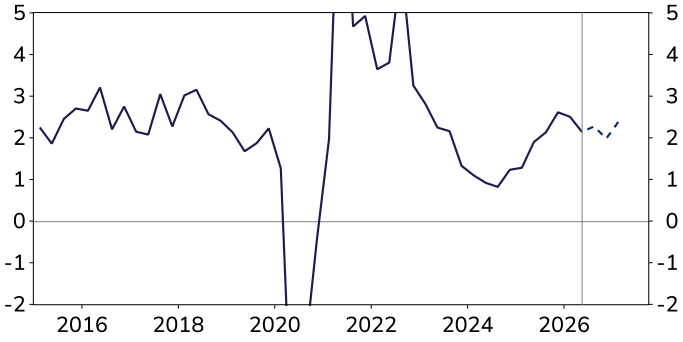
Based on current model estimates, Westpac-Now's final estimate for Q2 2026 points to GDP growth of 0.6%qtr (with a 70% confidence interval of 0.29%qtr to 0.91%qtr) and 2.3%yr, representing a step up from the 0.4%qtr and 2.1%yr outcomes recorded in Q2 2026. This suggests that economic momentum has strengthened, with the economy continuing to show resilience.

The key question going forward is whether higher interest rates, elevated energy prices and heightened geopolitical uncertainty in the Middle East will begin to weigh more heavily on demand, offsetting the substantial support currently being provided by business investment. Our forecasts suggest that growth will moderate, particularly following the RBA Board's September rate hike, with activity slowing rather than stalling.

Looking ahead, model dynamics suggest growth will pick up towards trend, at around 0.6%qtr in Q4 2026 and Q1 2027. However, these projections remain much more tentative, given their reliance on projected inputs rather than realised data. In addition, heightened uncertainty, particularly around the lingering impacts of the Middle East conflict, means risks around these forward estimates are larger than usual.

Westpac-Now Estimates and Projections*

Year-ended % growth. Axis truncated for covid.



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

*Dotted line show Westpac-Now central estimates. Quarter ahead (or Q3 2026) relies on actual Westpac-MAI to July 2026. Beyond the quarter ahead, estimates rely on projections of the Westpac-MAI generated using internal model dynamics.

September Quarter data: Momentum improving

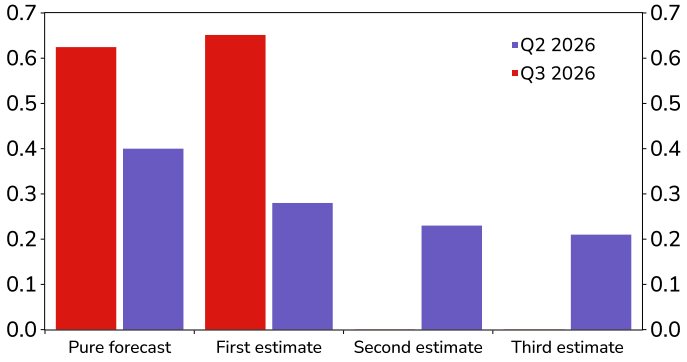
Data released in the first month of the September quarter indicates that the economy has picked up momentum relative to the previous quarter, with our nowcast estimating Q3 growth at 0.6%qtr, in line with the 0.6%qtr "pure forecast" based solely on data available up to June 2026.

This is similar to what occurred in Q2 2026. Following the large downside surprise in April 2026, which coincided with sharp falls in consumer and business confidence, growth estimates stabilised over the remainder of the quarter. The weakness in Q2 was concentrated in April, with subsequent data pointing to stabilisation rather than further deterioration.

Early Q3 data point to a similar pattern, with activity showing signs of resilience despite headwinds.

Evolution of Westpac-Now

Within-quarter changes to Westpac-Now, quarterly % change



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Note that monthly activity estimates are more uncertain than normal when inflation is shifting. Faster price growth can cause nominal indicators, such as consumer spending, to rise more strongly even though 'real', inflation-adjusted spending may be softening (and vice versa). The inclusion of 'real' indicators, such as employment and banking transaction volumes, helps mitigate some – but not all – of this uncertainty.

Bottom line:

Westpac-Now points to GDP growth of around 0.6%qtr in Q3 2026 (2.3%yr), indicating that the economy remains more resilient than previously feared. Strong business investment, particularly in data centres and renewable energy, continues to provide an important offset to soft demand in interest-sensitive sectors of the economy, including the housing market.

Looking ahead, higher interest rates, elevated energy prices and ongoing geopolitical uncertainty are expected to weigh on activity, particularly following the RBA's September rate hike. However, our central case remains one of slower growth rather than a material downturn.

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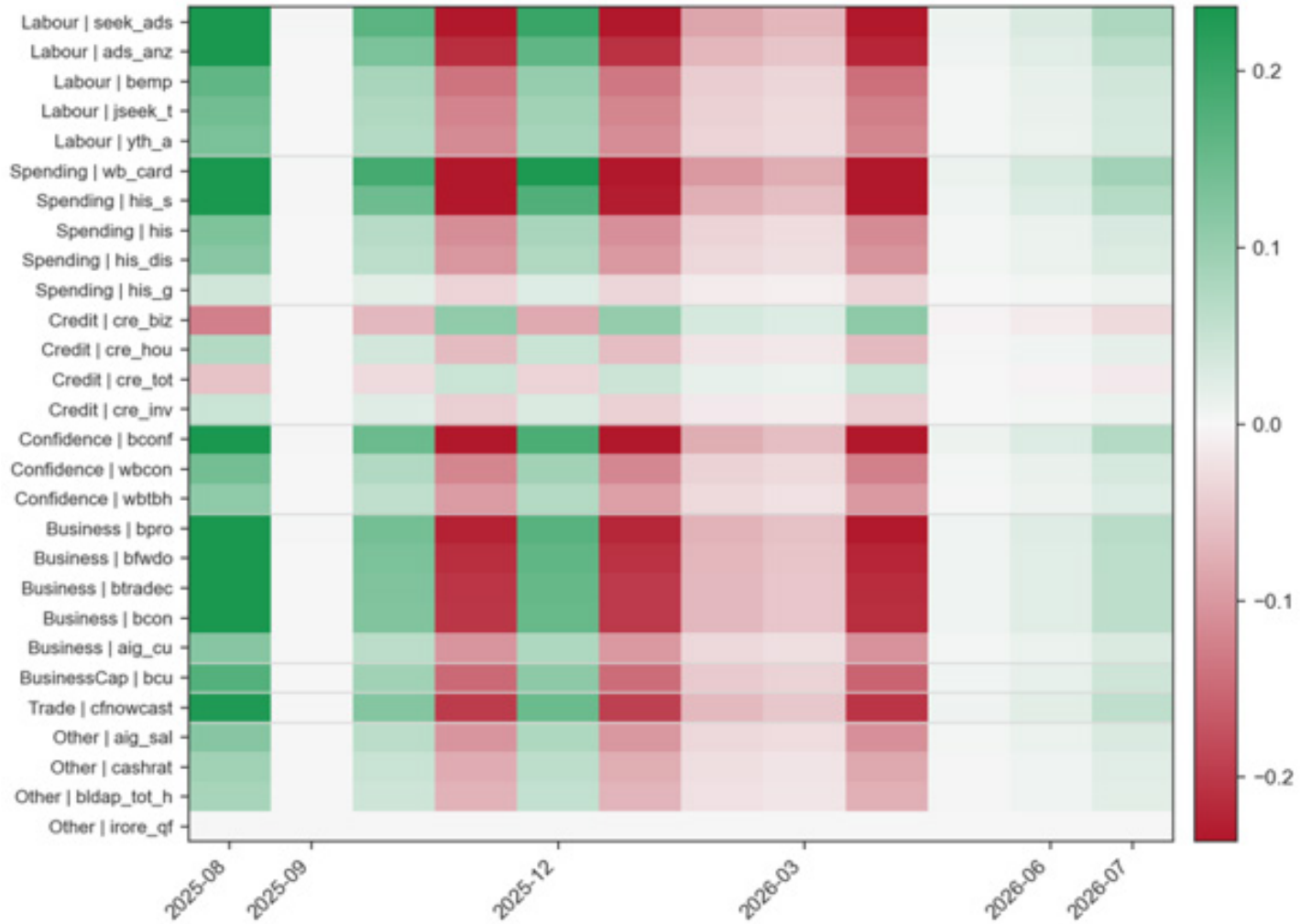
Appendix A: Westpac-Now Release Schedule (2026)

Going forward, Westpac Now will be published on the Friday following each ABS Labour Force Survey (LFS) release, at 11:30am AEDT/AEST (Canberra time). Each release incorporates the latest labour market data alongside other high frequency indicators and provides an updated nowcast for quarterly GDP growth. As the quarter progresses, each update should be interpreted as a progressively more complete estimate of that quarter's economic performance.

Release date (Friday)	LFS reference month	Quarter focus	Interpretation
16 October 2026	September 2026	Q3 2026 – second estimate	Refined Q3 signal as activity data accumulate
20 November 2026	October 2026	Q3 2026 – final estimate	Near complete read on Q3 activity
18 December 2026	November 2026	Q4 2026 – first estimate	Initial assessment of Q4 momentum

Appendix B: The common activity factor heatmap by indicators



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USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
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180 day BBSY	5.21	0.00
1 year swap	4.91	0.00
2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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2 year swap	4.93	0.02
3 year swap	4.94	0.04
4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

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10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
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Time	Event	Exp	Prev
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12 October 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Risk sentiment improved after President Trump noted the US would avoid military action against Iran before the midterm elections, helping markets recover from a volatile week.

Global equities advanced, with US stocks rebounding from the prior session's technology-led sell-off and European markets outperforming.

US Treasury yields were little changed, with European bond yields ending the week lower. The US Treasury market will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day.

Investor focus has shifted to upcoming US inflation data and Fed commentary, shaping expectations for the FOMC's October meeting.

Commodity prices generally advanced, with oil remaining sensitive to geopolitical developments even as plans for additional Russian diesel supply offered some prospect of relief for global fuel markets.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	64.8	0.2%
AUD/USD	0.6978	0.3%
AUD/JPY	110.46	0.6%
AUD/GBP	0.5272	0.2%
AUD/NZD	1.2427	0.1%
AUD/EUR	0.6237	0.5%
AUD/CNH	4.6705	0.1%
AUD/SGD	0.8931	0.2%
AUD/HKD	5.4762	0.3%
AUD/CAD	0.9957	0.6%
EUR/USD	1.1189	-0.2%
USD/JPY	158.26	0.2%
USD Index	102.21	0.1%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.61	0.00
90 day BBSY	4.82	0.00
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In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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Cliff Notes: mulling the minutes

#cliffnotes #rba #australia #inflation #us #fomc #ecb #aud #usd

By Sian Fenner, Ryan Wells & Illiana Jain

11:10 October 09 2026

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Key insights from the week that was.

The only data release of note in Australia this week was the October Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment Survey, which reported a 4.7% drop in the headline index. At 80.4, sentiment has tumbled back to deeply pessimistic levels, similar to the post-pandemic cost-of-living shock when readings were among the weakest in the survey's more than fifty-year history. Indeed, inflation and interest rate pressures are once again clearly front of mind for consumers, with both the view on 'family finances vs a year ago'

and ‘family finance next 12 months’ falling 8.0% and 6.4% in the month, respectively. Moreover, the RBA’s September rate hike looks to have had a significant impact – sentiment tanked 20% between those surveyed before the RBA decision and those surveyed afterwards.

Views on the economic outlook were relatively more resilient, but they still weakened, with the one-year and five-year ahead sub-indexes falling 1.6% and 0.4% respectively. Consumers are becoming more ‘on edge’ about job security, albeit not outright alarmed. The unemployment rate remains relatively low versus history, although it has drifted up to a cycle high of 4.6% as labour supply continues to outstrip demand. We expect it to hold there in next week’s September Labour Force Survey – see our preview for more detail. All told, with higher interest rates, renewed inflation pressures and a softening jobs market all weighing at once, households are entering the final months of the year on the back foot.

Offshore, the focus was on US data.

Before turning to this week's releases, it is worth noting that September non-farm payrolls came in softer than expected across most metrics. Employment rose by only 29k (89k expected), and there were sizeable downward revisions to prior months, with a combined 60k removed from July and August payrolls, leaving gains of just 31k and 29k respectively. The details pointed to weaker hiring in leisure & hospitality and education & health services industries, although construction and manufacturing employment continued to benefit from ongoing data-centre-related investment. The unemployment rate edged up to 4.2%, with softer employment occurring alongside a rise in labour force participation to 61.8%. Meanwhile wage growth moderated to 0.1%mth (3.0%yr). Taken together, the report suggests labour demand is cooling, with the three-month average pace of job creation slowing to around 50k. However, softer payroll gains are not necessarily indicative of labour market deterioration. Lower immigration and ageing demographics have reduced the pace of employment growth needed to keep the unemployment rate stable. As such, the report is more consistent with a labour market that is gradually normalising than one entering a meaningful downturn.

The September FOMC minutes reinforced a distinctly hawkish message, with participants noting they had "not seen sufficient progress on lowering inflation in recent months" and expressing concern that inflation risks remained "skewed to the upside". Policymakers highlighted that both core services and core goods inflation remained elevated, with some attributing persistent goods price strength to the effects of the AI buildout despite the sector's traditional disinflationary role. There was also concern that, after more than five years of inflation above target, elevated inflation could begin to influence inflation expectations and wage- and price-setting behaviour. In contrast, labour market conditions were generally viewed as stable and "close to maximum employment". While a majority noted the labour market had strengthened somewhat recently, several participants highlighted unusually low dynamism, characterised by low hiring, low layoffs, a low job-finding rate and elevated long-term unemployment. Importantly, participants generally judged that aggregate wage growth was moderate and "consistent with inflation moving toward 2 percent", with several explicitly noting that "the labor market was not currently a source of inflationary pressures".

A key focus was the interaction between AI investment, productive capacity and inflation. While participants broadly expected AI-related investment to boost productivity growth and potential output over time, several warned that "the AI buildout could cause aggregate demand to outpace aggregate supply over the medium term, putting upward pressure on inflation". Consistent with this view, some participants had raised their estimate of the neutral policy rate and several judged the current policy stance to be "not restrictive or only mildly restrictive". Against this backdrop, all participants supported the September rate increase, and most assessed that another increase in the federal funds rate would likely be appropriate by year-end, although future decisions would remain data dependent.

The September ISM Services PMI released this week painted a similar picture of an economy that remains resilient but is gradually losing momentum. The headline index eased to 54.9 from 55.4 in August, with the decline driven by a sharp fall in business activity and a 9.4pt drop in new export orders, which slipped into contractionary territory for the first time in eight months. Labour market conditions improved modestly with the employment index moving to broadly neutral territory 50.1 after two months below 50, supported by elevated backlogs and still-solid demand. Respondent commentary illustrated the mixed nature of labour demand, with some firms reporting they were "filling positions vacated due to promotions or retirements", while others cited "restructuring due to efficiencies gained using AI tools". Cost pressures also remained elevated, with the prices paid index rising to 74.0, its highest level since July 2022 and around 18pts above its historical average, while fuel costs, tariffs and supply chain constraints remained the most frequently cited concerns. Overall, the report suggests services activity remains consistent with ongoing expansion, albeit at a slower pace, while labour demand and pricing pressures remain firm.

Overall, the data supports our view that the FOMC will move to a broadly neutral policy stance by the end of the year with one more rate hike, although the case for a back-to-back move in October has become less clear cut.

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FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
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4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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4 year swap	4.96	0.02
5 year swap	4.99	0.02
6 year swap	5.04	0.02
7 year swap	5.10	0.01
8 year swap	5.15	0.00
9 year swap	5.19	0.00
10 year swap	5.24	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	8,717	0.6%
S&P 500	7,812	0.6%
Japan Nikkei	69,031	0.0%
Hang Seng	24,211	1.8%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,173	0.8%
UK FTSE100	10,552	1.1%
VIX Index	14.84	-3.7%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.90	0.00
10 year bond	5.34	-0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.05	0.01
2 year bond	4.79	0.03
10 year bond	5.24	0.01
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.48	-0.01
Japan	3.02	-0.08
UK	5.44	-0.04

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	414.73	0.7%
Gold	4194.24	1.5%
Copper	14540	1.6%
Oil (WTI futures)	91.85	0.4%
Coal (coking)	270.00	1.1%
Coal (thermal)	152.25	-0.3%
Iron Ore	91.35	-0.7%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.36	0.01
3 yr bond	4.93	0.02
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	8,786	0.4%

Data as at 7:00am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

Markets regained some footing to close off the week after President Trump said the US would not strike Iran before next month's midterm elections, supporting risk sentiment and helping equities recover. However, tensions flared again over the weekend, with an attack on Saudi Arabia's main airport and a US strike on a commercial tanker in the Gulf of Oman. On Friday, President Trump also announced that Russia would supply 13.5 million barrels of diesel to global markets through October to help ease fuel shortages and lower prices, a move that would mark a significant departure from years of sanctions despite the ongoing war in Ukraine. US bond markets will be closed on Monday for Columbus Day, although equity markets remain open.

- US equities closed higher on Friday, capping a volatile week that saw sharp moves in both bond yields and energy markets. The S&P 500 rose 0.6%, although it remained below the record high reached earlier in the week. The Dow Jones gained 0.8%, while the Nasdaq also advanced 0.8%, rebounding from Thursday's tech-led sell-off amid concerns over the pace of AI-related growth. European equities outperformed as volatility in regional bond markets eased, with the Euro Stoxx 50 rising 0.8% and the FTSE 100 up 1.1%.
- Asian equities delivered a mixed performance on Friday. The Nikkei 225 closed flat, recovering from an intraday decline of 1.3% after reports that OpenAI's revenue targets may indeed be reached. The CSI 300 was up 0.2%, while the Hang Seng rose 1.8%, supported by gains in technology stocks. The ASX 200 advanced 0.6%, with futures pointing to a further gain at today's open. South Korea's Kospi was closed for Hangul Day.
- US Treasury yields were little changed as investors digested President Trump's pledge not to take military action against Iran until after the midterm elections. The 2-year and 10-year Treasury rose 3bps and 1bp respectively, with the latter holding at 5.24%, below the 24-year high reached earlier in the week. Attention now turns to the September CPI report, due Wednesday night (11:30pm AEDT), and comments from Fed Chair Warsh, both of which are expected to shape market expectations ahead of the FOMC's October meeting. Futures currently assign a 17% probability to an October rate hike and have almost fully priced in a hike by December, leaving the implied year-end policy rate at 4.13%.
- European bonds ended lower after a volatile week. The 10-year bund yield fell 1bp, while the 10-year gilts declined 4bps. France's 10-year OAT yield also dropped 4bps, although concerns over the government's ability to reduce the budget deficit to 5% of GDP by 2027 continue to weigh on sentiment.

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
-	CN M2 Money Supply Sep	7.4%	7.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

- In Australia, the 3-year government bond yield was unchanged at 4.90%, while the 10-year yield fell 6bps to 5.34%. Attention this week will centre on the September Labour Force Survey, due Thursday, where a moderation in the participation rate from its near 115-year high is expected to keep the unemployment rate broadly steady (see our preview). Swap markets continue to assign only a modest probability to further policy tightening, with around 26% odds of a November rate hike currently priced.
- The US dollar index rose modestly, gaining 0.1%. The AUD rose against the greenback, up 0.3% to 0.6978. Other crosses against the USD were mixed, with the yen up 0.2%, euro losing 0.2% and the pound flat.
- Commodities were mostly higher. Oil prices recovered from early losses, with Brent crude rising 0.4% to US$104.7/bbl and WTI also gaining 0.4%. Elsewhere, gold advanced 1.5% and copper rose 1.6%, while iron ore bucked the trend, falling 0.7% amid a subdued outlook for demand.

International Data

In the US, the **University of Michigan consumer sentiment** deteriorated marginally in the preliminary October print, the headline index declining from 48.1 to 46.3. Current conditions fell from 50.9 to 44.7 while expectations edged up to 47.3. Historically low sentiment is yet to stop consumers from spending though, with real consumption growth remaining robust through 2026.

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August CPI – Came in on our expectations

#inflation #australia #rba #economicbulletinsaustralia #inflation

By Justin Smirk & Neha Sharma

15:27 September 30 2026

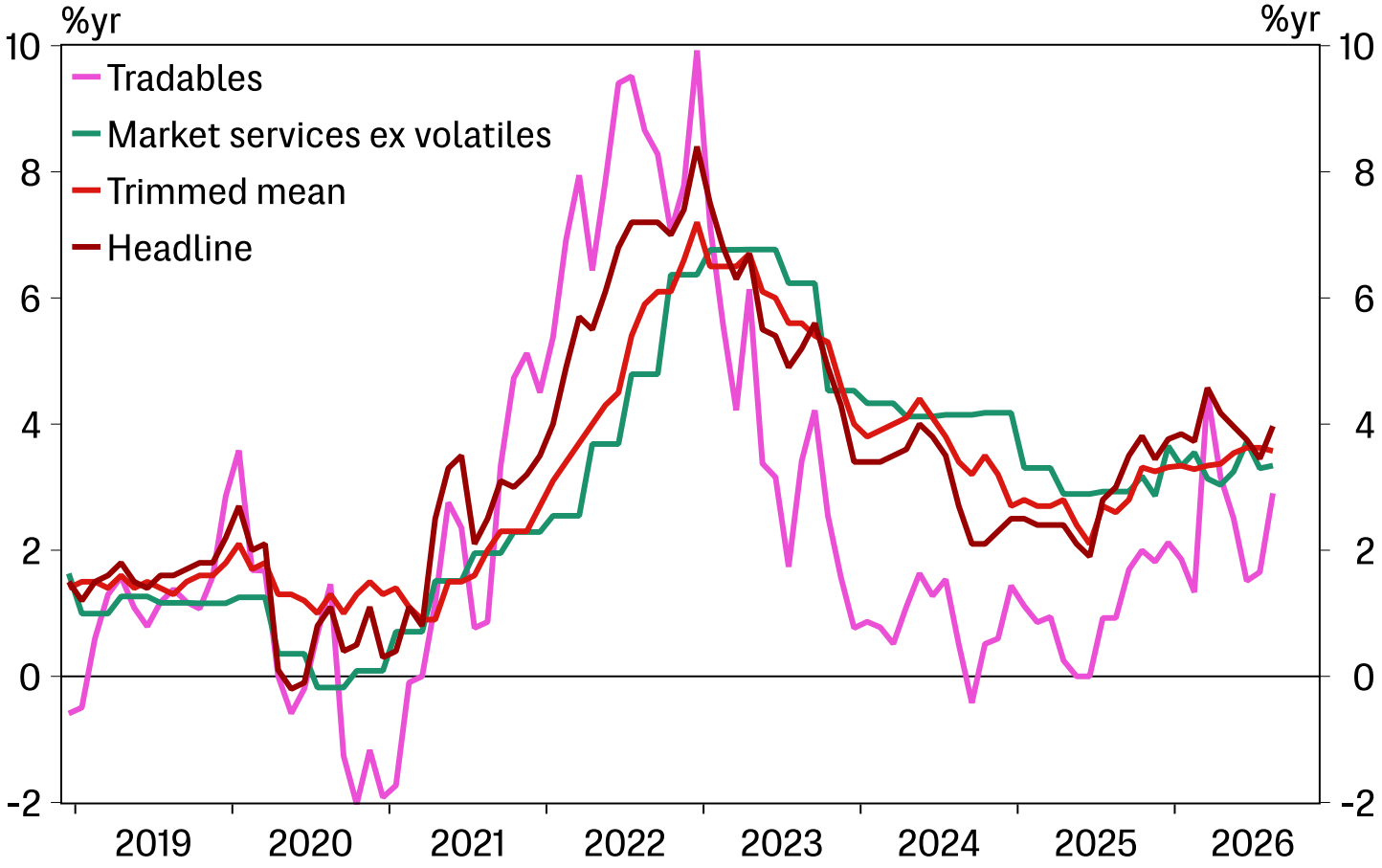
Share

August Monthly CPI: Headline 0.4%mth/4.0%yr, Trimmed Mean 0.2%mth/3.6%yr. Market services ex volatile –0.4%mth/3.3%yr.

- The CPI rose 0.4% in August, spot on Westpac's expectation but a bit softer than market expectations of 0.5%. Due to base effects the annual pace picked up to 4.0%yr from 3.5%yr.

- Key factors driving the headline result were auto fuels (14.8%); games, toys & hobbies (10.2%) with rents providing a solid base (0.3%) while some offset was provided by both domestic (–4.9%) and international holiday travel & accommodation (–1.5%).
- Trimmed mean (TM) inflation printed 0.2% again bang on Westpac's expectation while the market was slightly higher at 0.3%. The annual pace was flat at 3.6%yr, the third month in a row at this pace, while the six-month annualise pace was steady at 3.9%yr.
- Key factors driving the TM print were: rents (0.3%) and new dwelling purchases (0.2%). The TM distribution ranged from –0.38% to 0.82%.
- Today's inflation update revealed price discounting for some durable goods as retail demand softens. We would expect to see a bounce from these categories in the following month. There was also offsetting strength elsewhere in durable good so at least for now, the momentum continues to suggest some near term upside risk to our current inflation estimates.
- Nevertheless, as the TM came in on expectations and based on a first quick pass at updating the quarterly profile, we see little pressure to revise our current Q3 estimates of 1.3%qtr for the CPI and 0.9%qtr for the TM.
- The RBA remains alert to near term inflationary risks. We are expecting the momentum in TM inflation to remain well above the top of the target band through to year-end underpinning our expectations for the RBA to raise rates again in November.

Monthly inflation

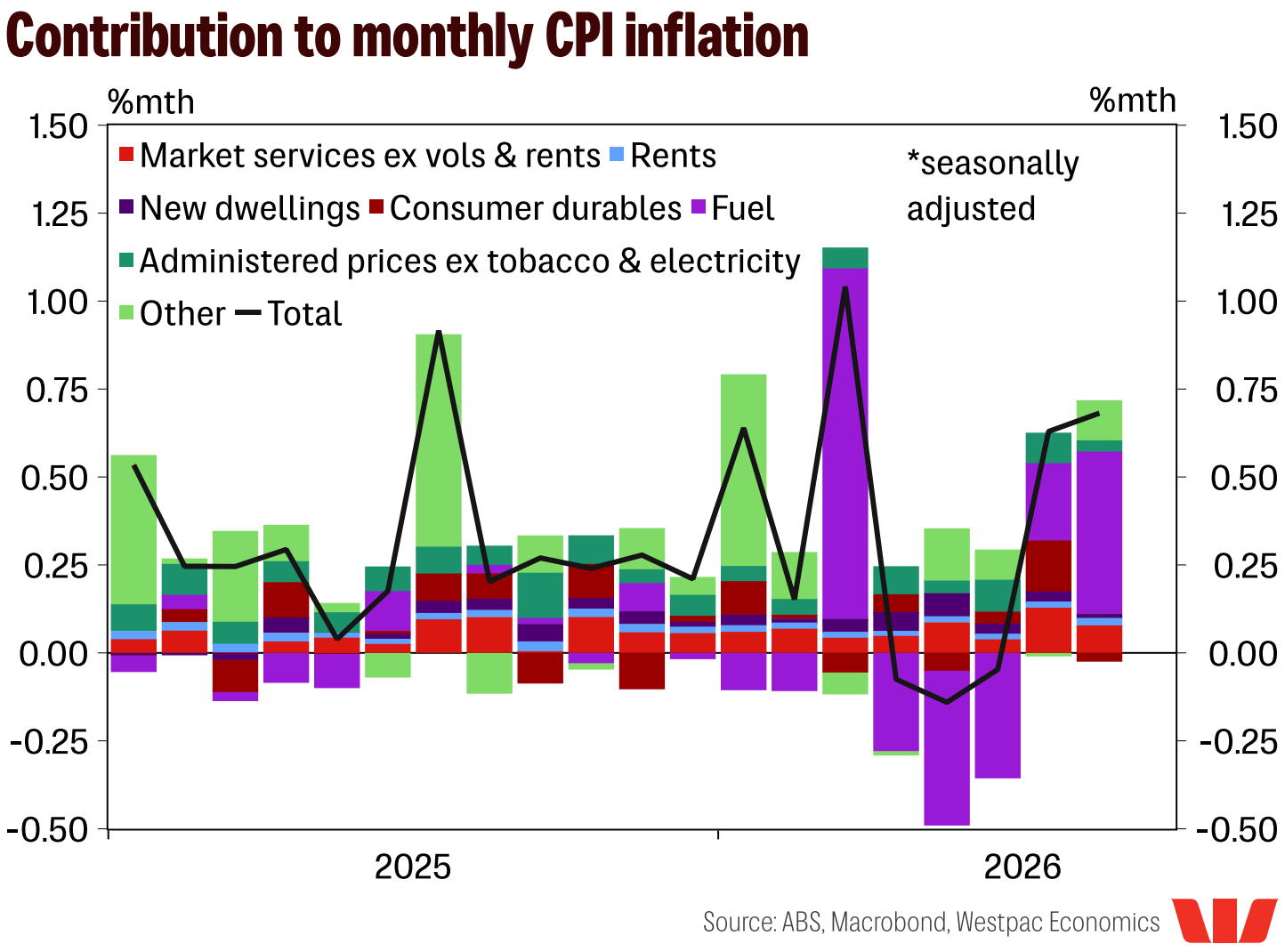


Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

August CPI in more detail

Following the bumper read in July, the monthly CPI moderated in August rising 0.4%mth. This was in line with our expectations and slightly softer than the market consensus. This took the year-ended pace to 4.0%yr. On a seasonally adjusted basis the CPI rose 0.7%mth highlighting the impact of seasonal sales in August.

They key drivers behind the monthly lift were automotive fuel, up 14.8%mth, contributing 0.5ppts to the headline figure. The surge resulted from the ending of the fuel excise discount on August 3 and rising global energy prices. With crude oil prices still elevated due to the conflict in the middle east, and growing shortages of refined products due to both the middle east conflict and Ukrainian assaults on Russian refining capacity, auto fuel is expected to remain an inflationary impulse at least until the end of 2026.



The monthly TM also softened, rising 0.2%mth compared to the 0.5%mth read from July. The result was again in line with our expectations, and very close at two decimal places (0.24%mth vs 0.23%mth), but softer than the market's view. The year-ended pace held at 3.6%yr for the third consecutive month, although it continued to ease marginally at the second decimal place. In contrast, the six-month annualised pace has continued to trend higher since April and is currently running at 3.9%yr.

There is a possibility that as the ABS continues to grapple with seasonal adjustment issues we will see revisions to the TM estimates. Last July also saw a strong 0.48%mth read which eased to 0.29%mth in August. This is not too dissimilar from the 0.48%mth and 0.24%mth reads for 2026.

We are expecting core inflation to start to moderate as we get to year end but our current estimate for the month of December still has the TM running at a 3.3% in the year while the six-month annualised pace is still a chunky 3.1%. Applying a trim on the seasonally adjusted 3m/3m expenditure classes yields a TM of 0.9%qtr currently. This is in line with our current Q3 TM estimate.

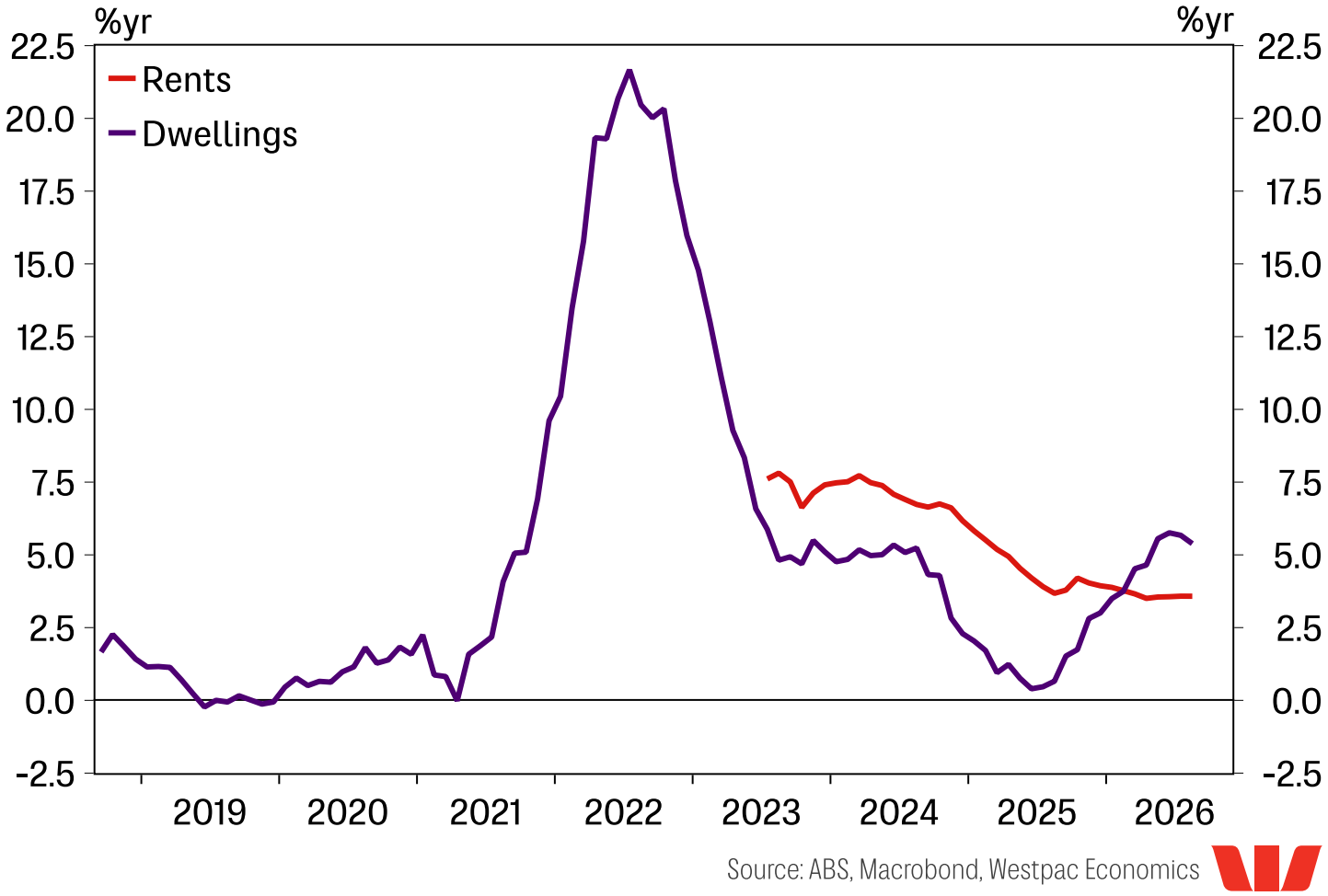
Other measures of underlying inflation told a similar story, easing on a monthly basis but holding steady on a year-ended basis. Market services ex volatiles fell –0.4%mth to be 3.3%yr higher. Excluding both volatiles & holidays saw a 0.2%mth/4.1%yr lift.

Most market services components eased in the month (including on a seasonally adjusted basis) but annual growth across this group as a whole remained above the RBA's 2-3% target band. The near-term momentum (three-month annualised) is also quite strong across several components of services. Of note include deposit and loan facilities (11.2%mth), sports participation (10.9%), clothing repair (7.0%), restaurant meals (6.8%) and other household services (5.2%). We are closely watching market services as this is where inflationary risks, outside of energy, appear to be most persistent.

Due to its sizable weight in the CPI, and the fact price changes here tend to be less volatile than many other categories, so they almost always appear in the TM estimates, housing prices remain a key focus. Rents rose 0.3%mth in August, in line with our expectations, to be up 3.6%yr. Since April, the seasonally adjusted rents series has been running lower than the non-seasonally adjusted series. We are expecting rents to hold around this pace till year end before moderating modestly as we move through 2027.

New dwellings inflation was 0.2%mth in August (softer than our expectation for a 0.4%mth rise). Since peaking in May, monthly price growth has slowed in each successive month, potentially reflecting increasing difficulty for developers in passing through higher costs amid softer conditions in established housing markets and weaker demand in the face of higher interest rates. The annual pace looks to have topped out. It was at 5.8%yr in June easing to 5.4%yr currently with the three-month annualised pace at 3.7%. We expect dwelling price inflation to continue easing through to the end of 2027 as falling established house prices limit the ability of builders to pass on rising construction costs. There is a medium-term risk that as conditions improve builders may raise prices more aggressively to claw back margins.

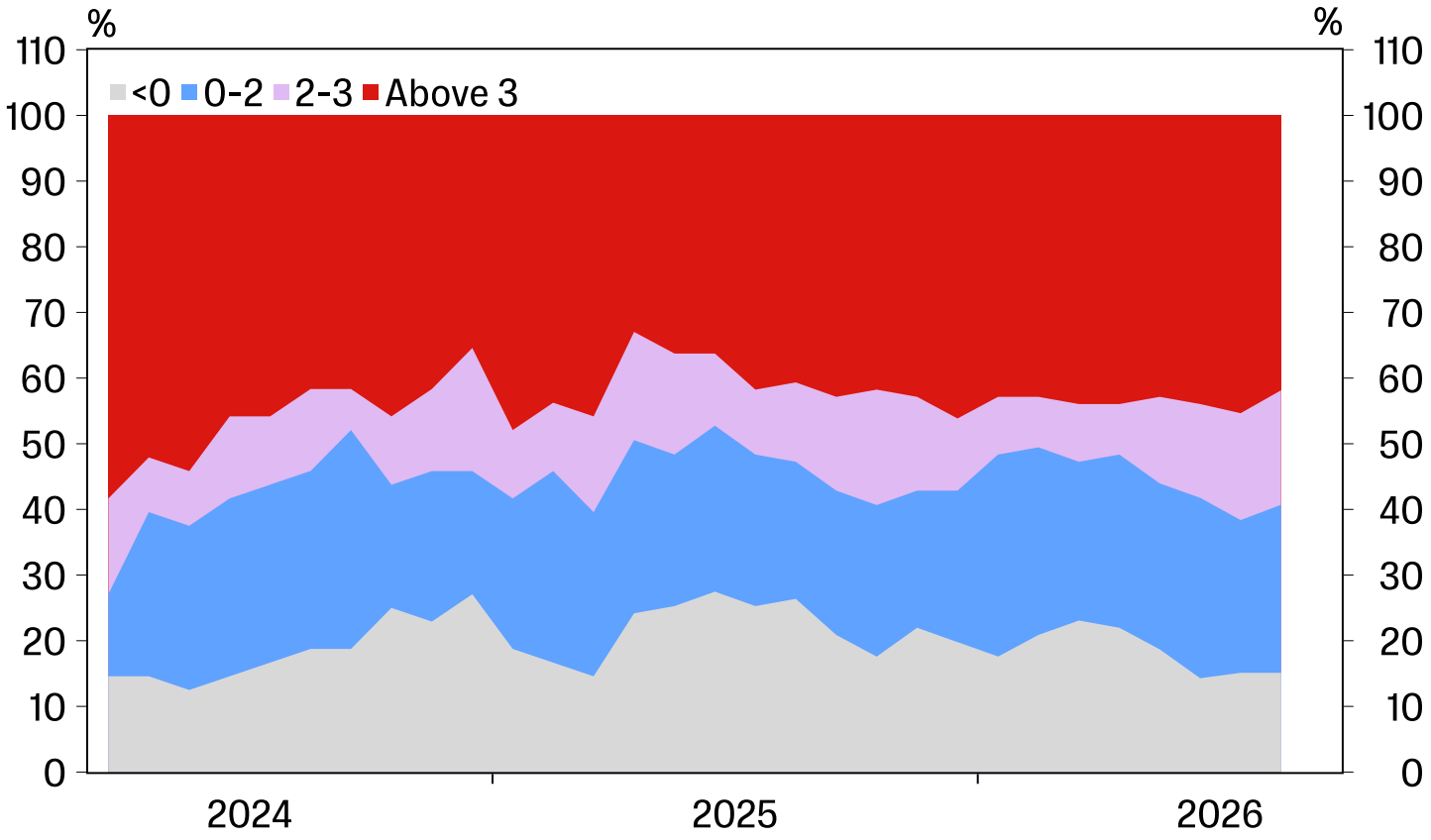
Housing inflation – rents and dwellings



Overall, the breadth of inflation moderated in August. The share of the basket running above 3%yr eased from 45% to 42%, with the share below 2%yr increasing from 38% to 41%.

Inflation Sub-Categories

Year-ended, Share of Basket



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Key surprises in the month:

Upside surprises

- Insurance surprised to the upside (0.7%mth vs 0.3%mth) after a run of weaker-than-usual reads over the past two months.
- Motor vehicle repair costs rose a solid 0.8% against our 0.3%mth expectations, with spare parts and accessories also up 0.3%mth vs –0.4%mth.
- Footwear rose 1.7%mth against our expectations for a -2.9%mth decline, the gains were broad-based across women, men & children.
- Household goods surprised to the upside. Household appliances, utensils and tools rose 1.9%mth against our flat expectations, meanwhile household textiles fell –1.0%mth against our expectations for a –5.0%mth fall. Furniture and furnishings also fell by less than expected –0.6%mth vs –1.3%mth.
- Recreation and culture surprised to the upside (–1.0%mth vs –1.5%mth), owing to a 1.4%mth lift in other recreation, sport & culture against our expectations for a flat read on the back of an outsized gain in games, toys & hobbies (10.2%mth vs 2.5%mth). Holiday travel was marginally less weak than expected (–3.3% vs –3.5%mth).

Downside surprises

- Food was the key downside miss falling –0.1%mth against our expectations for a 0.2%mth lift. Meat & seafood (–0.9%mth vs 0.5%mth) and fruit & vegetables (–1.2%mth vs 0.1%mth) were the key areas of weakness.
- Audio, visual and computing equipment and services came in weaker-than-expected (0.7%mth vs 1.2%mth), owing to a softer 0.6%mth lift in computing services (3.0%mth expected). This was partly balanced by a stronger than expected lift in computing equipment (0.9%mth vs –0.5%mth). The latter is where we are most likely to see the impact of the AI boom in the CPI, due to computer chip inflation, other than construction cost inflation for new dwellings.
- Motor vehicles came in lower at –0.4%mth vs –0.1%mth which could be the start of price pressures associated with the rapid expansion of the share of Chinese cars in the Australian market. Automotive fuel was also slightly softer at 14.8%mth vs 16.7%mth.
- Garments and accessories were both softer. Garments fell –1.9%mth against our expectations for a 0.2%mth rise, meanwhile accessories came in at 0.1%mth vs 0.5%mth expected.

CPI Item	Qtr CPI Jun-26 % qtr	Monthly CPI Jun-26 % mth	Monthly CPI Jul-26 % mth	Monthly CPI Aug-26 % mth	WBC fcs Aug-26 % mth
Food	1.0	0.4	0.3	-0.1	0.2
of which, bread & cereals	0.0	0.7	-0.3	0.0	0.4
of which, meat & seafood	0.8	-0.3	0.2	-0.9	0.5
of which, dairy & related products	2.1	1.3	0.2	-0.1	0.3
of which, fruit & vegetables	3.4	1.0	-0.8	-1.1	0.1
of which, food products nec	-0.7	-0.2	0.0	0.3	0.4
of which, non-alcohol beverages	1.6	1.0	0.0	0.3	-0.4
Alcohol & tobacco	0.5	-0.5	1.2	0.5	0.1
of which, Alcohol	0.1	-0.7	1.2	0.5	0.2
of which, Tobacco	1.5	0.0	1.2	0.5	0.0
Clothing & footwear	1.1	-1.0	2.6	-0.9	-0.1
of which, garments	0.7	-3.1	3.2	-1.9	0.2
Housing	0.9	0.5	0.4	0.2	0.3
of which, Rents	0.8	0.3	0.4	0.3	0.3
of which, House purchases	1.8	0.4	0.4	0.2	0.4
of which, Electricity	0.3	0.7	-1.6	0.0	-0.7
of which, Gas & other fuels	-1.9	2.7	2.8	0.0	2.6
H/hold contents & services	0.1	-4.2	4.4	0.2	0.0
Health	2.2	-0.1	0.1	0.1	0.0
Transportation	-0.7	-2.7	2.6	4.2	4.5
of which, auto fuel	-2.1	-10.9	7.5	14.8	16.6
Communication	0.6	-0.7	1.8	-0.2	0.0
Recreation	-0.4	1.8	1.8	-1.0	-1.5
of which, holiday travel	-1.0	4.6	1.8	-3.3	-3.5
Education	1.5	0.0	0.0	0.1	0.1
Financial & insurance services	0.9	0.5	0.2	0.2	0.1
CPI: All groups %qtr/%mth	**0.6**	**-0.1**	**1.0**	**0.4**	**0.4**
Trimmed Mean: %qtr/%mth	**0.8**	**0.3**	**0.5**	**0.2**	**0.2**

What does this mean for the RBA?

Yesterday, post the RBA rate hike and monetary policy decision statement, Westpac changed its view from a November follow up rate hike being a risk to being the base case. The post-meeting statement was notable for its emphasis on the Middle East conflict, noting that “global energy prices are now much higher than had been assumed in the August forecasts”. In addition, RBA’s liaison suggests firms are passing this on or planning to do so. The pass-through was characterised as partial, and additional to domestically driven inflation arising from capacity pressures. We read this as implying that the RBA is concerned about upside risks to underlying inflation in Q4 of this year, as well as Q3.

Our current forecast of 0.9%qtr for the September quarter TM stands post today's release and represents a step up from 0.8% in the June quarter holding the annual pace at 3.6%yr. Our current forecast for the Q4 TM is 0.7%qtr/3.3%yr but given the move in energy prices, and anecdotes of firms now passing on those rising costs, we too see upside risks to this estimate.

As such, we hold to the view that the RBA will follow up with another rate hike in November. For more information on the RBA decision please see Luci Ellis's note "RBA hikes in September, November follow-up now expected".

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Cliff Notes: the importance of supply

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By Elliot Clarke, Ryan Wells & Illiana Jain

09:47 September 25 2026

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Key insights from the week that was.

Australia's only data release this week was the August Labour Force Survey. Employment surprised to the upside, rising 39.5k. But, once again, new labour demand was more than offset by supply as the participation rate bounced 0.2ppts higher to 67.1%, just shy of January 2025's 115-year high of 67.2%. As a result, the unemployment rate increased from 4.5% to 4.6% and was close to rounding up to 4.7% (4.65% to two decimal places).

There may be some residual seasonality in August's print related to the new survey collection model. However, the underlying trend is still consistent with a gradual easing in the labour market, seeing the unemployment rate drift higher. We expect this to continue through to the first half of 2027.

The strength in labour force participation also speaks to the broader issue of Australia's supply capacity. As discussed by Chief Economist Luci Ellis, the RBA's assumptions around participation, productivity and the NAIRU collectively skew towards a weak assessment of supply capacity. For participation in particular, the RBA's near-term assumptions are downbeat compared to recent demographic trends and also sit below Treasury's longer-term projections as set out in the 2026 IGR. As above, the August LFS emphasises that slack could emerge more quickly than the RBA's forecasts imply without an outright fall in employment.

Ahead of next week's RBA meeting and inflation data, our latest state-level analysis provides perspective on the persistence of underlying price pressures, particularly the importance of housing-related components. For a broader assessment of the fiscal backdrop and the implications for the states, our latest state fiscal update explores how the housing market correction and changes to NDIS funding arrangements are pressuring state finances.

Before turning to this week's events offshore, it is important to highlight that last Friday the Bank of Japan raised its policy rate by 25bp to 1.25%. Policymakers maintained a constructive assessment of the economy, pointing to resilient consumption, ongoing labour market tightness, and solid investment spending. More importantly, the Bank expressed growing confidence that inflation is increasingly being sustained by domestic wage and demand dynamics rather than imported cost shocks alone.

In our view, the emphasis placed on improving underlying inflation dynamics suggests policymakers are becoming increasingly comfortable that inflation is able to be sustained by domestic demand and wage growth. Normalisation is likely to remain gradual, but the Bank appears firmly on a path towards further tightening, with rates likely to reach 1.5% by mid-2027.

This week, market participants have focused on discussions between the US and China on trade, security and technology as President Xi visits Washington.

Preliminary discussions between US Treasury Secretary Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng ahead of President Xi's arrival in Washington were characterised by both sides as productive, and Treasury Secretary Bessent subsequently announced that discussions in Washington would leave trade negotiations for upcoming meetings between the two leaders in Shenzhen and Miami. To allow room for this deferral, the current trade truce will be extended until January 2027. President Trump subsequently outlined that discussions during President Xi's Washington visit would instead focus on security, technology and AI.

A more constructive tone was also seen between the US and Iran overnight, if press reports are accurate. According to Bloomberg and Reuters, sources suggest the US and Iran are again exploring a staged deal which would see Iran re-open the Strait of Hormuz and the US lift its blockade of Iranian ports. Negotiations are occurring on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly, with Qatari officials

mediating.

President Trump continues to show little interest in a deal before November’s mid-term elections, but the global economy is under increasing pressure as the price of Brent oil hovers between USD100 and USD110 while refining spreads add additional impetus to refined product prices. The mooted consideration of a potential US diesel export ban this week makes clear that the US is not immune from this pressure despite having significant domestic energy supply and refining capacity, relative to their own demand.

The consequences of the current energy supply shock and other disruptions the US have experienced over the past year remain front of mind for FOMC members. Those speaking this week such as NY and Cleveland Fed Presidents Williams and Hammack highlighted the risk to inflation expectations from a series of supply shocks when the economy is fully employed, and the likelihood of an additional hike(s) being required to rein in current inflation momentum and risks. Williams noted that expectations of another hike by year end are "reasonable" and that the FOMC have "a lot of work to do". Debt market’s concern remains acute, having now almost priced in four hikes over the coming year and taken the US 10-year above 5.00%, currently 5.20%.

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First Impressions: NZ household incomes, assets and savings update - June quarter 2026

#consumer #newzealand

By Satish Ranchhod
Senior Economist, Westpac NZ

10:24 October 08 2026

Share

New Zealand incomes and savings are rising, as is the value of households' financial assets. However, the value of housing assets remains flat.

Key takeouts from Stats NZ's latest update on household incomes, assets and savings (June quarter 2026)

- Overall household income levels are continuing to rise. Much of that is due to increases in entrepreneurial earnings (which is in part due to increased earnings in the agricultural sector). Wage and salary growth has been more limited but has picked up.
- Household savings levels have been rising for three years now, with another solid rise over the past three months.
- Overall household wealth levels have risen modestly. Although the value of households' financial assets is continuing to rise, housing assets have essentially shown no growth since late 2023.
- Household spending on interest costs rose just slightly in the June quarter. That's the first increase in two years. The easing in average borrowing costs seen over the past few years has come to a close with the RBNZ's hiking cycle now in train.

Household incomes

Disposable income levels in the economy grew by 5.2% in the year to June, down from 6.5% in the year to March

- Underpinning the rise in overall income levels have been continued increases in entrepreneurial earnings, which are up 12% over the past year. That will include stronger earnings in the agricultural sector, which has been boosted by the strength in commodity export prices. That lift in agricultural earnings has been reflected in stronger economic confidence and spending in many rural regions. We expect commodity export earnings will remain firm over the year ahead.
- In contrast, wage and salary earnings are up just 2.7% over the past year. That's up from 1.8% in the year to March, but it's a fairly muted rise, especially given the continued increases in the population and inflation of 4.1%.

Savings and wealth

Household savings have continued to rise, climbing by $2.5b over the past quarter.

- June's large increase in savings builds on the solid increases seen over the past three years.
- The savings rate in the June quarter was 3.7% of disposable incomes, down just slightly from last quarter.

Overall household wealth levels were up 1.9% over the past year. Under the surface, the make-up of household wealth continues to shift.

- The value of households' financial assets has continued to rise and is up 4.6% over the past year.
- However, the value of housing and land assets is down 0.9% over the past year, and it has remained essentially unchanged since late 2023. We expect housing market conditions will remain soft over the coming year, limiting increases in overall household wealth.

Interest costs

- Households' spending on interest costs rose just slightly in the June quarter, climbing by 0.3%.
- While that's a relatively small change, it is the first increase that we've seen in two years.

- Over the past few years, many borrowers saw their debt servicing costs fall as they rolled off earlier high mortgage rates and onto lower ones. That helped to support household spending.
- However, the easing in average borrowing cost has now ended. Recent months have seen mortgage rates pushing higher as the RBNZ has begun to hike the Official Cash Rate, with further hikes expected over the coming year.
- Looking ahead, we don't expect a significant increase in average household borrowing costs. However, we won't see the same support for spending that we did over the past few years.

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Q3 Job Vacancies: another step lower

#labour #labour #employment

By Neha Sharma
Economist, Westpac

13:07 October 01 2026

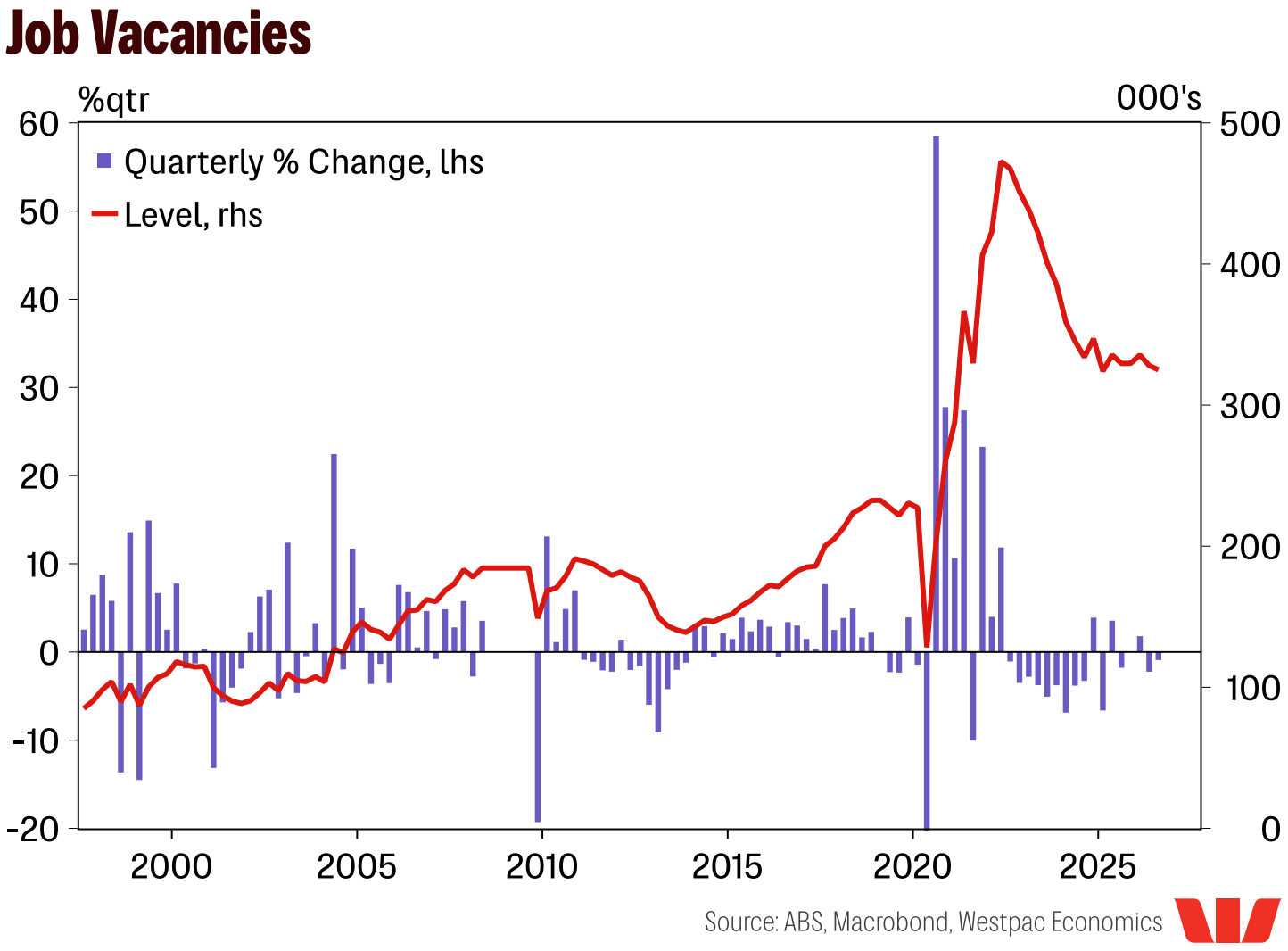
Share

The number of job vacancies fell by 3.0k (–0.9%qtr) between May and August. The decline was wholly driven by the private sector, where vacancies fell 2.0%qtr. In contrast, public sector vacancies rose 7.8%qtr.

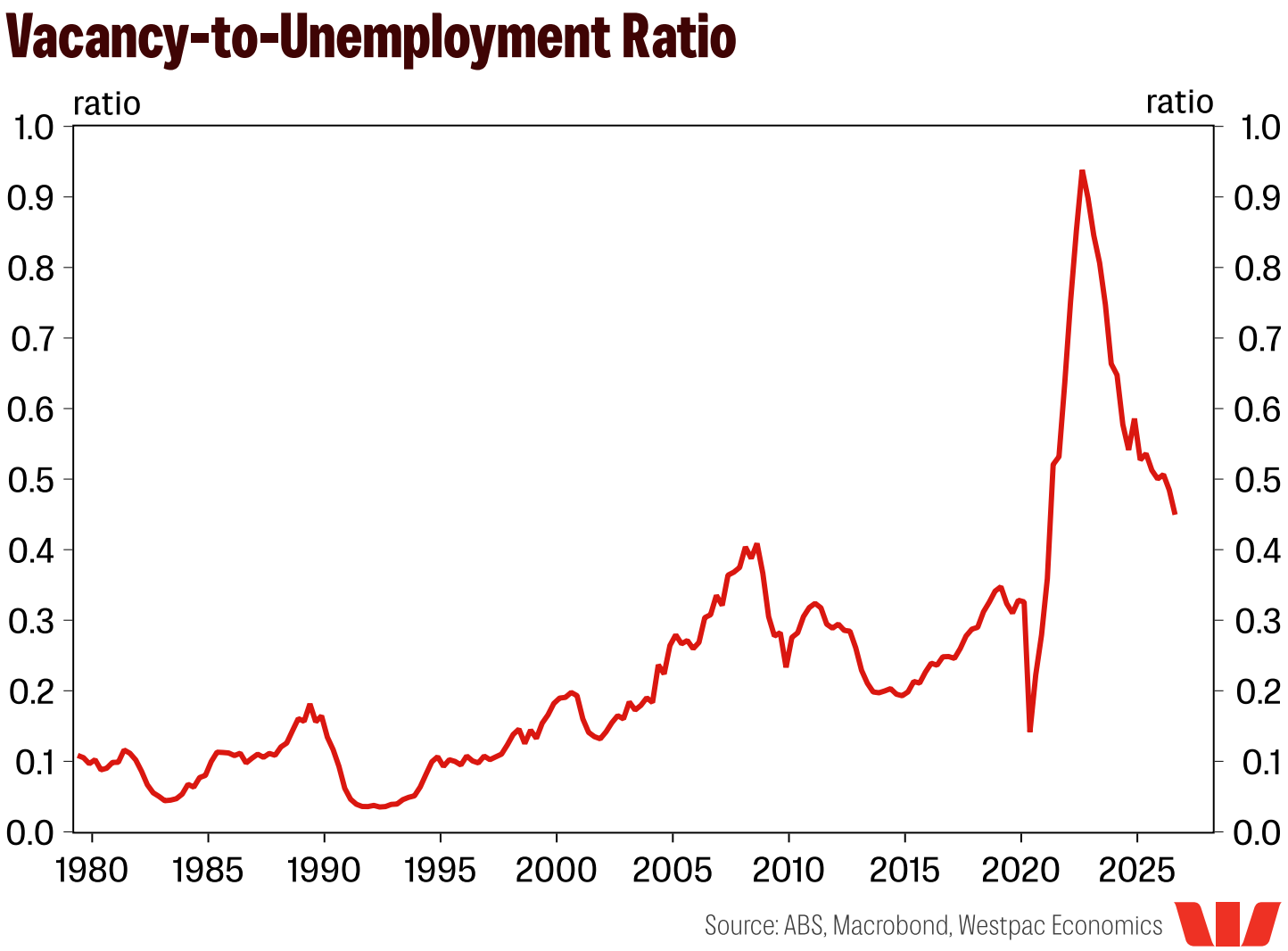
Job vacancies fell by 3.0k (–0.9%qtr) between May and August, extending the previous quarter's decline. The May and February estimates were also revised slightly lower. As a result, vacancies are now 1.4% below their level a year earlier. The result was at odds with partial indicators, which all pointed to a rise in the quarter.

The decline was wholly driven by the private sector, where vacancies fell 2.0%qtr to be 1.5%yr lower. In contrast, public sector vacancies rose 7.8%qtr, marking the strongest quarterly increase in four years and partially reversing the sharp 7.5%qtr decline recorded in the May quarter. Public sector vacancies were flat over the year.

Job vacancies have largely moved sideways since early 2025, though a resumption of the broader downtrend now appears increasingly likely. Labour demand has held up reasonably well, though not sufficiently to match growth in labour supply, resulting in a gradual easing in labour market conditions (see here). Today's result is also consistent with our view that this process will continue into early 2027 as the cumulative effects of high inflation and higher interest rates continue to weigh on activity and hiring demand.

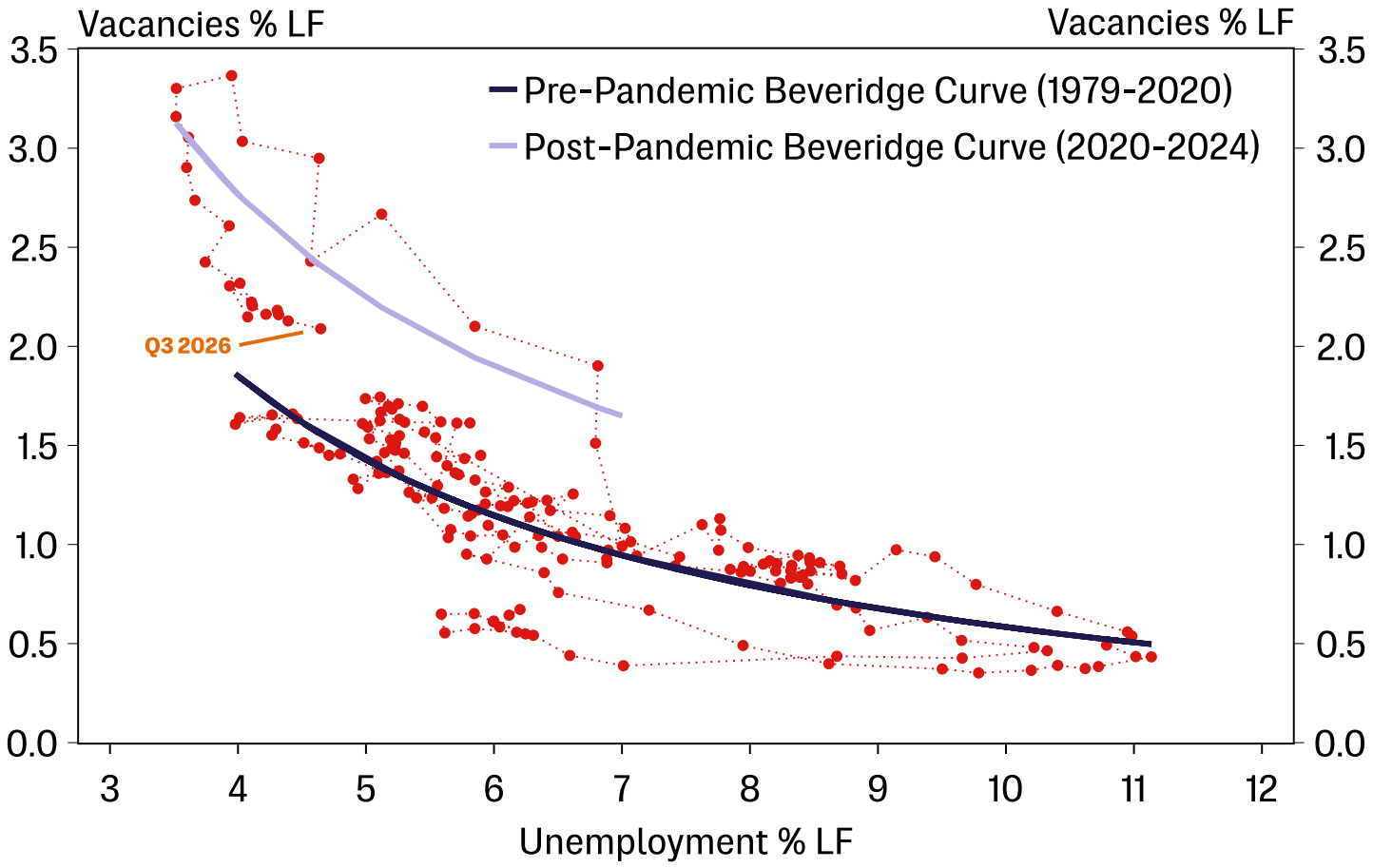


The vacancy-to-unemployment ratio, a key measure of labour market tightness closely monitored by the RBA, declined from 0.48 to 0.45. The fall was the sharpest since early 2025, reflecting both a decline in vacancies and a 6.8%qtr increase in the number of unemployed people over the quarter, largely owing to the continued strength in labour supply. The ratio remains well above its long-run average of around 0.2.



Given the strong growth in labour supply, the Beveridge curve provides a useful framework for assessing recent labour market developments. By comparing vacancies and unemployment as shares of the labour force, it controls for growth in the overall size of the labour market. Between 2022 and 2024, the labour market moved down the steep portion of the Beveridge curve, with substantial declines in vacancies occurring alongside only modest increases in unemployment. While labour market tightness has continued to unwind, Australia remains in this region of the curve, suggesting that further rebalancing between labour demand and supply can occur through lower vacancies without a material rise in unemployment.

Australia's Beveridge Curve



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

All statistics mentioned below are not seasonally adjusted and hence may not add up to the seasonally adjusted statistics referenced above.

By industry, job vacancies declined in eight of the 18 industries over the three months to August. The largest falls were recorded in wholesale trade (–18.2%qtr), professional, scientific & technical services (–17.4%qtr), and information media & telecommunications (–16.7%qtr). Consumer-facing sectors were mixed, with retail trade (24.6%) and arts & recreation services (10.3%) recording strong increases, while accommodation & food services edged 0.9% lower. Only three industries have seen vacancies fall below their pre-pandemic levels: administrative & support services (–24.3%qtr), information media & telecommunications (–9.1%qtr), and financial & insurance services (–7.3%qtr).

Overall market sector vacancies were flat in the quarter, meanwhile the non-market sector saw a 2.9% drop, owing to declines in education & training (–8.2%qtr) and health care & social assistance (–4.2%qtr). For detailed insights on industry condition, see Q2 Labour Account and the Westpac Business Signal.

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30 September 2026

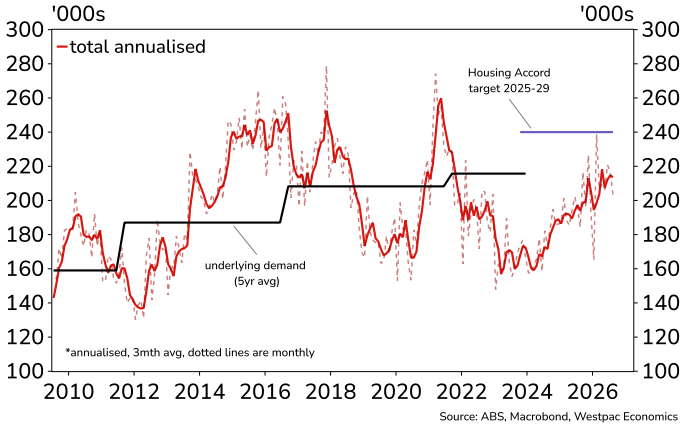
AUSTRALIAN DWELLING APPROVALS BULLETIN

Unit approvals drive the headline lower

Key points

- Total dwelling approvals fell 6.1%mth in August, with the annual pace easing to 10.3%yr. The headline decline was driven by a sharp fall in private unit approvals.
- Private detached dwelling approvals rose 3.7%mth, reaching their highest level since August 2021. In contrast, private unit approvals fell 21.2%mth.
- Queensland recorded the weakest result, while NSW also posted a sizeable decline. By contrast, WA, Victoria and South Australia recorded gains over the month.
- The value of residential building approvals fell 0.6%mth. Volatility in the data centre dominated 'other commercial buildings' segment contributed to the total value of building approvals falling 21.3%mth.
- While detached dwelling approvals continue to show resilience, recent RBA cash rate increases continue to present risks to the outlook.

Dwelling approvals



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Total dwelling approvals –6.1%mth, 10.3%yr

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Detached approvals point to some resilience

Luka Belobrajdic
Economist

Total dwelling approvals fell 6.1%mth in August, with the annual pace easing slightly to 10.3%yr. The result was broadly in line with Westpac's expectation for a 5.0%mth decline, although notably weaker than the market expectation for a 1.0%mth fall. July's decline in private detached dwellings proved short lived, with approvals rebounding in August. Instead, weakness in the headline result was driven by a sizeable decline in private unit approvals.

Note that most figures in the charts and table are presented on a rolling-three month basis to smooth out monthly volatility.

Private detached dwelling approvals rose 3.7%mth in August, following a large 2.5ppt upward revision to July's 1.9%mth decline. The increase was the strongest in more than a year, with private detached dwelling approvals reaching their highest level since August 2021. With the annual pace strengthening to 18.4%yr, detached dwelling approvals continue to appear resilient despite recent interest rate increases. Some of this resilience may partly reflect the implementation of changes to SMSF property borrowing arrangements on 10 August.

Private unit approvals drove the decline in the headline result, falling 21.2%mth in August. Following a 1.2ppt upward revision to July's 0.8%mth increase, the annual pace returned to contractionary territory at –2.1%yr. Weakness was broad-based across segments, with both high-rise and low-mid-rise approvals declining in the month.

Queensland recorded the weakest result, with private approvals falling 22.6%mth, driven primarily by weakness in unit approvals, while private approvals in NSW also declined, falling 17.1%mth. By contrast, WA (+0.2%mth), Victoria (+8.4%mth) and South Australia (+32.0%mth) all recorded gains over the month.

In value terms, residential building approvals fell 0.6%mth, driven by a 0.5%mth decline in new residential approvals and a 2.1%mth fall in renovation activity. Non-residential approvals declined sharply, down 44.8%mth. Volatility continues to be driven by the data centre-dominated 'other commercial' segment, which fell 91.1%mth on a non-seasonally adjusted basis. Excluding this segment, in non-seasonally adjusted terms, non-residential approvals fell a more subdued 13.9%mth (from -37.9%mth). The total value of building approvals declined 21.3%mth in August.

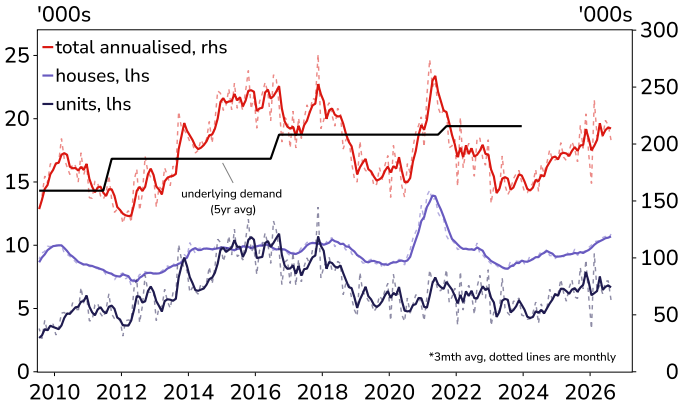
August's result suggests dwelling approvals continue to moderate following the strength recorded earlier in the year. However, the underlying picture remains more resilient, with the headline decline driven by volatility in unit approvals while detached dwellings strengthened. NSW and Victoria, traditionally among the more interest rate sensitive housing markets, recorded the weakest detached dwelling outcomes, potentially signalling broader rate effects ahead. For a comprehensive assessment of housing market conditions, see our latest **Housing Pulse** (see here).

Building approvals – August 2026

		3mth %chg*		%yr	
3mth avg	latest	Jul	Aug	Jul	Aug
Private houses	10,692	2.7	2.5	12.9	14.3
Private units	6,669	-9.2	3.1	3.4	5.5
Public dwellings	440	31.4	11.3	2.9	-8.9
Total dwellings	17,802	-1.7	2.9	8.8	10.1
Total dwellings, mthly*	16,953	-1.9	-6.1	10.9	10.3
– units in 'high rise'^	3,972	-18.4	11.0	3.9	16.1
– units in 'low rise'^	3,066	-5.9	-3.0	-5.6	-8.0
Renovations, $bn	1.310	-1.2	-4.1	9.2	7.2
Non–res., $bn	8.068	27.1	-4.0	42.8	9.4

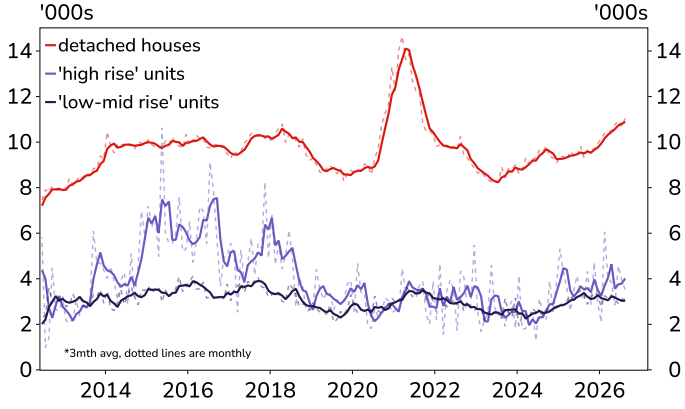
*figures for 'total dwellings mthly' are monthly and mthly%ch, all others are rolling 3mth avg and 3mth%ch; ^all sectors, Westpac estimates
Sources: ABS, Westpac Economics

Dwelling approvals: major segment



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Dwelling approvals: detailed segment



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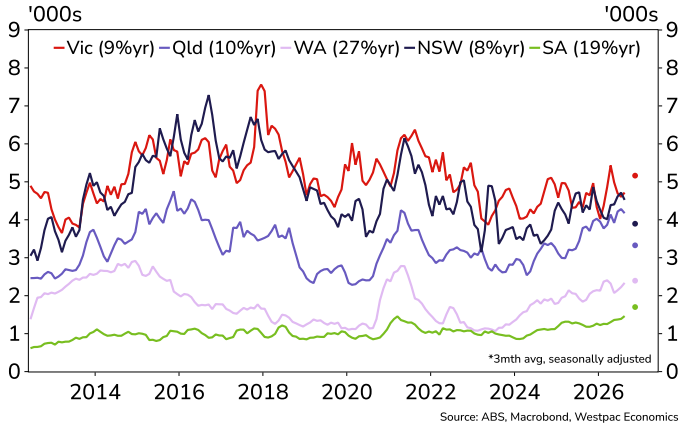
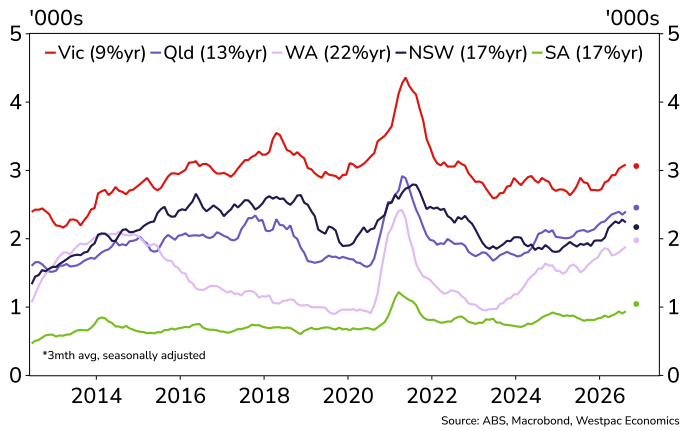
Total dwelling approvals: by state



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Detached house approvals: by state



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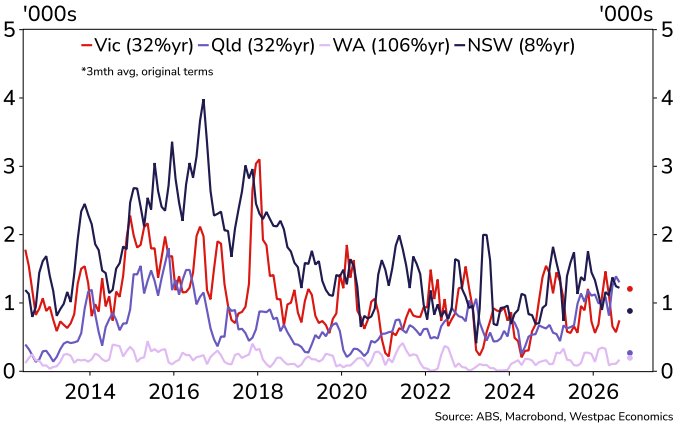
'High rise' approvals: by state



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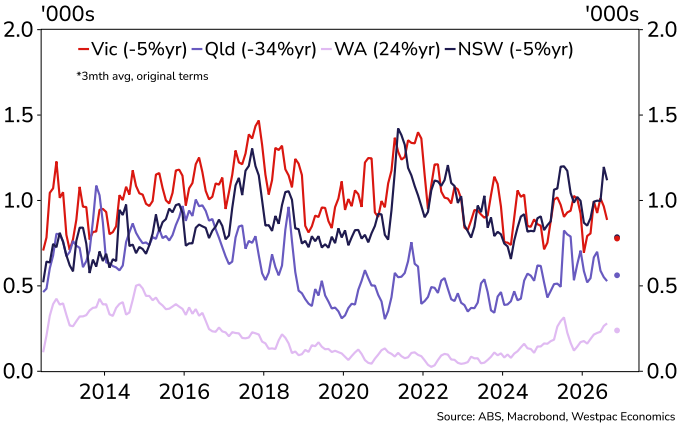
'Low-mid rise' approvals: by state



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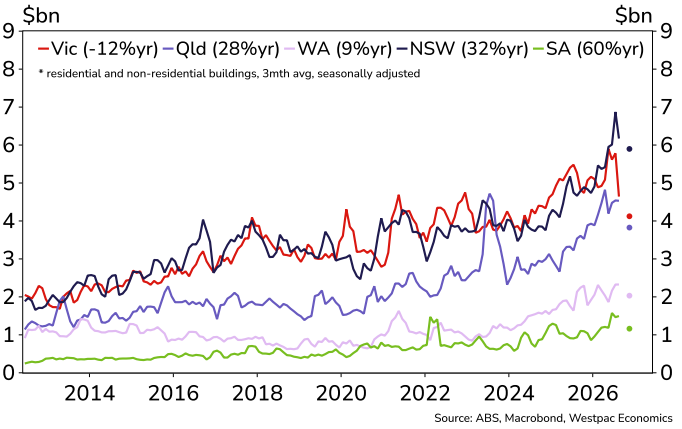

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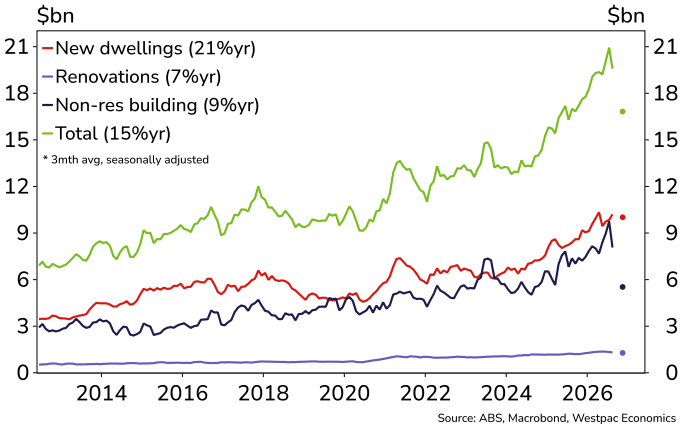
Total building approvals: by segment



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29 September 2026

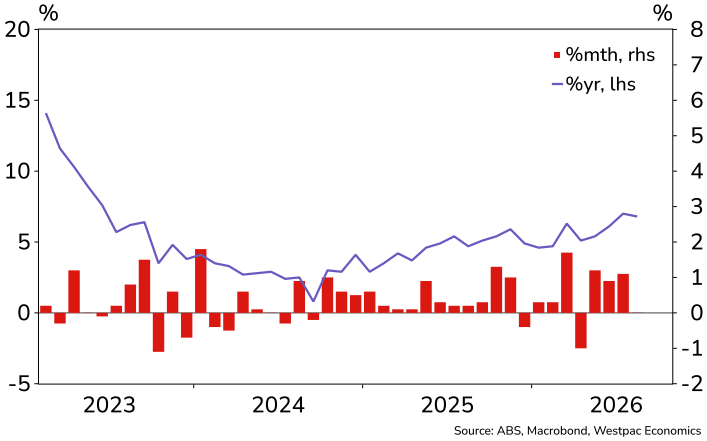
HOUSEHOLD SPENDING INDICATOR BULLETIN

Transport strength masks a softer spending pulse

Key points

- Household spending was unchanged in August, with annual growth easing to 6.8%yr.
- Services spend declined 0.3%mth, offset by a 0.3%mth rise in goods spend. A modest rotation away from discretionary categories emerged, with discretionary spend falling 0.3%mth and non-discretionary spend rising 0.6%mth.
- Transport spending rose strongly, supported by higher fuel spending and electric vehicle purchases, while most other categories were weaker.
- Our **Westpac Card Tracker** points to robust growth in nominal spending over the September quarter but with the pace much slower through the August and September months and a further shift from discretionary to non-discretionary categories, reflecting a renewed squeeze from higher fuel costs and weak consumer sentiment.

Monthly Household Spending Indicator Growth



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Aug household spending indicator: 0.0%mth, 6.8%yr

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Higher fuel prices lift fuel spending and EV purchases

Luka Belobrajdic
Economist

The monthly household spending indicator was unchanged in August, with the annual pace of growth easing to 6.8%yr. Today's result was somewhat stronger than Westpac's expectation for a 0.5%mth decline, but weaker than the market expectation of a 0.4%mth increase. It also marks a material slowing in the pace of spending growth following a run of stronger outcomes since May.

The strength recorded in services spending over recent months gave way in August, with spending falling 0.3%mth (+5.9%yr). This was offset by a modest 0.3%mth rise in goods spending, taking annual growth to 7.7%yr, its strongest pace since November 2022. As highlighted in our latest **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker** (see here), there has been a modest rotation away from discretionary categories. Discretionary spending fell 0.3%mth (+7.2%yr), while non-discretionary spending offset some of this weakness, rising 0.6%mth (+6.3%yr).

At the detailed level, recreation & culture recorded the largest decline, falling 1.4%mth, with the ABS noting that some of the weakness reflected payback following elevated spending associated with major sporting events in previous months. Clothing & footwear (–1%mth), alcoholic beverages & tobacco (–1%mth), health (–0.9%mth), furnishings & household equipment (–0.6%mth), and food (–0.3%mth) also declined. Offsetting some of this weakness were gains across miscellaneous goods & services (+0.3%mth), and hotels, cafes & restaurants (+0.8%mth). The major offset, however, came from transport spending, up 2.3%mth. The ABS attributed the increase to stronger fuel spending and new vehicle purchases, particularly electric vehicles. Higher fuel prices, together with the full restoration of fuel excise from 3 August, helped drive an 8.1% increase in fuel spending. Excluding fuel spending, total household spending would have fallen 0.3%mth.

State outcomes were mixed. Tasmania (–0.5%mth), Victoria (–0.4%mth) and WA (–0.2%mth) recorded declines, while SA (+0.1%mth), NSW (+0.3%mth) and Queensland (+0.3%mth) proved more resilient.

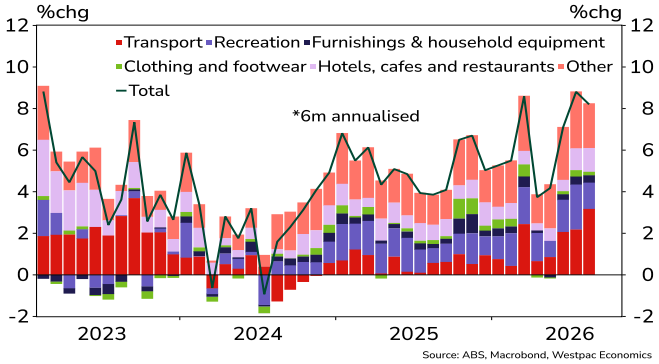
Today's result points to a moderation in the recent strength in household spending. Our **Westpac Card Tracker** suggests September has been about flat as well, albeit with nominal spending still posting robust growth for the quarter as a whole. Some of the quarterly gain appears to reflect higher prices rather than stronger underlying activity. Meanwhile, part of the slower monthly pace – and shift from discretionary to non discretionary – appears to be due to renewed constraints from higher fuel prices, concerns around further interest rate increases and ongoing weakness in housing sentiment, themes that are also evident in consumer sentiment, which deteriorated further through September (see here).

Household spending indicator – August 2026

	$bn	% chg mth		% chg yr	
	Aug-26	Jul-26	Aug-26	Jul-26	Aug-26
sa	82.34	1.1	0.0	7.0	6.8
trend	82.16	0.6	0.5	6.2	6.3

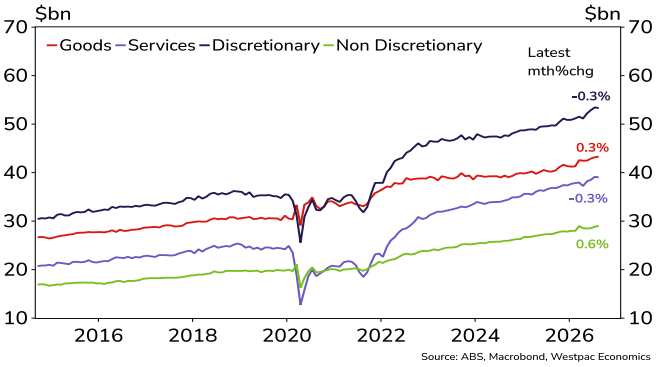
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics.

Contribution to growth by category: nominal



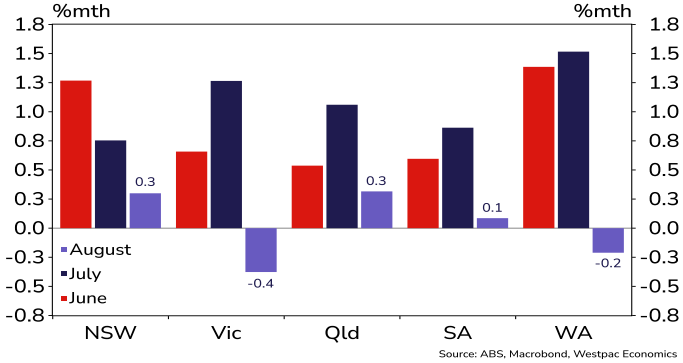
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Goods, services, discretionary & non-discret.



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Monthly household spending by state



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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1 October 2026

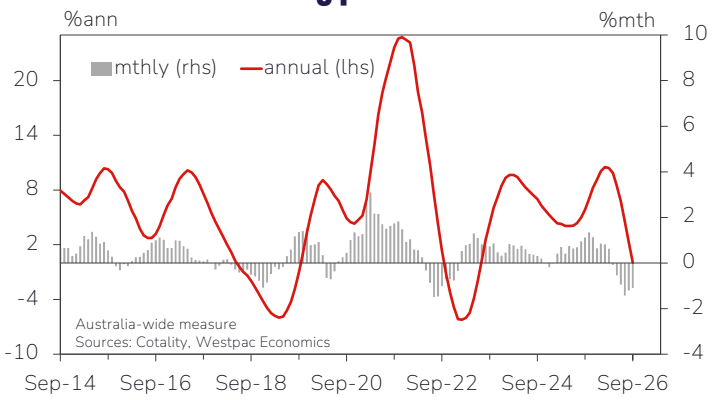
AUSTRALIAN DWELLING PRICES BULLETIN

Slide continues

Key points

- The Cotality home value index – covering all of Australia – fell 1.1% in September following a downwardly revised declines of 1.2% in August and 1.4% in July. Annual growth stalled flat with prices nationally now 5.2% below their peak in March.
- Declines continue to be widespread. Across the major cities, prices fell 1.4% in Sydney, 1.5% in Brisbane, 1.3% in Adelaide, and 1.2% in Perth with Melbourne recording a slightly milder 0.7% decline. Sydney and Melbourne continue to see more pronounced declines with prices now down 7%yr and 6.2%yr respectively.
- Preliminary estimates show the number of sales, in rolling 3mth terms, down 3.9%qtr and 17.4%yr. The pace of turnover falls has moderated from the rapid 8.6%qtr recorded in July.

Australian dwelling prices



Sep Cotality home value index: –1.1%mth; flat %yr

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Losing altitude

Matthew Hassan
Head of Australian Macro–Forecasting

The Cotality home value index, covering all of Australia, fell 1.1% in September with downward revisions to the previous two months again shaving a further 0.4% off prices. The correction has now seen prices decline 5.2% from their March peak. Annual growth is flat.

The price correction remains broad, Cotality reporting 97% of capital city suburbs experienced falls over the three months to September, Darwin the only city to record gains. Sydney and Melbourne continue to see more pronounced declines, albeit moderating a touch, particularly in Melbourne. Against this, declines in Brisbane, Adelaide and Perth have accelerated over the last few months. Across segments, unit prices and lower price tiers continue to track slightly milder falls than houses and top tiers.

Seasonal variations accentuated price weakness through winter but are now neutral. The peak-to-trough price decline nationally is slightly milder at 4.6% in seasonally adjusted terms. Unless specified, figures in titles, tables and the commentary below are in non-seasonally adjusted terms, consistent with the 'headline' figures reported by Cotality. However, figures shown in charts are in seasonally adjusted terms.

Preliminary estimates of turnover show rolling 3mth volumes down 3.9%qtr in September and 17.4%yr with previous estimates revised 1-2ppts lower. The monthly pattern suggests small gains in July and August have given way to another sizeable fall in September.

Looking at the price performance across different jurisdictions:

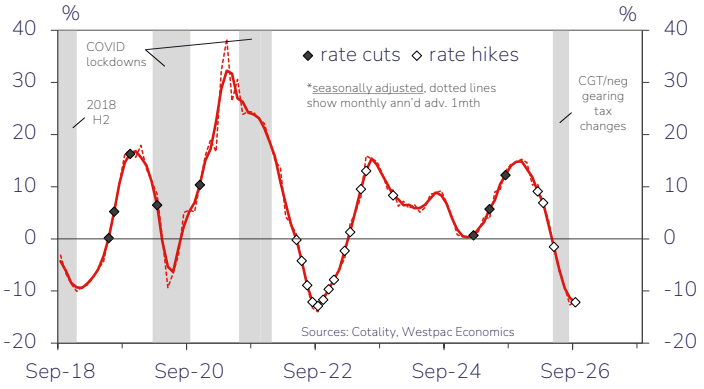
- **Sydney** prices dropped 1.4% fall in September, monthly declines averaging 1.6% over the previous four months, tracking a 17% annualised pace of decline since May. All segments and tiers recorded falls in Q3 but with top and middle tier houses notably weaker.
- **Melbourne** prices fell 0.7%mth, a slower pace than other capitals. This likely reflects the weaker starting point coming into the correction, prices already back to the levels seen in mid-2021. As elsewhere, 'top tier' houses prices are leading the decline. 'Low tier' unit prices mostly held their ground in Q3, prices in this sub-segment already plumbing 10yr lows.
- **Brisbane** was the weakest capital city price-wise, recording a 1.5% drop in September with previous monthly declines also revised down heavily (August from 1% to 1.6% and July from 1.2% to 1.7%). The combined effect has taken the rolling 3mth change to –4.7%qtr from –2.7%qtr last month and –0.6%qtr in July. At 5.9%yr, annual growth is still positive but losing altitude quickly, having run at 18%yr as recently as May. Sellers have been slow to respond to

Cotality home value index: September 2026

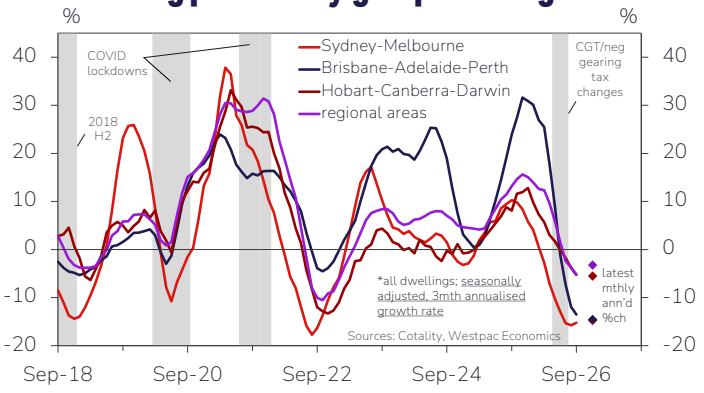
	%mth				%ann			
	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep
Australia*	**-0.9**	**-1.4**	**-1.2**	**-1.1**	**6.8**	**4.5**	**2.3**	**0.0**
seas. adjusted	-0.8	-1.1	-1.1	-1.0	6.8	4.6	2.3	0.1
– houses	-1.0	-1.5	-1.3	-1.2	7.3	4.9	2.5	0.0
– units	-0.8	-1.2	-0.7	-0.8	4.8	3.0	1.5	0.0
Major capital cities								
Sydney	-1.5	-1.9	-1.6	-1.4	0.2	-2.3	-4.8	-7.0
Melbourne	-1.4	-1.6	-1.1	-0.7	-1.2	-3.2	-4.8	-6.2
Brisbane	-0.6	-1.7	-1.6	-1.5	16.1	13.0	9.4	5.9
Adelaide	-0.2	-0.3	-1.1	-1.3	11.7	10.7	8.7	6.5
Perth	-1.2	-1.8	-1.7	-1.2	21.4	17.8	14.0	10.1
Turnover^	**-5.3**	**-8.6**	**-7.8**	**-3.9**	**-12.8**	**-17.6**	**-17.3**	**-17.4**

* Australia–wide measure, covering both capital cities and regional areas.
Sources: Cotality, Westpac Economics.
^ rolling 3mth total, %3mth and %ann ch, seasonally adjusted by Westpac.

Australian dwelling prices: 3mth ann'd



Dwelling prices: city groups and regional areas



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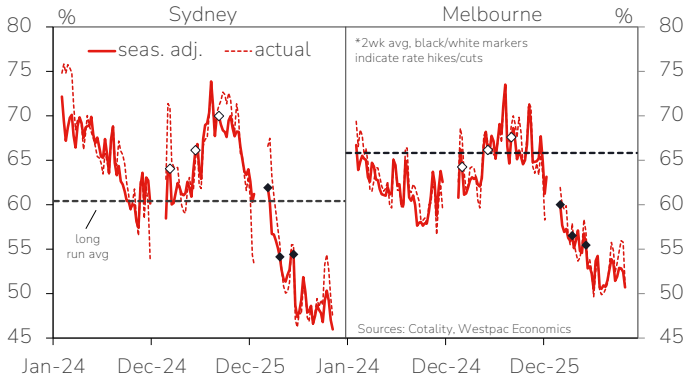
the sudden stop with total listings up over 50% vs a year ago, albeit still not high compared to long run averages (reflecting the extremely tight starting point for the Brisbane market).

- **Adelaide** dwelling prices fell 1.3%mth, the August decline also marked down from 0.8% to 1.1%, annual price growth dropping to 6.5%yr. The price correction began later in Adelaide but is now running at a similar pace to prices nationally.
- **Perth** recorded a 1.2% decline but also saw big downward revisions to previous months (August from 0.8% to –1.7% and July from –1.3% to –1.8%). At 10.1%yr, annual growth is still solidly positive but was tracking at over 25%yr earlier in the year. As with Adelaide and Brisbane, the detail shows a more even spread of declines across price tiers. However, turnover is showing a milder pull-back in Adelaide.
- The smaller capitals were again more mixed, price growth still positive in Darwin (0.4%mth, 11.9%yr), relatively resilient in Hobart (–0.5%mth, 7%yr) but weaker in Canberra (–1.1%mth, –1.6%yr).
- **Regional markets** showed a 0.9% decline in Qld but slightly milder declines in NSW (–0.7%) and Victoria (0.3%). Annual prices growth is in the 3.4-6.3%yr range.

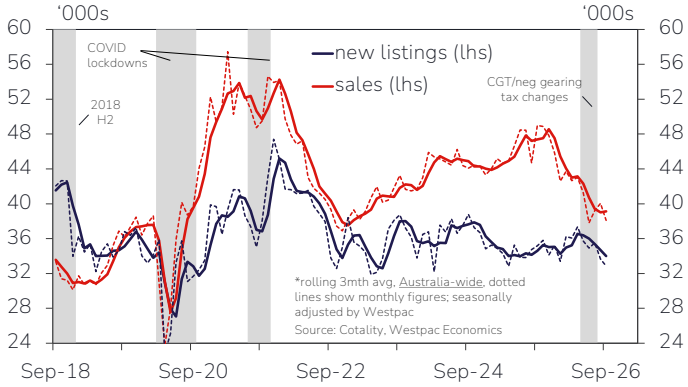
Our recently released **Housing Pulse** report (here) provides a deeper diver into the situation in Australia's housing markets. While the absence of selling pressure, still tight supply-demand balance and sentiment mix suggests the correction was still relatively 'orderly' through the September quarter, the latest monthly data shows momentum remains unambiguously negative.

That said, there are clearly more headwinds to come. The RBA latest interest rate rise and what now looks to be a more likely prospect of a follow-up increase at its meeting in early November will impact in coming months. Next week's consumer sentiment update will show how the change, and the latest round of weak updates, is shaping housing-related sentiment. Either way, momentum looks set to remain weak into year-end and, barring a significantly improved inflation and interest rate outlook, early 2027.

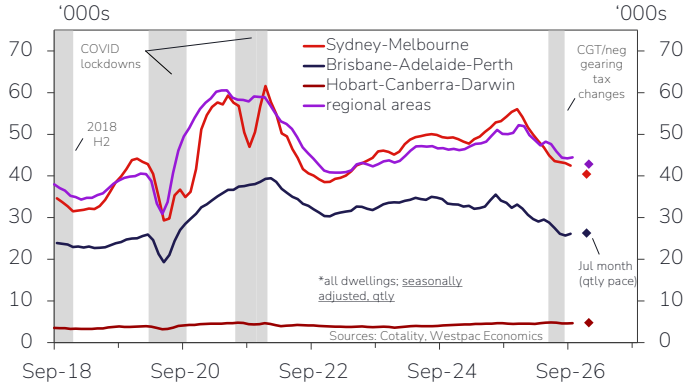
Auction clearance rates



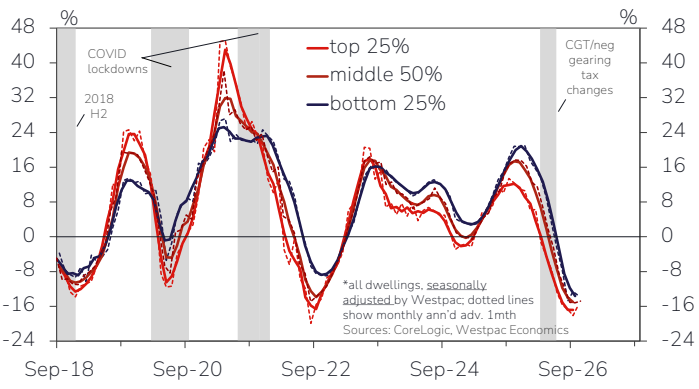
Australian dwellings: sales and listings



Dwelling sales: city groups and regional areas



Australian dwelling prices: price tiers



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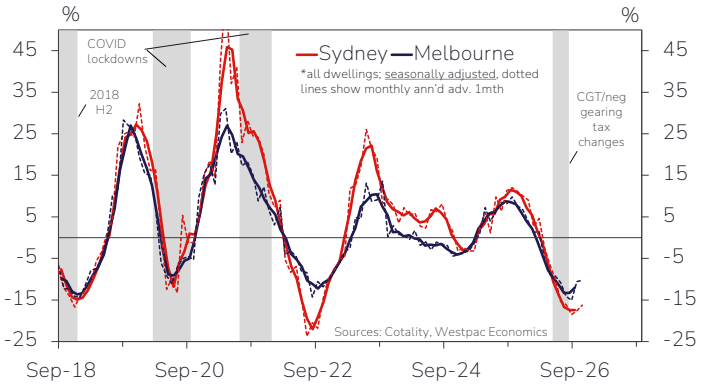
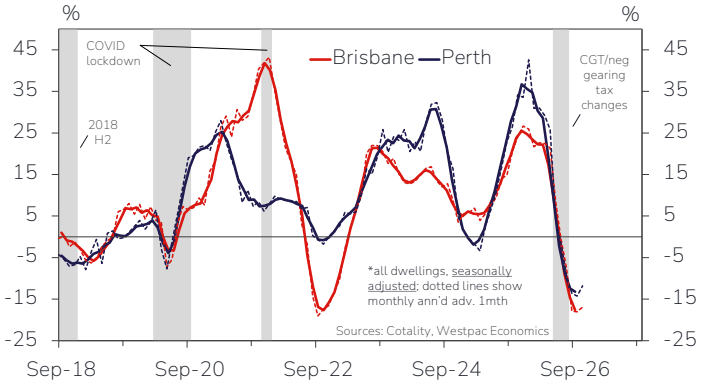
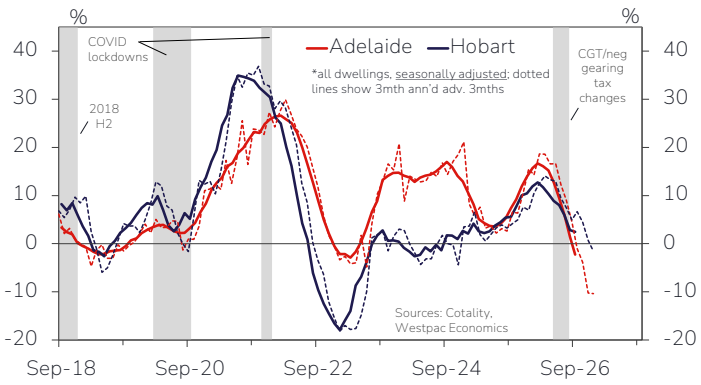
Sydney, Melbourne dwelling prices: 3mth ann'd



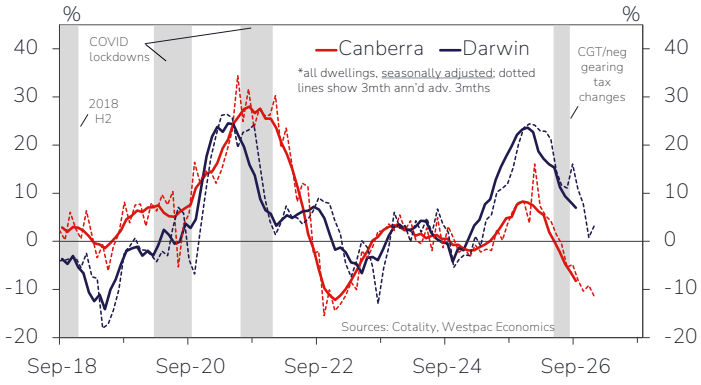
Brisbane, Perth dwelling prices: 3mth ann'd



Adelaide, Hobart dwelling prices: 6mth ann'd



Canberra, Darwin dwelling prices: 6mth ann'd



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ECONOMIC BULLETIN

Persistent inflation and the RBNZ.

1 Oct 2026 | **Satish Ranchhod**, Senior Economist | +64 9 336 5668 | +64 21 710 852 | satish.ranchhod@westpac.co.nz

A lack of headroom: The RBNZ, oil prices and administered costs.

- **New Zealand households have faced a run of large cost increases in recent years related to administered charges and parts of the economy that are less exposed to competition, such as electricity charges and local council rates.**
- **Those cost increases have continued for an extended period, making them hard for the RBNZ to look through.**
- **This has also meant that the RBNZ had little headroom to absorb upside inflation surprises even before the recent spike in oil prices.**
- **We expect that there will be ongoing sizeable increases in many of these costs. That is a key reason why we expect domestic (non-tradables) inflation will be higher than the RBNZ expects over the longer-term.**
- **That ongoing firmness in domestic inflation is also a reason why we expect the RBNZ will ultimately need to raise the OCR by more than they assumed in their September policy Statement.**
- **But getting inflation down to target levels in the face of an oil price spike and high administered prices won't be easy and involves some tough trade-offs. Administered prices tend to be less responsive to changes in economic conditions. As a result, interest rate hikes are likely to have a bigger impact on parts of the economy that are not the main drivers of inflation.**

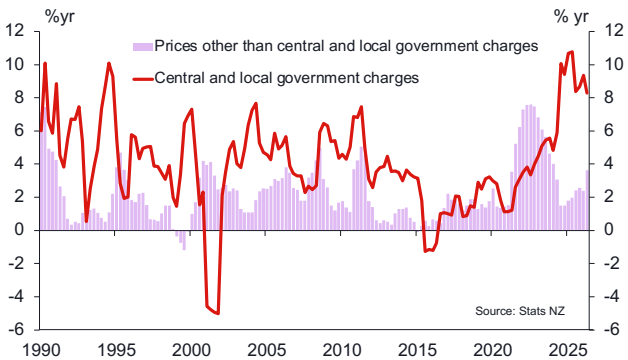
Inflation is high for reasons beyond oil prices.

Inflation in New Zealand rose to 4.1% in the year to June, the highest it's been in three years. And it's set to remain above 3% until at least mid-2027.

Much of the recent strength in inflation has been due to the spike in oil prices since the outbreak of war in the Middle East. However, even before the spike in fuel costs, inflation had been running hot for an extended period: inflation has been above 3% since mid-2025, and it's now been above the RBNZ's 2% target midpoint for five years.

That persistent firmness in inflation is particularly notable as, based on RBNZ estimates, the New Zealand economy has had a negative output gap since September 2024, with softness in economic growth and a weak labour market. Those conditions would typically be associated with more moderate inflation than we've seen.

Sources of inflation



Looking beneath the surface, much of the strength in inflation over the past year has been related to administered costs, such as government charges, and price increases in parts of the economy that are less

exposed to competitive pressures. For instance, over the past year, local council rates rose nearly 9%, electricity prices rose by 12% and health insurance premiums rose by 19%.

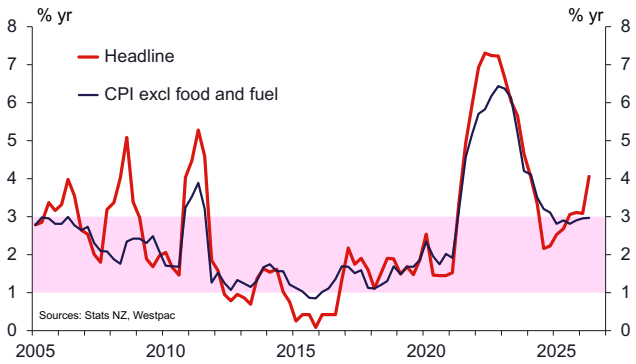
The less competitive nature of some of these sectors means they aren't very responsive to changes in interest rates. Instead, they are most likely to behave in a "cost-plus" manner. And in some cases, recent years have seen large increases in operating costs that are now being passed on to consumers.

These aren't one-off cost rises the RBNZ can look through.

Just as the RBNZ might look through a one-off spike in oil prices, there's a reasonable argument for looking through a one-off rise in administered prices that pushes up inflation. For instance, a one-off increase in vehicle registration costs might boost inflation temporarily, but isn't something the RBNZ would respond to.

However, the issue here is that the increases we're seeing are *not* one-off price rises. We've seen large increases spread across a range of administered costs for several years now (see chart on page 4). That's been reflected in measures of core inflation, which strip out swings in volatile items like fuel and instead track the underlying trend in prices. For example, excluding the rise in food and fuel prices, inflation in the year to June was 2.9%, and it's been running close to or above 3% for five years now. That's meant that the RBNZ had little headroom to absorb upside inflation surprises even before the recent spike in fuel costs.

Headline and core



We expect that there will be continued large increases in some administered costs. For instance, in the case of local council rates, many councils will need to fund significant infrastructure spending over the coming years. There have been efforts to limit the extent of those increases, such as the **Government's cap on council rates**. However, that doesn't change the underlying reason for the large rates increases in recent years, such as increased spending on essential infrastructure. And if councils can't raise the required revenue through rates, they may have to look at other approaches like user pays. That could shift costs for households, rather than reducing them.

Price rises – past five years

	% increase past year	Average annual % increase – past 5 years	Total % increase 2021 to 2026
Petrol	27.5	10.3	51.3
Electricity	12.0	6.0	33.2
Gas	10.9	9.8	58.9
Water supply	4.2	7.5	43.5
Local authority rates	8.8	9.0	54.0
Dwelling insurance	-0.8	10.0	58.5
Contents insurance	-4.0	9.2	52.6
Health insurance	19.2	12.0	75.2
Vehicle insurance	0.6	7.2	39.6
Total consumer prices	**4.1**	**4.7**	**25.6**

Why does this matter?

It's important to remember that the RBNZ's focus is not individual prices in the CPI (like fuel prices or council rates), but the overall level of inflation. In essence, it doesn't matter why inflation is elevated – all that matters is that it is elevated and how persistent inflation will be.

Right now, with core inflation already elevated, it's hard for the RBNZ to look through the large and continuing cost increases that we've seen across a range of areas that are less exposed to competition. And given the risk of ongoing large increases in these costs, we expect that domestic (non-tradables) inflation will be higher than the RBNZ has assumed over the longer-term.

That's part of the reason why we continue to expect that the RBNZ will need to raise the Official Cash Rate by more than they had assumed in their September policy Statement. We're forecasting a 25bp rate rise at the RBNZ's December meeting and expect the OCR will peak at 4% next year. That risk is being compounded by the protracted nature of the current rise in oil prices, along with other risks such as **El Niño** which could boost food prices over the coming year.

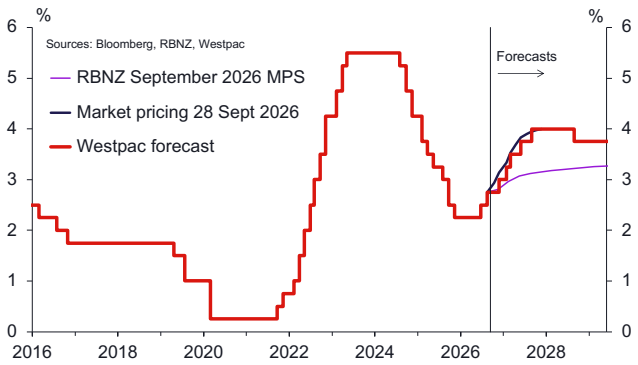
However, costs like oil prices, electricity charges, and administered charges like council rates are not responsive to changes in interest rates. As a result, when inflation pressures are centred on such areas, the RBNZ needs to work harder to keep overall inflation in check. It does this by leaning against inflation in areas of the economy that are more responsive to interest rates to bring aggregate inflation pressures down towards target in a timely manner. But rather than leaning against the source of inflation pressures, the impact of tighter policy will be to dampen demand and price-setting in other more

interest rate-sensitive parts of the economy such as the construction sector or discretionary retail spending.

This is an uncomfortable but necessary trade-off. Tighter policy will weigh on discretionary spending, the labour market and near-term growth, and would affect prices in parts of the economy that are not the drivers of inflation. A higher OCR also means increases in households' debt-servicing costs, and for some households, that will be very challenging.

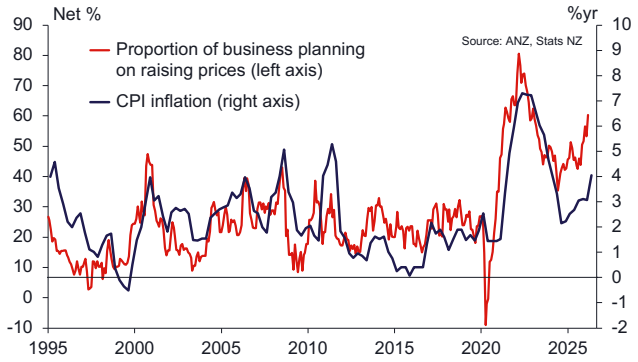
However, looking through or not responding to these sorts of ongoing large cost increases would still leave households dealing with significant increases in overall living costs. In the long run, that could be more damaging for households and the economy.

Official Cash Rate forecasts



Adding to the RBNZ's concerns about both the oil price shock and continued large increases in administered prices, inflation expectations are relatively elevated. In fact, long-term inflation expectations in business and consumer surveys are close to where they were in 2022 when inflation was much higher than today. Similarly, firms consistently signal in business surveys that cost pressures are strong and margins have been squeezed.

Business pricing intentions vs consumer prices



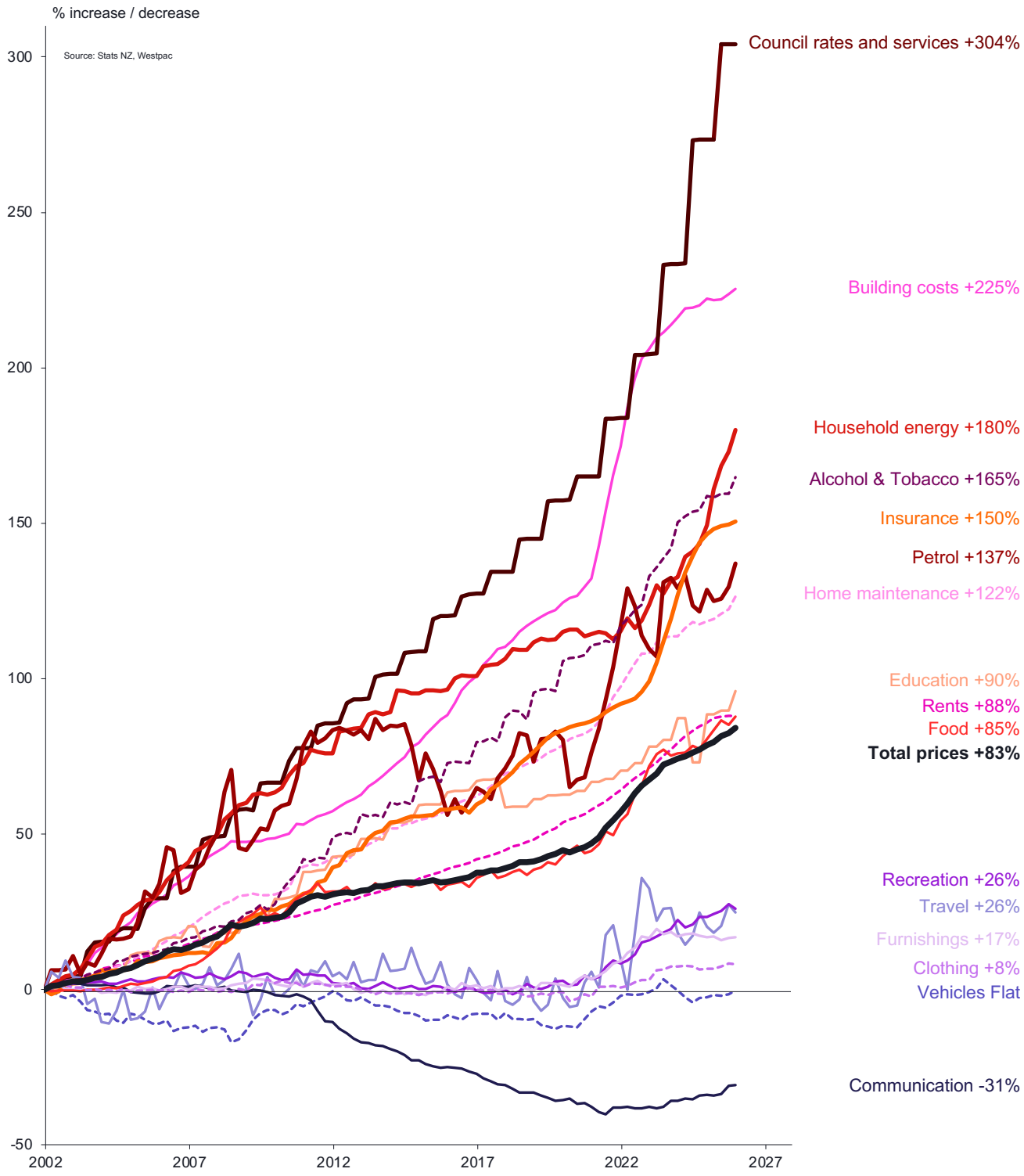
Softness in demand might be limiting some firms' ability to lift prices at the current time. However, when demand eventually firms again, there's a risk that businesses expect continued high levels of inflation and try to push through larger price rises (sometimes referred to as high inflation expectations becoming 'embedded').

That means inflation could remain high even when the immediate impact of temporary boosts to inflation, like an oil price spike, fades. This is a key reason why it's important to get inflation back to 2% on a consistent basis, rather than allowing inflation to run at levels closer to the top of the RBNZ's target band.

The RBNZ does have discretion in how aggressively it responds to inflation, and that is where the source of inflation matters. The RBNZ is likely to adjust the OCR more gradually when inflation is related to less interest rate-sensitive areas, like oil costs or government charges. And when doing so, it does account for how changes in the Official Cash Rate could affect the labour market and economic activity. But even if the RBNZ responds more gradually to inflation, it can't ignore ongoing large cost increases indefinitely. Eventually inflation needs to be brought back to target.

See overleaf for a chart of how consumer prices have changed over the past 25 years.

Change in prices since 2002 (Selected prices from the CPI)



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Mapping out Asia ...

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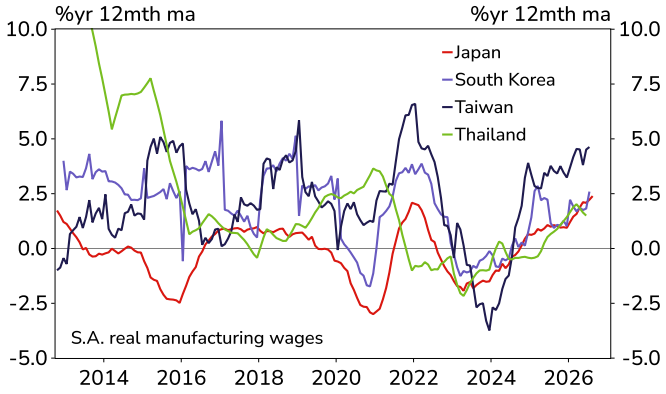
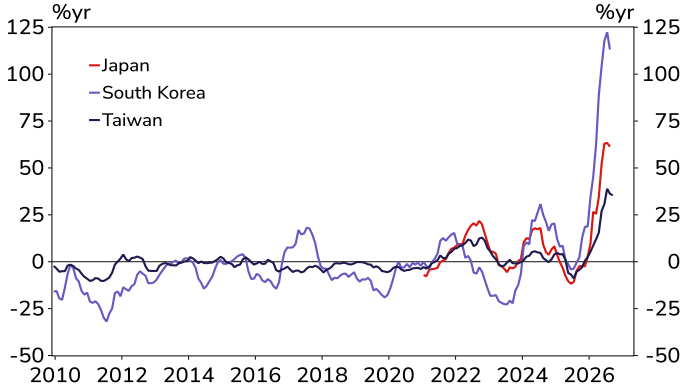
- For two decades, lower labour costs across Asia helped suppress global goods inflation.
- Much of that disinflationary pulse originated in North Asia, where production was increasingly offshored to lower-cost labour markets.
- Today, ageing populations and rising incomes are lifting labour costs across much of the region.
- While production continues to migrate towards South and Southeast Asia, the next phase of manufacturing is increasingly driven by capital, technology and power rather than low-cost labour.
- As a result, labour costs are unlikely to provide the same disinflationary impulse that supported goods prices over the previous decade.

Asia's labour-cost advantage is fading



Source: DGBAS, MOEL, MHLW, NSO, MODS, SBJ, BTEI, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Electronics export prices skyrocket

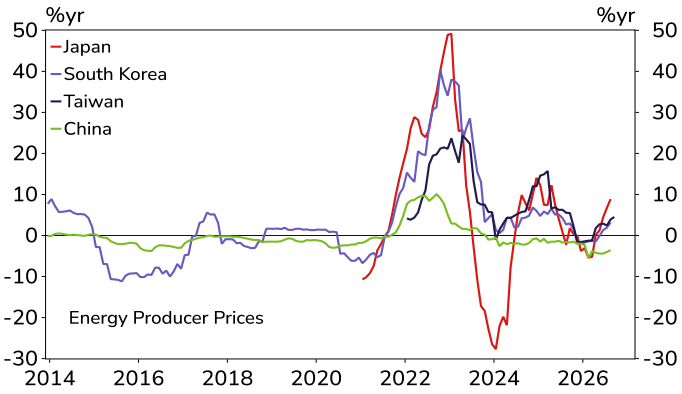


Source: DGBAS, BOK, BOJ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

- Technology has historically provided a source of disinflation as production costs fell and competition intensified.
- Asia sits at the centre of the AI supply chain through firms such as TSMC, Samsung and SK Hynix, which produce critical semiconductors and memory chips used in AI infrastructure.
- Rising costs for electricity and critical minerals are increasing production costs across the sector.
- Strong demand has allowed firms to pass these costs on while maintaining healthy profitability. SK Hynix's net profit rose from ₩19.8tn to ₩42.9tn (+117%yr).
- Firms are also competing on performance and technological capability rather than price, allowing technology-related inflation to emerge for the first time in years.

- Many Asian economies remain reliant on imported energy, leaving producers exposed to higher oil and LNG costs.
- Semiconductor manufacturing and the broader AI infrastructure build-out are highly energy intensive. Expansions by TSMC, Samsung and SK Hynix are increasing electricity demand across North Asia while data-centre investment adds a further source of demand.
- As technology firms compete with traditional manufacturers for power, energy costs are becoming an increasingly important part of the production process.
- Rising production costs are therefore being driven by both higher energy prices and stronger underlying demand for electricity.

The AI boom is lifting energy demand



Source: BOJ, NBS, BOK, DGBAS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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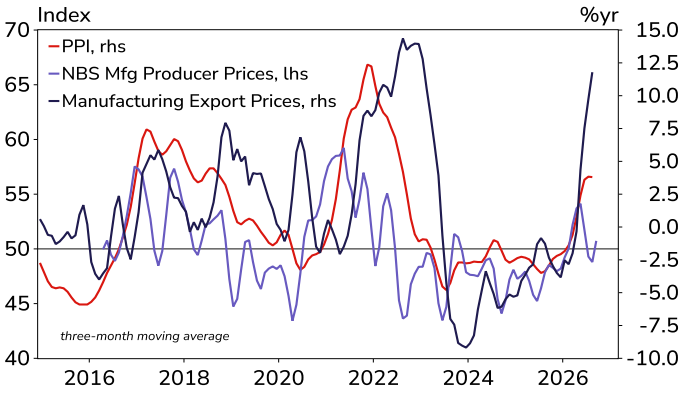
... in charts

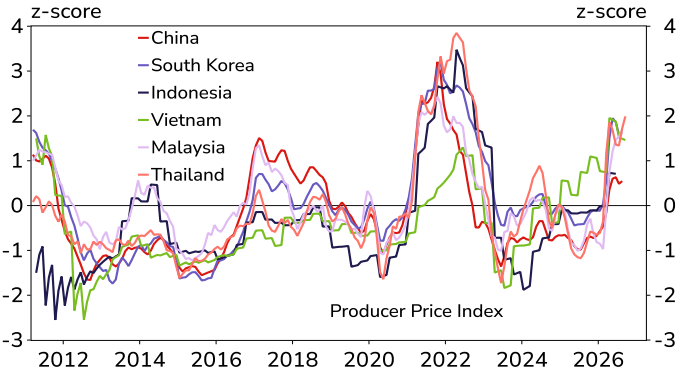
- Chinese producer-price deflation remains evident across parts of traditional manufacturing, particularly sectors facing persistent overcapacity such as automobiles
- Historically, Chinese producer prices acted as the pricing anchor for much of Asia's manufacturing sector.
- What has changed is that parts of the region are increasingly specialising in industries where China is not the dominant supplier.
- Strong demand for semiconductors, memory and AI-related goods is allowing firms in Taiwan and South Korea to set prices according to their own market conditions despite ongoing weakness in Chinese producer prices.
- China's deflationary pulse remains important, but it no longer guarantees lower prices across the rest of Asia.

China's deflation is losing influence



Source: NBS, CFLP, GAC, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

The cheapest supply chain no longer wins

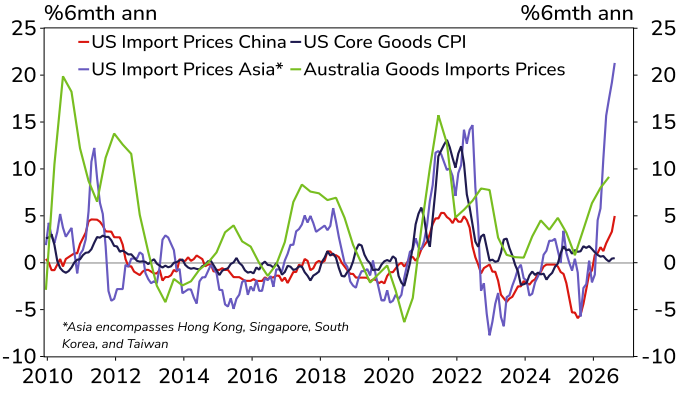


Source: BOJ, BOK, SingStat, HKC&SD, NBS, Philippine Statistics Authority, BPS, Vietnamese National Statistics Office, DOSM, BTEI, Indian Ministry of Commerce & Industry, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

- Rising costs were previously offset by production shifting to lower-cost economies elsewhere in Asia.
- Production continues to migrate towards Vietnam, India, Indonesia, Malaysia and Thailand, helping contain costs.
- However, these economies are unlikely to replicate the scale of China's integration into global manufacturing during the 2000s.
- High-value production remains concentrated in North Asia while firms increasingly value resilience, security and specialisation alongside cost minimisation.
- Future supply-chain shifts may therefore help limit cost pressures, but are unlikely to generate the same disinflationary pulse seen over the last two decades.

- For much of the past decade, falling goods prices helped offset elevated services inflation across developed markets. The forces that drove that disinflation are now becoming less powerful.
- While Chinese deflation and production relocation to lower-cost economies will continue to provide some support, they are unlikely to fully offset these pressures.
- As a result, imported goods may provide less assistance in bringing inflation back to target than they have in the past.
- This leaves central banks increasingly reliant on containing domestic inflation pressures, particularly in services.
- As a result, achieving inflation targets may require a longer period of restrictive monetary policy than has historically been the case.

Asian prices add risk to developed markets



Source: BLS, ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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First Impressions: NZIER Quarterly Survey of Business Opinion, September quarter 2026

#businessconditions #newzealand

By Michael Gordon
Senior Economist, Westpac NZ

08:35 October 06 2026

Share

Businesses are feeling more optimistic about the months ahead, but current conditions remain tough for many industries. Cost pressures eased off a little compared to last quarter.

Key results (seasonally adjusted)

General business situation: +40 (Prev: +14)

Trading activity, past three months: -1 (Prev: +1)

Trading activity, next three months: +15 (Prev: +11)

Average selling prices, past three months: +27 (Prev: +37)

Average selling prices, next three months: +45 (Prev: +51)

The NZIER's quarterly survey of business opinion showed a strong lift in general confidence in September, despite resurgent fuel prices and the uncertainty around the looming election. Firms were more confident about their prospects for the next few months, even though their recent performance remained rough in many industries.

The survey was held over a relatively compressed period (9 to 28 September), with around 40% of responses coming back on the first day. Later responses were less confident, as the resurgence in world oil prices was finally reflected in prices at the pump over the course of the month.

General business sentiment rose to a net 40% positive compared to a net 14% in June, returning to around the levels seen in the December quarter last year (before the Middle East conflict). However, the own-activity measures, which tend to have a closer correspondence with GDP growth, were more subdued. Trading activity over the last three months was slightly weaker than in June, while expectations for the quarter ahead saw a more modest four-point increase to +15%.

Other forward-looking measures were also up for the quarter. Hiring intentions rose strongly to a net 23% positive (although past employment was down). Notably, firms continue to report that workers are becoming harder to find, despite the ongoing rise in unemployment over the last couple of years. That said, the proportion of firms citing labour as a factor limiting output declined this quarter. Investment intentions picked up, more so for plant and machinery than for buildings.

The results were mixed across industries. Manufacturing and services were more upbeat for the months ahead but reported substantially weaker performance over the last quarter. In contrast, builders and merchants reported both stronger past results and greater optimism about the near-term outlook.

The pricing measures in the survey were down compared to June – not entirely surprising as fuel prices were lower on average through the September quarter compared to the June quarter. The notable exception was merchants, who expected both higher costs and prices for the quarter ahead.

The implications for the RBNZ ahead of its 28 October policy review are unclear – there is certainly no smoking gun in this report that would demand that the RBNZ abandon the "pause" strategy communicated at the September MPS. Optimism among businesses remains high despite the obvious headwinds, but there is still a wide gap between hopes and reality. The pricing measures have eased compared to last quarter, but that may simply confirm the RBNZ's expectation that annual inflation will drop from the 4.1% recorded last quarter as fuel prices eased. The September quarter CPI, released on 22 October, may be more informative in that respect.

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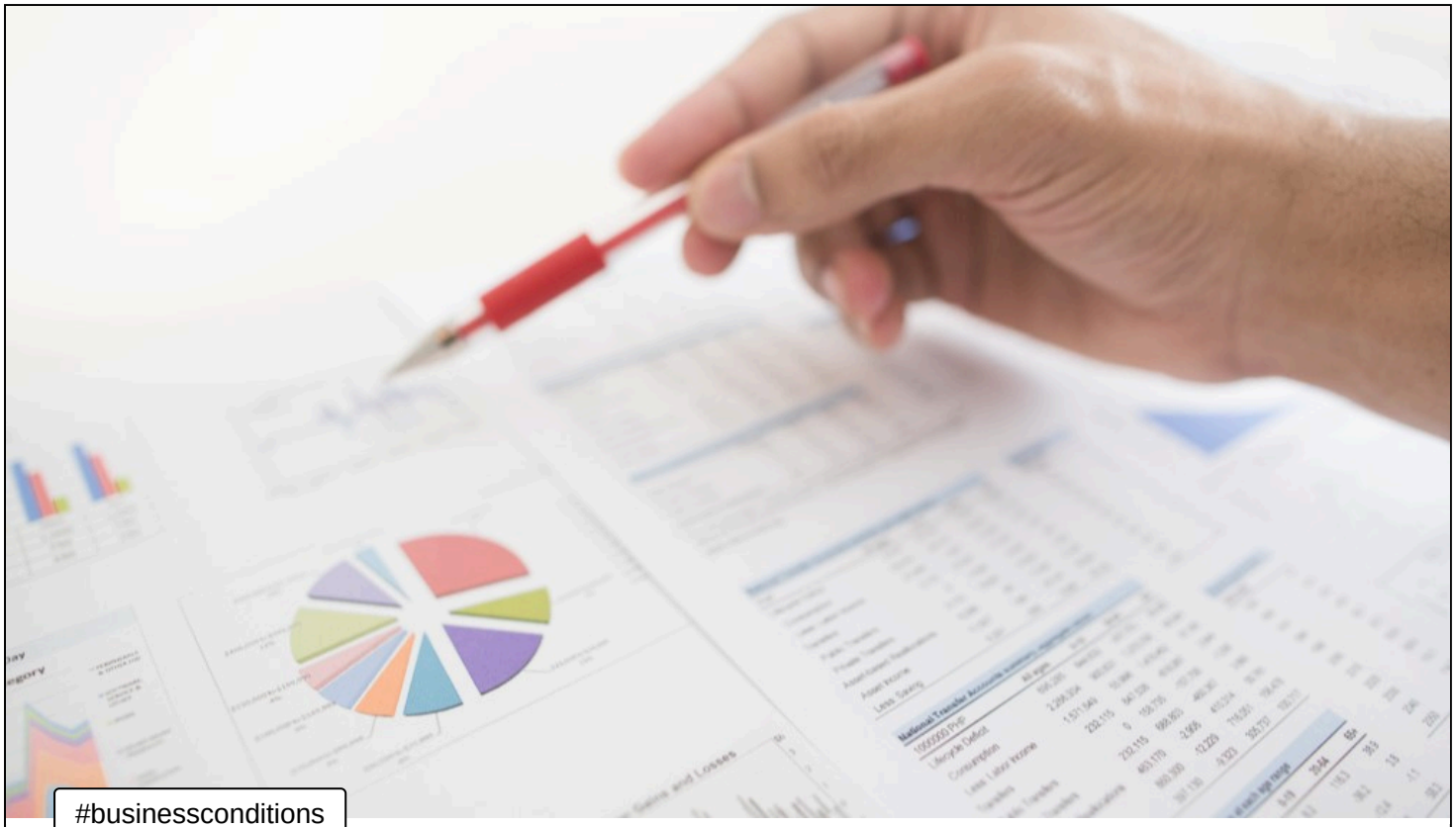

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October 13 2026 • 5 mins

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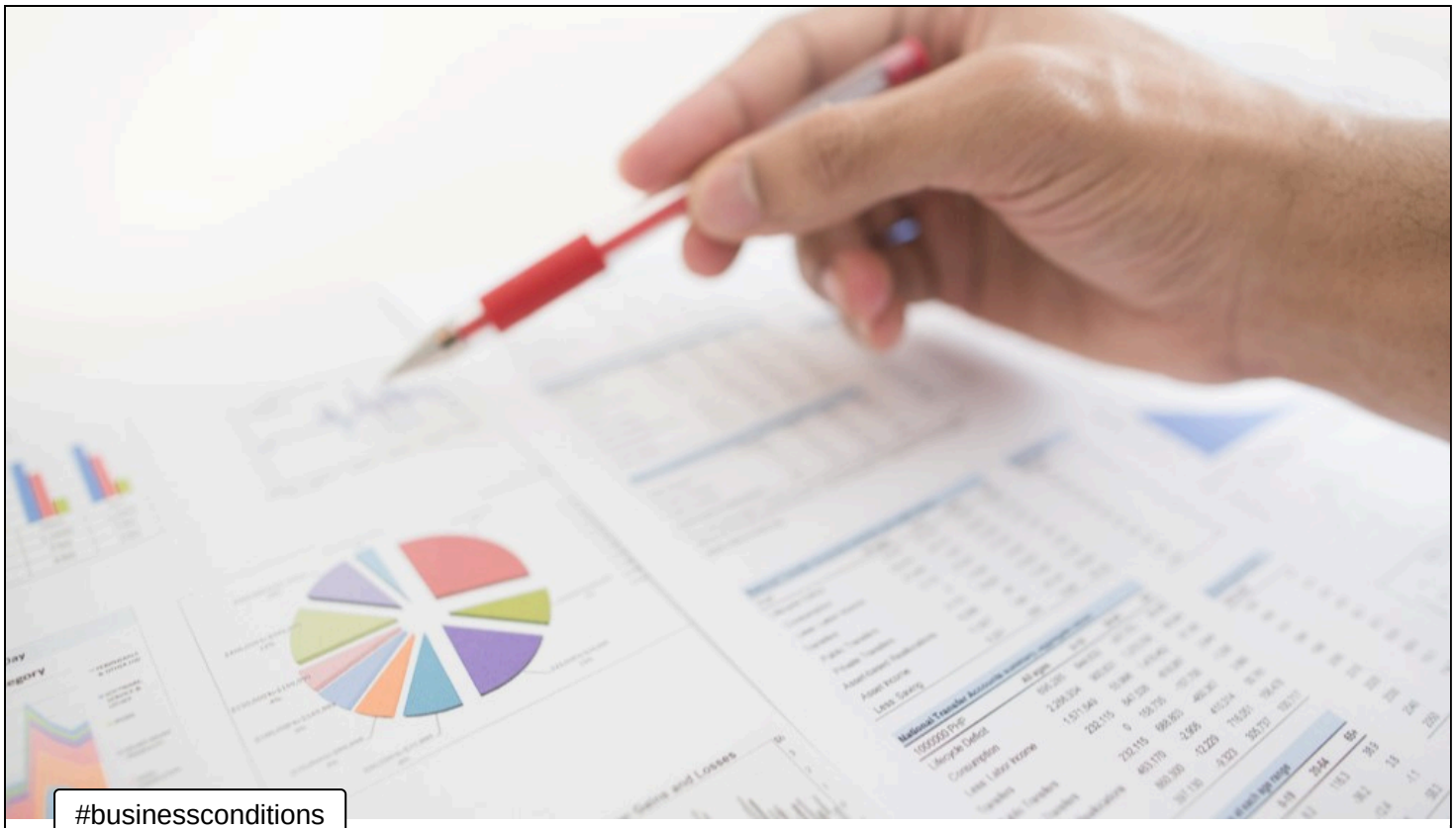

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Week beginning 12 October 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: When reality gets revised.

The Week That Was: Mulling the minutes.

Focus on New Zealand: Fuel, housing and the bumpy road ahead.

For the week ahead:

Australia: RBA minutes, business survey, labour force survey, Westpac-MI Leading Index.

New Zealand: monthly price indices, house prices and sales, retail card spending, manufacturing PMI.

China: CPI, PPI, trade balance.

Euro Area: industrial production, trade balance.

United Kingdom: BoE Governor Bailey speaking, monthly GDP.

United States: Columbus Day, FOMC Chair Warsh speaking, Beige Book, CPI, PPI, retail sales, industrial production, import prices, home sales.

Information contained in this report current as at 9 October 2026.

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When reality gets revised

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

- **Recent revisions to US PCE inflation, UK productivity and Canadian population estimates are reminders that statistical measurement is imperfect. Revisions are both a fact of life and, when they improve measurement, desirable.**
- **Australian data will also be revised over time, though not necessarily in the same ways as these latest revisions abroad. The ABS tends to favour quality over speed, which reduces the need for early revisions as more data become available. But revisions can still matter. Population estimates implied in the initial releases of labour market and GDP data are especially likely to be revised in the near term.**
- **Estimates of current trends can change as future data are published. Shifting seasonal patterns are another source of revision, especially for monthly CPI components with short histories. Series that are derived from multiple other imperfectly measured series are more prone to revision than quantities that can be measured directly. All these considerations point to a need for humility when using recent data to make strong policy pronouncements.**

On September 30, the Fed's preferred measure of inflation, PCE, was revised down. New methods and data sources were applied to three components of services inflation (financial advice, software and legal services), large enough to result in downward revisions to the overall read on core PCE inflation. These changes had been pre-announced in June and were therefore not a surprise. The CPI measure of inflation was not affected, nor should the revisions materially change your view of US inflationary pressures.

Some revisions are more consequential for interpretation and policy. A couple of weeks before the US PCE revision, it was revealed that the UK Office for National Statistics was revising down its estimates of average hours worked per worker. The result was that measured productivity growth was nowhere near as weak as had been widely believed. As my friend and counterpart, TS Lombard's Chief Economist Freya Beamish commented on social media, "Oh well. Not like any major policy decisions were taken on the basis of those numbers." Quite.

Also in September, Statistics Canada revised up its estimates of Canada's population, taking the recent growth rates from outright contraction to still-slow growth a little below ½%yr. The number of temporary residents in Canada is still falling, but the revised data do a better job of tracking them, especially those seeking an extension on their permit. (An alert for customers who have seen the cross-country population graph I often use at client events: the Canadian line now looks different but still shows a sharp slowing.)

> **"Economic data are often revised. Sometimes the revisions change the story; sometimes they do not."**

There is no fault to be attributed here. Revisions to key statistics are a part of economic life. Sometimes the underlying data arrive with a lag, perhaps because of reporting deadlines. Sometimes the compiling agency improves its methods or gains access to a better data source. The US and UK examples above fall into this category. In the Canadian case, better data and a more accurate definition of scope were involved. All these revisions should be welcomed. They provide a more accurate picture of the underlying reality.

Australia, revised

Revisions are a fact of life for Australian statistics, too. I am still a little scarred by that unexpected –0.5%qtr GDP print when the September quarter 2016 data were first released on my first day as RBA Assistant Governor; the figure has since been revised to 0%qtr and was followed by a big bounce-back in the December quarter.

The recent revisions mentioned above are less likely to be replicated in Australia, though. Australia's CPI is designed such that the headline (not seasonally adjusted) measure is never revised. This is because it is used in many legal contracts. If an error is detected, the ABS makes the adjustment in subsequent months and quarters rather than revising the history. Our labour force survey has a much higher response rate than its UK equivalent – Australians are a compliant lot when the ABS comes knocking – and measures actual hours worked more reliably. And our population statistics already handle the array of temporary resident visas with the Bureau instead applying a standard 12-month-in-16-month residency test to count as a resident for the population statistics rather than using a visa-classification basis.

This last case illustrates Australia's broader tendency to favour quality over speed in official statistics. Our CPI and national accounts data tend to be published a bit later than peer countries' data for the same reference period, and our

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estimated resident population data is quite a bit lagged relative to Canada's (the 12-month-in-16 criteria taking over a year to confirm). The trade-off is that observers of the Australian economy must wait longer but can be less worried about "flash" and "advance" releases of data that can be quickly revised to tell a completely different story.

Revisions to data still can matter in Australia, and it helps to be aware of the specific cases where it might occur. For example, precisely because the population data are very lagged, the population estimates underlying the initial releases of the labour force survey and national accounts are based on preliminary data and get revised later as a matter of routine. This is why ratios such as the unemployment, employment-to-population and participation rates provide a better real-time gauge of labour market conditions than the monthly change in employment. Similarly, GDP per capita can be revised even when GDP is not. This type of revision is also a more likely source of short-term changes in measured hours worked in the Australian productivity data than the conceptual change that shifted the UK data.

The usual reporting lags – and occasional correction of reporting errors by the reporting entity – will always be a factor in Australia just as it is in other countries. The annual national accounts, due on 23 October, incorporate additional data, revise the quarterly estimates and provide first estimates of important quantities such as the capital stock. Just as importantly, though, the annual accounts reconcile the different ways of measuring GDP. In doing so, what we thought we knew about the recent history of output growth can change.

Every purchase is also a sale, so conceptually, you should get the same answer for final output regardless of whether you count how much is produced, how much people spent on it, or how much income people got for producing it. In practice, though, the "production", "expenditure" and "income" approaches do not always line up until the ABS goes through a more thorough reconciliation process in compiling the annual accounts.

When the future changes the past

Future data can also change our view of the past. Two good examples are trend estimation and seasonal adjustment. Future observations help reveal whether an apparent trend is stable. As a result, real-time trend estimates can differ considerably from those calculated with the benefit of later data.

Identifying stable seasonal patterns also requires a reasonable run of data. Future observations affect whether an earlier movement is judged to be normal seasonal variation. This problem is more pronounced for newer series, where there is not yet enough history to establish what "normal" looks like.

Consider, then, the monthly CPI. This relatively new measure has only a short run of data with many individual components having too little history to use standard seasonal adjustment methods. As Westpac's senior economist Justin Smirk has previously highlighted, some components such as footwear are being 'seasonally adjusted' by applying Henderson trends, similar to those used in the 'trend' measures of labour market and national accounts data. For some other components, including books, furniture, audio-visual and computing equipment and children's clothes, certain price falls – usually associated with sales periods – are just arbitrarily removed from the seasonally adjusted series. The index is held at its previous month's level but otherwise matches the non-seasonally adjusted series.

The seasonally adjusted measures of these CPI components will inevitably be revised over time, and thus so could the monthly trimmed mean estimates. This helps explain why the RBA has said it would, for now, focus on the quarterly trimmed mean based on the old seasonal factors. That measure will at least not be buffeted by shifting measurement of seasonality in a short history. If seasonal patterns are themselves also shifting, the current underlying trend might look a bit different in a few years, not just a smoother month-to-month profile.

The broader point here is to remember that economic statistics are a lens on reality. Sometimes the lens is smudged, sometimes the scope is off and sometimes what is being read as underlying trends is wrong. Measures constructed from several imperfect series – productivity from output and hours worked, or unit labour costs from productivity and labour costs, or savings rates derived from income and spending – are especially prone to revision compared with concepts that can be measured more directly, like a price. That is a strong argument for humility before making firm policy pronouncements based on simple data comparisons.

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Cliff Notes: mulling the minutes

Sian Fenner, Head of Business and Industry Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist
Illiana Jain, Economist

The only data release of note in Australia this week was the October Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment Survey, which reported a 4.7% drop in the headline index. At 80.4, sentiment has tumbled back to deeply pessimistic levels, similar to the post-pandemic cost-of-living shock when readings were among the weakest in the survey's more than fifty-year history. Indeed, inflation and interest rate pressures are once again clearly front of mind for consumers, with both the view on 'family finances vs a year ago' and 'family finance next 12 months' falling 8.0% and 6.4% in the month, respectively. Moreover, the RBA's September rate hike looks to have had a significant impact – sentiment tanked 20% between those surveyed before the RBA decision and those surveyed afterwards.

Views on the economic outlook were relatively more resilient, but they still weakened, with the one-year and five-year ahead sub-indexes falling 1.6% and 0.4% respectively. Consumers are becoming more 'on edge' about job security, albeit not outright alarmed. The unemployment rate remains relatively low versus history, although it has drifted up to a cycle high of 4.6% as labour supply continues to outstrip demand. We expect it to hold there in next week's September Labour Force Survey – see our preview for more detail. All told, with higher interest rates, renewed inflation pressures and a softening jobs market all weighing at once, households are entering the final months of the year on the back foot.

Offshore, the focus was on US data.

Before turning to this week's releases, it is worth noting that September non-farm payrolls came in softer than expected across most metrics. Employment rose by only 29k (89k expected), and there were sizeable downward revisions to prior months, with a combined 60k removed from July and August payrolls, leaving gains of just 31k and 29k respectively. The details pointed to weaker hiring in leisure & hospitality and education & health services industries, although construction and manufacturing employment continued to benefit from ongoing data-centre-related investment. The unemployment rate edged up to 4.2%, with softer employment occurring alongside a rise in labour force participation to 61.8%. Meanwhile wage growth moderated to 0.1%mth (3.0%yr). Taken together, the report suggests labour demand is cooling, with the three-month average pace of job creation slowing to around 50k. However, softer payroll gains are not necessarily indicative of labour market deterioration. Lower immigration and ageing demographics have reduced the pace of employment growth needed to keep the unemployment rate stable. As such, the report is more consistent with a labour market that is gradually normalising than one entering a meaningful downturn.

The September FOMC minutes reinforced a distinctly hawkish message, with participants noting they had "not seen sufficient progress on lowering inflation in recent months" and expressing concern that inflation risks remained "skewed to the upside". Policymakers highlighted that both core services and core goods inflation remained elevated, with some attributing persistent goods price strength to the effects of the AI buildout despite the sector's traditional disinflationary role. There was also concern that, after more than five years of inflation above target, elevated inflation could begin to influence inflation expectations and wage- and price-setting behaviour. In contrast, labour market conditions were generally viewed as stable and "close to maximum employment". While a majority noted the labour market had strengthened somewhat recently, several participants highlighted unusually low dynamism, characterised by low hiring, low layoffs, a low job-finding rate and elevated long-term unemployment. Importantly, participants generally judged that aggregate wage growth was moderate and "consistent with inflation moving toward 2 percent", with several explicitly noting that "the labor market was not currently a source of inflationary pressures".

> **"A key focus was the interaction between AI investment, productive capacity and inflation."**

While participants broadly expected AI-related investment to boost productivity growth and potential output over time, several warned that "the AI buildout could cause aggregate demand to outpace aggregate supply over the medium term, putting upward pressure on inflation". Consistent with this view, some participants had raised their estimate of the neutral policy rate and several judged the current policy stance to be "not restrictive or only mildly restrictive". Against this backdrop, all participants supported the September rate increase, and most assessed that another increase in the federal funds rate would likely be appropriate by year-end, although future decisions would remain data dependent.

The September ISM Services PMI released this week painted a similar picture of an economy that remains resilient but is gradually losing momentum. The headline index eased to 54.9 from 55.4 in August, with the decline driven by a sharp fall in business activity and a 9.4pt drop in new export orders, which slipped into contractionary territory for the first time in eight

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months. Labour market conditions improved modestly with the employment index moving to broadly neutral territory 50.1 after two months below 50, supported by elevated backlogs and still-solid demand. Respondent commentary illustrated the mixed nature of labour demand, with some firms reporting they were "filling positions vacated due to promotions or retirements", while others cited "restructuring due to efficiencies gained using AI tools". Cost pressures also remained elevated, with the prices paid index rising to 74.0, its highest level since July 2022 and around 18pts above its historical average, while fuel costs, tariffs and supply chain constraints remained the most frequently cited concerns. Overall, the report suggests services activity remains consistent with ongoing expansion, albeit at a slower pace, while labour demand and pricing pressures remain firm.

Overall, the data supports our view that the FOMC will move to a broadly neutral policy stance by the end of the year with one more rate hike, although the case for a back-to-back move in October has become less clear cut.

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Fuel, housing and the bumpy road ahead

Kelly Eckhold
Chief Economist NZ

Higher fuel costs, a weaker exchange rate, and a softer housing market have prompted a refresh of our near-term forecasts. Inflation looks set to finish 2026 above 4%, while growth could lose a little momentum into year-end. Even so, we continue to expect the RBNZ to pause in October before lifting the OCR to 3% in December.

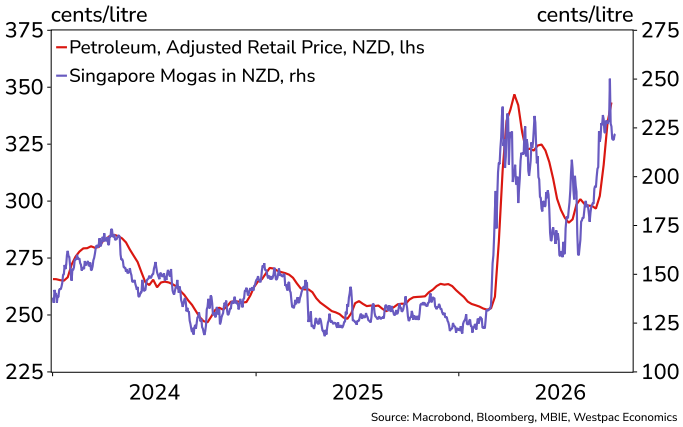
New Zealand's recovery is still moving forward, but the road has become rougher. Since our last forecast update in August, global oil and refined-fuel prices have climbed sharply, the New Zealand dollar has fallen, and longer-term interest rates have moved higher. At home, the housing market has remained weaker than we anticipated. None of those developments, on their own, are enough to derail the recovery. Together, however, they point to a tougher finish to 2026 for households and businesses. We have therefore revisited our near-term inflation, housing and growth forecasts. The broad story remains one of continued economic expansion and gradually improving labour demand, but with a more pronounced inflation spike and slightly less momentum in consumer spending. Our OCR call is unchanged: a pause at the October review, followed by a 25 basis point increase to 3% at the December Monetary Policy Statement.

A temporary inflation reprieve

We continue to think that consumer prices rose 0.7% in the September quarter. That would lower annual inflation from 4.1% in June to 3.7% in September, broadly consistent with the monthly price updates published so far. The final monthly release for the quarter is due on 16 October and will help firm up that estimate. But any easing in the annual rate is likely to prove short-lived. We now expect prices to rise 1.1% in the December quarter, lifting annual inflation to a three-year high of 4.2% by year-end. That is half a percentage point above our previous projection and above the RBNZ's September forecast of 3.9%.

The reason is easy to see at the petrol pump. Higher global fuel prices have been amplified by a more than 4% fall in the New Zealand dollar since the start of September. Local petrol prices have risen by around 50 cents a litre over the past month, with the nationwide average price of 91 unleaded reaching a record $3.55 a litre this week. RBNZ Governor Breman acknowledged a couple of weeks ago that higher oil prices have tilted the risks around the near-term inflation outlook to the upside. Importantly, however, the RBNZ remains focused on the medium-term inflation outlook rather than trying to offset every movement in volatile fuel prices.

Singapore 91 Mogas vs NZ 91 retail petrol price



Source: Macrobond, Bloomberg, MBIE, Westpac Economics

For now, we have left our quarterly inflation forecasts for 2027 unchanged. Even so, the higher starting point at the end of this year means annual inflation is likely to remain firm through much of 2027. Our updated profile has inflation at 3.7% in March 2027, 2.6% in June, 2.5% in September and 1.7% in December. That is broadly similar to the RBNZ's path through the first three quarters, although our forecast falls more quickly late in the year. We will take a fuller look at the 2027 inflation and growth outlook next week alongside the monthly Market Outlook.

Housing fails to find its feet

The housing market has also delivered a disappointment. We had expected prices to stabilise through the second half of 2026, but sales volumes have continued to weaken, and the median time required to sell a property has lengthened to 48 days. Average prices have kept edging lower, despite firmer conditions in parts of the South Island with greater exposure to the strong export economy. The latest indicators do not suggest that a decisive turn is close. We have therefore revised our forecast for national house price growth in 2026 from a 0.6% rise to a 1.4% decline. That incorporates quarterly falls of 0.5% in September and 0.8% in December.

The headwinds are familiar: the labour market remains soft, mortgage rates are higher and employment growth is still moderate. Those forces are likely to keep the market subdued for some time, with risks tilted towards another weak year in 2027. Changes to the taxation of capital gains on investor housing following the 2026 General Election may add another potential drag.

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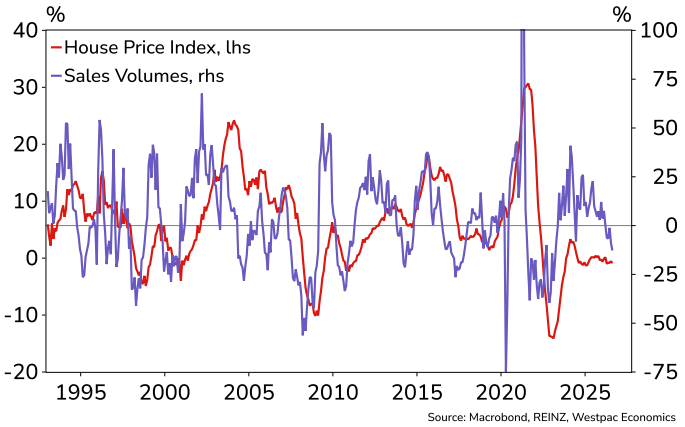
Annual % change in house prices vs sales



Source: Macrobond, REINZ, Westpac Economics

Regional outcomes will continue to differ. Tourism- and agriculture-focused areas should benefit from stronger income and employment growth, supported by robust commodity export prices. We have lifted our 2026/27 Fonterra Milk Price forecast to $9.75/kg and set an opening forecast of $9.50/kg for 2027/28. In contrast, homeowners in the major North Island cities may have to wait longer for the wealth boost that comes with rising property values. Data released this week shows that household wealth continues to be dragged down by declining housing values.

A little less momentum

The weaker housing backdrop matters for the wider economy. When petrol absorbs more of the household budget and home values are drifting lower, consumers tend to become more cautious. That combination is likely to crimp discretionary spending in the run-up to Christmas and could take some steam out of the construction recovery. That's even though our own card spending data for September showed resilience in consumer spending. Recent business and consumer confidence surveys have nevertheless remained resilient despite the rise in energy prices and long-term interest rates. Our short-term growth forecasts therefore remain broadly intact, but we have trimmed our December quarter consumer spending projection and now expect GDP growth of 2.5% over 2026. That is still a solid result, although the balance of risks has shifted to the downside.

There are several moving parts to watch. Sustained high fuel prices would squeeze household purchasing power more than we have allowed for. The sharp lift in long-term interest rates may also weigh on activity through 2027, even if shorter-term borrowing costs evolve as expected. The election result introduces two-sided risks that are difficult to quantify before the shape and timing of policy changes are known. Against that, strong agricultural incomes and signs of improving employment growth should provide a buffer. We have not changed our 2026 labour market forecasts. Hiring appears to be strengthening gradually, but it will take time before that improvement translates into a noticeable fall in the unemployment rate.

The RBNZ should still pause before Christmas

Despite the higher near-term inflation track, we are not changing our OCR forecast. Since the July Monetary Policy Review, our view has been that the RBNZ would slow the pace of increases as the OCR approached the Bank's estimate of a neutral 3%. The September meeting clearly signalled a pause in October and one further rise in December. We continue to regard that as the most likely path. The latest developments raise headline inflation but, so far, there is little evidence that inflation expectations are moving higher or that the fuel shock is generating broader, persistent price pressure. At the same time, growth risks warrant some caution.

A pause in October would give the Monetary Policy Committee time to assess the cumulative effect of the increases already delivered and to refine its strategy for 2027. Financial conditions have also tightened from an unexpected source: longer-term interest rates have risen markedly over the past six weeks. That increase has at least offset the easing impulse from the lower exchange rate, even though the weaker currency is adding to imported inflation in the near term. We still think the RBNZ is likely to have more work to do in 2027, but there is plenty of data to come before that judgement needs to be made.

For now, the best description of the outlook is resilient but less comfortable. Export incomes remain strong, activity is expanding and the labour market is beginning to improve. But households face an awkward combination of record petrol prices, soft home values and higher borrowing costs. That mix points to a bumpy end to the year: inflation will be hotter, spending growth a little cooler and the recovery more uneven across regions. The RBNZ can afford to wait in October, but if the economy develops broadly as we expect, a further hike to 3% in December will still be needed.

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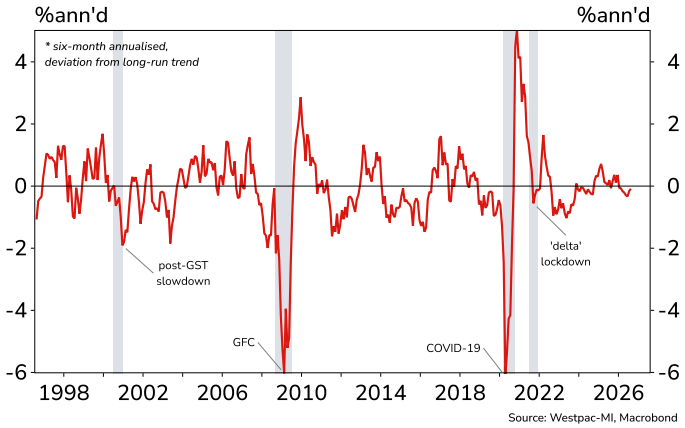
AUS: Sep Westpac MI Leading Index (%ann'd)

Oct 13, Last: –0.09

The Leading Index growth rate lifted to –0.09% in August from –0.17% in July. Momentum has improved to be just a touch below trend, consistent with soft rather than weak growth.

The September read looks likely to be another soft one. Component-wise, sentiment-based measures continued to deteriorate in response to higher fuel price another RBA rate hike while dwelling approvals also recorded a decline and both equity and labour markets softened further. Commodity prices ticked up and the yield spread also widened slightly as rising bond yields outpaced short term rates.

Westpac-MI Leading Index



Source: Westpac-MI, Macrobond

AUS: Sep Labour Force – Employment Change (000s)

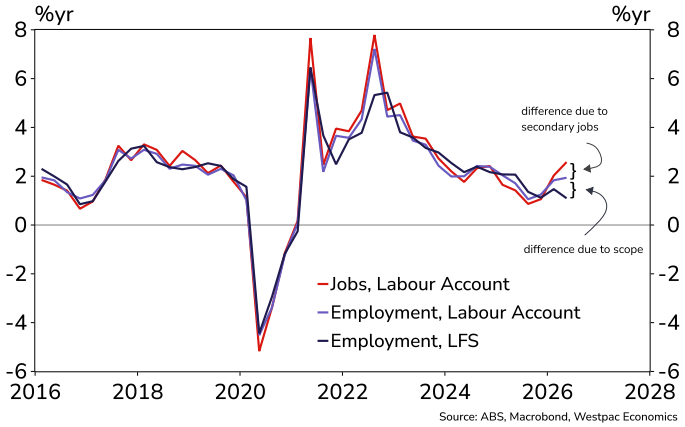
Oct 15, Last: 39.5, Westpac f/c: 20
Market f/c: 20, Range: flat to 35

Employment surprised to the upside in August with a 39k gain. Looking through the monthly swings, while momentum has improved over recent months, employment growth has largely continued to bump around below its historic average and the current pace of working age population growth.

Our preview provides a deeper look into the various gauges of labour demand – the LFS suggests employment growth is sluggish but broader measures in the Q2 Labour Account showed a stronger narrative. Meanwhile job ads and business surveys are also pulling in different directions.

For September, we have pencilled in a lift in employment of +20k, which would see annual growth hold in recent ranges.

Jobs vs. Employment Growth



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: Sep Labour Force – Unemployment Rate (%)

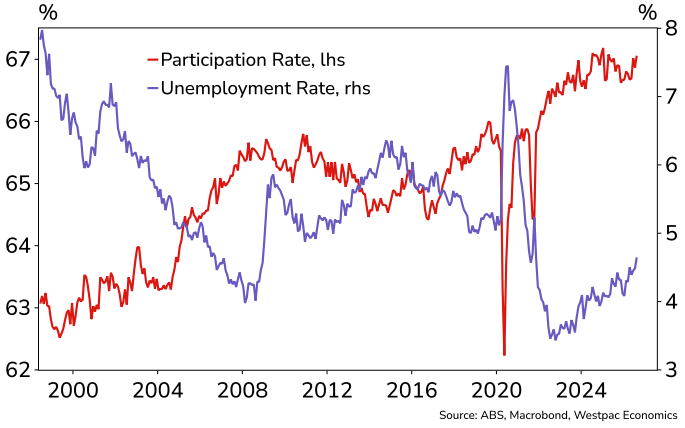
Oct 15, Last: 4.6, Westpac f/c: 4.6
Market f/c: 4.6, Range: 4.5 to 4.7

The participation rate jumped to 67.1% in August, just under the 115-year high recorded in January 2025. With labour supply once again outstripping demand, the unemployment rate rose from 4.5% to 4.6% – the highest since in late-2021, close to rounding up to 4.7% (4.646% at three decimal places).

A softer economy and sub-par employment growth typically discourages some people to search for work, but cost-of-living pressures and interest rate rises are more than outweighing this effect, encouraging more people into the labour market.

With the participation rate expected to pare back to 67.0%, we think the unemployment rate will hold steady at 4.6%. Please see our preview for more detail.

Participation and unemployment rates



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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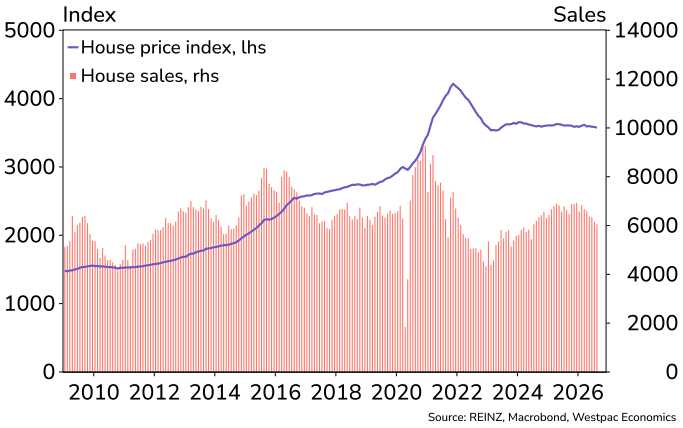
NZ: Sep REINZ House Sales and Prices (%ann)

Oct 14, Sales Last: –13.0, Prices Last: –0.9

The housing market has remained soft in recent months, with sales falling to a two-year low and prices edging lower. Mortgage rates have risen as the RBNZ has initiated a new tightening cycle, and a growing supply of unsold homes on the market means that buyers are under no pressure to bid prices higher. Conditions remain stronger in the south, with prices up on last year in Canterbury, Otago and Southland, while Auckland and Wellington are the weakest markets.

REINZ house sales and prices



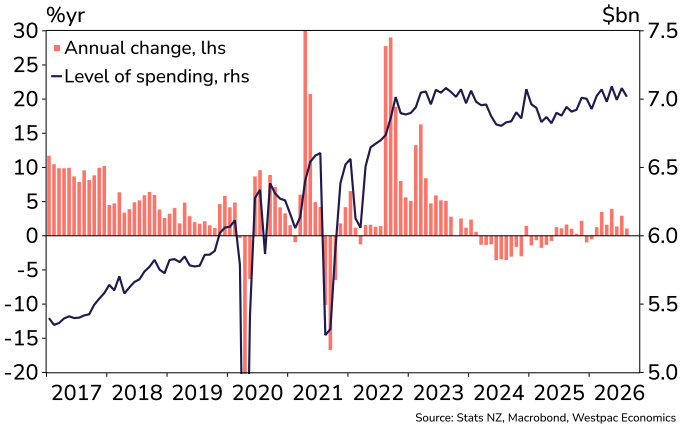
Source: REINZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Sep Retail Card Spending (%mth)

Oct 16, Last: –0.9, Westpac f/c: 0.8

We're forecasting a 0.8% rise in retail spending in September, reversing the 0.9% fall seen in the previous month. In part, the forecast rise in spending is due to the sharp increases in petrol prices in recent weeks. Those higher fuel costs are weighing on spending in other categories like hospitality. Nevertheless, we still expect a 0.5% rise in core (ex-fuel) spending. Stats NZ's monthly retail spending figures have been very choppy for the past two years, and we're likely to see a bounce following last month's unexpected falls in categories like furnishings.

NZ retail card spending



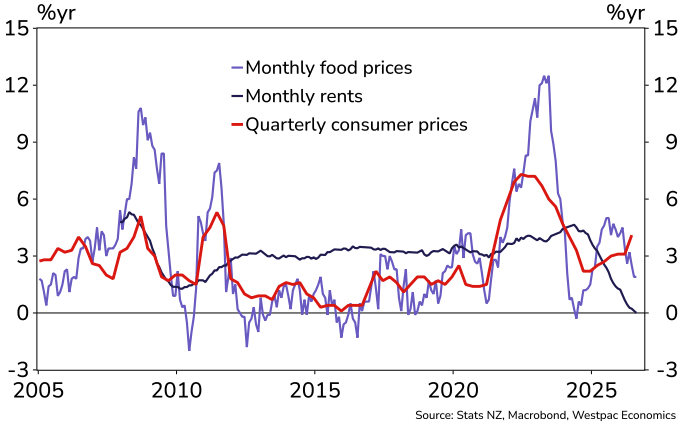
Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Sep Selected Consumer Prices (%mth)

Oct 16

This will be the last monthly update ahead of the full quarterly CPI release on 22 October. We're currently forecasting a 0.7% quarterly rise in the CPI (+3.7%yr) and will be watching the detail of the Selected Prices update to pin down that forecast. In terms of the big categories, we're forecasting a roughly 6% rise in petrol costs, along with a 0.7% rise in food prices. That's balanced against continued softness in housing rents (which are the single largest component of the CPI). The key sources of risk for our forecast are the volatile travel categories, most of which recorded sizeable drops last month that we expect to partially reverse in September.

NZ selected consumer prices



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Mon 12							
US		Columbus Day	–	–	–	–	Stock markets open, bond markets closed.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Hammack.
Tue 13							
Aus	Sep	RBA Minutes	–	–	–	–	Markets will look for guidance on the policy outlook.
	Sep	NAB Business Conditions	index	–1	–	–	Conditions have eased to their weakest level since the pandemic.
US	Sep	NFIB Small Business Optimism	index	98.7	98.0	–	Confidence has recovered since onset of Middle East conflict.
	Sep	Existing Home Sales	%mth	–2.0	–0.8	–	Housing demand remains constrained by affordability.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Waller, Barkin, Collins.
Wed 14							
Aus	Sep	Westpac–MI Leading Index	%ann'd	–0.09	–	–	Consistent with soft, rather than weak growth.
NZ	Sep	REINZ House Prices	%yr	–0.9	–	–	Buyer enthusiasm dampened by rising mortgage rates...
	Sep	REINZ House Sales	%yr	–13.0	–	–	...and an ample supply of homes on the market.
	Aug	Net Migration	no.	3010	–	–	Balance has turned more positive as NZer departures slow.
Chn	Sep	PPI	%ann	3.8	4.4	–	China's inflation pick–up appears increasingly supply–led ...
	Sep	CPI	%ann	0.8	1.0	–	... while consumer inflation remains subdued.
	Sep	Trade Balance	US$bn	119.1	117.3	–	The AI boom continues to buoy Chinese exports.
US	Sep	CPI	%mth	0.4	0.6	–	Iran war, tariffs and data centre buildout are adding pressure.
	Oct	Federal Reserve's Beige Book	–	–	–	–	Update on economic conditions across the regions.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Bowman, Barkin.
Thu 15							
Aus	Sep	Employment Change	000s	39.5	20	20	Labour demand absorbing much of the additional supply ...
	Sep	Unemployment Rate	%	4.6	4.6	4.6	... but not enough to prevent unemployment from drifting up.
Jpn	Aug	Core Machinery Orders	%mth	–3.7	2.9	–	Business investment momentum remains uneven.
	Aug	Industrial Production	%mth	–1.7	–	–	Final estimate.
Eur	Aug	Industrial Production	%mth	–0.1	0.1	–	Manufacturing activity continues to struggle.
UK	Aug	Monthly GDP	%mth	0.4	–	–	July's rise showed surprising resilience.
US	Sep	Retail Sales	%mth	1.2	0.3	–	Focus is on the underlying health of the consumer.
	Oct	Phily Fed Manufacturing	index	37.8	26.4	–	Sentiment bounced notably; Phily leads the regions.
		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	197	–	–	Claims remain low and stable.
	Sep	PPI	%mth	0.4	0.5	–	Pipeline inflation pressures remain contained.
	Aug	Business Inventories	%mth	0.8	0.4	–	Inventory accumulation picked up in July.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Hammack.
Fri 16							
NZ	Sep	Manufacturing PMI	index	53.1	–	–	A relatively strong performing sector in recent months.
	Sep	Selected Price Indices – Food	%mth	0.3	–	0.7	Seasonal increases in meat and beverage prices.
	Sep	Selected Price Indices – Rents	%mth	0.0	–	0.0	Ample supply continuing to limit rental growth.
	Sep	Retail Card Spending	%mth	–0.9	–	0.8	Expected to bounce following last month's unexpected fall.
Eur	Aug	Trade Balance	€bn	5.0	–	–	Exporters continue to diversify beyond the US.
	Sep	CPI	%ann	3.8	3.8	–	Final estimate.
UK		BoE Governor Bailey	–	–	–	–	Fireside chat with Institute of International Finance.
US		FOMC Chair Warsh	–	–	–	–	Fireside chat at IMF Annual Meetings, 2:30pm AEST.
	Sep	Import Price Index	%mth	0.7	0.6	–	AI hardware and commodity price volatility are driving the rise.
	Sep	Industrial Production	%mth	0.0	0.4	–	Manufacturing output growth remains patchy.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (9 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.60	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.77	4.95	4.95	4.80	4.55	4.30	4.10	3.95	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.92	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.90	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.35	5.20	5.10	5.00	4.90	4.85	4.80	4.80	4.80	4.80
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	12	40	35	30	25	15	5	0	–5	–10
United States										
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	5.23	4.80	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.70	4.75	4.80	4.85	4.90
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.22	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	4.00	3.95	4.10	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	5.05	4.75	4.90	5.00	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–18	–5	15	30	40	35	30	25	20	15

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (9 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
AUD/USD	0.6976	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5618	0.59	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.65
USD/JPY	158.07	155	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146
EUR/USD	1.1226	1.17	1.18	1.19	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3239	1.35	1.36	1.37	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40
USD/CNY	6.6917	6.70	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2417	1.22	1.19	1.16	1.14	1.12	1.12	1.11	1.11	1.11

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.4	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.1	1.4	1.5	1.4	1.4	1.6	2.6	1.4	1.6	2.5
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	0.5	0.7	0.6	0.7	0.4	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	3.7	3.0	3.0	2.5	2.4	3.6	3.7	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	0.9	0.7	0.8	0.7	0.6	0.6	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.5	3.3	3.2	3.1	2.8	2.7	3.3	3.3	2.7	2.3

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.7	1.1	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.5	2.6	2.7	2.8	0.3	2.4	2.8	3.1
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.2	5.1	4.9	5.4	5.4	4.9	4.4
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	1.1	0.4	0.4	0.6	0.3	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	4.2	3.7	2.6	2.5	1.7	3.1	4.2	1.7	2.1

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AGRI BITES

Dairy prices mooving higher.

8 October 2026

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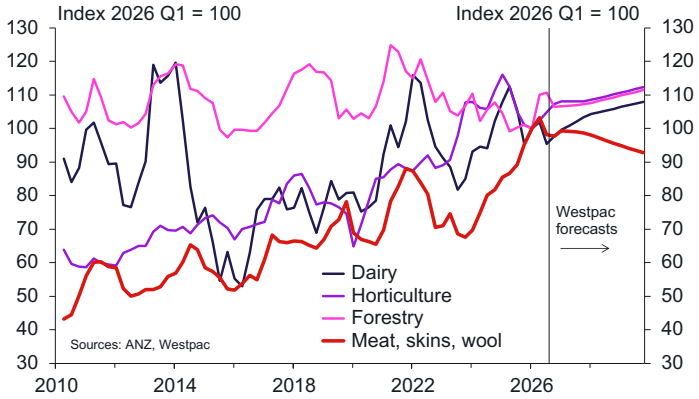
SUMMARY

Despite risk, agricultural export prices to remain elevated.

- Ongoing Middle East tensions are increasing volatility and raising energy, input and shipping costs, while broadly supporting prices for agricultural products. Impacts vary depending on idiosyncratic supply and demand conditions.
- Risks are exacerbated by the impact of a now confirmed super-sized El Niño, which could slice off up to 1ppt of New Zealand's GDP should on-farm production of both milk and meat contract significantly.
- We have revised up our farmgate milk price forecast for this season by 25c to $9.75/kg, with milk powder prices holding up better than we expected. El Niño presents a clear upside risk to this, as it does not appear to have been reflected in GDT auction prices to date.
- Meanwhile average New Zealand beef export prices should remain elevated over the coming year, as lean trimming prices reverse recent declines. Sheepmeat prices are set to ease on rising Australian supply, but remain at elevated levels.
- Kiwifruit and apple export prices are expected to remain elevated, supported by strong demand for premium varieties, although increasing supply is likely to keep prices largely flat rather than drive further gains.
- Export prices for New Zealand logs are set to remain broadly stable to slightly firmer, supported by lower log supply and balanced Chinese inventories.

Commodity prices – World and NZ dollar denominated

Commodity prices by category

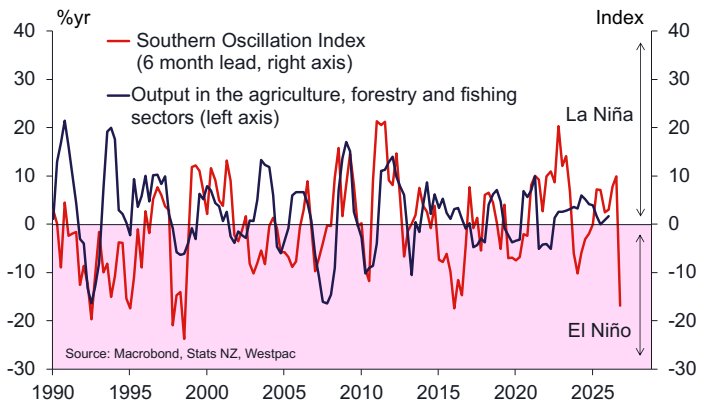


UPDATE ON EL NIÑO

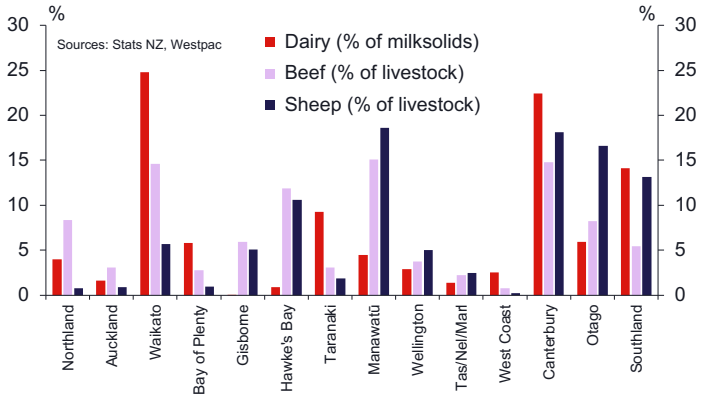
Farming is well placed to navigate impacts of a strong El Niño.

- Scientists have now confirmed that the current El Niño event will be the strongest on record. Temperatures in the Pacific Ocean are now 3.05C above the average, exceeding the record set in 2015.
- A supersized El Niño increases the probability of drier weather in eastern regions of New Zealand in coming months, with wetter conditions likelier in the west and southern areas of the country.
- The potential impact on GDP could be significant. Our previous research has shown a severe drought could slice off as much as 1ppt from economic growth.
- Much of that is will reflect lower agriculture production, particularly in dairy, sheep and beef farms. Increased on-farm costs and processing disruptions are also likely.
- A 1% loss in GDP is likely an upper end estimate of the El Niño impact. A key consideration is soil moisture levels are currently high, implying some resilience to future drier conditions.
- Farming practices have become more resilient to prolonged dry periods. Irrigation is more widely used than in past dry periods and snowmelt levels appear robust, which should be of particular benefit to Canterbury farms.

Southern Oscillation Index vs GDP: Agri, forestry, fishing



Agricultural activity by region

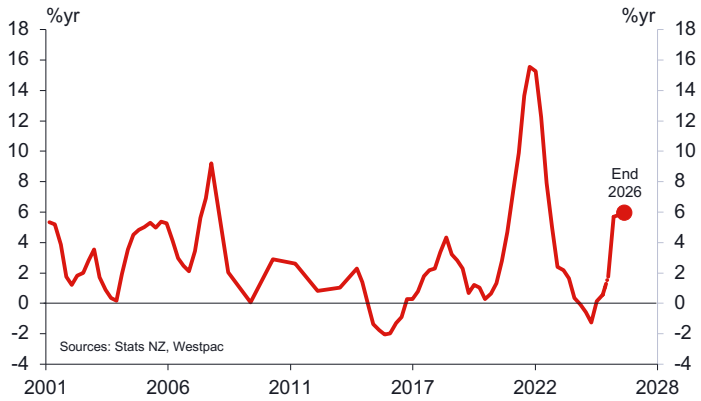


INPUT COSTS

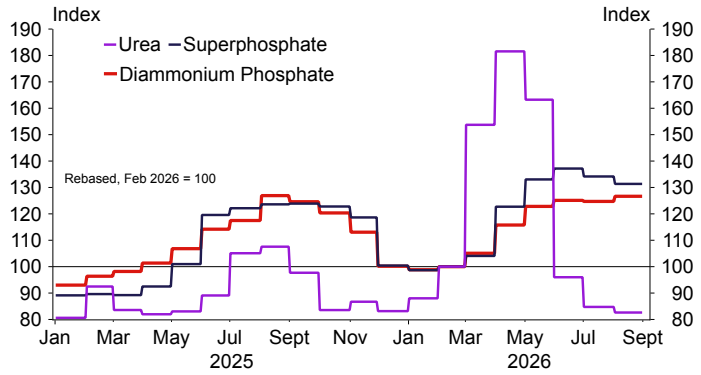
Conflict-related disruptions could push input costs higher than expected.

- Farm input costs are on the rise reflecting two key drivers: fuel and fertiliser costs.
- Diesel and petrol prices have increased by about 50% compared to the same period in 2025. While average prices fell in the September quarter, they closed the quarter at an elevated level as tensions between the US and Iran increased and broadened to encompass Saudi Arabia and the Yemeni Houthis.
- Fertiliser prices are also significantly higher. While the fertiliser market has stabilised after a period of extreme volatility earlier this year, prices remain highly sensitive to developments in the Middle East.
- Nitrogen (urea) prices have fallen substantially from a mid-year spike, with an pick up in Chinese exports now boosting supply. These prices though remain vulnerable to supply disruptions.
- By contrast, phosphate and other sulphur-based fertiliser prices are tracking higher and remain at elevated levels, as supply constraints, trade restrictions and disruptions to shipping offset the impact of softening demand in some regions of the world.

Farm input expenses



Crude and derivative product prices



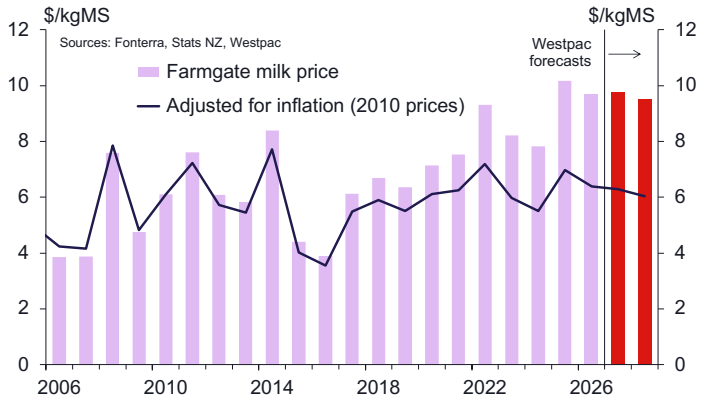
Sources: Macrobond, ICE, CME Group, SGX, World Bank, Westpac

DAIRY

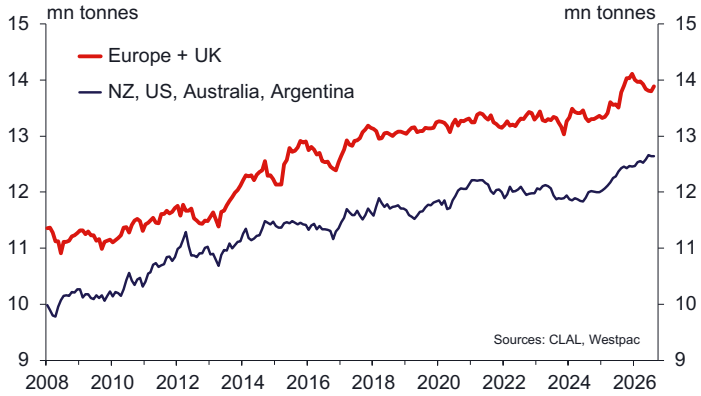
Farmgate milk price forecast revised up on strong protein demand.

- We have revised up our farmgate milk price forecast for this season by 25c to $9.75/kg. This is above Fonterra's forecast midpoint of $9.50/kg (range of $8.50-10.50), but lower than futures market pricing of just over $10/kg.
- We have also opened our forecast for the 2027/28 season at $9.50/kg. Note that there is a wide margin of uncertainty around the forecast at this stage, and we will review as the next season approaches.
- Dairy prices at auction have generally held up better than our expectations, although the performance has varied across products. Trends in global demand are shifting away from fats and towards proteins, which has boosted demand and prices for skim milk powder in particular.
- Our forecasts do not include an assumption about the impact of El Niño, which presents a clear upside risk to prices and a downside risk to volumes. While the futures market is pricing a strong lift in milk powder prices over the New Zealand summer, there has been no apparent urgency to buy at the GDT auction. Fonterra is forecasting a 2% lift in milk volumes over the rest of this season, on top of what was already a strong increase last season.
- Global milk production also remains ample, although it has slowed in Europe in recent months. El Niño is less likely to affect conditions among the major producers in the Northern Hemisphere.

Farmgate milk price



Milk production by top exporting regions

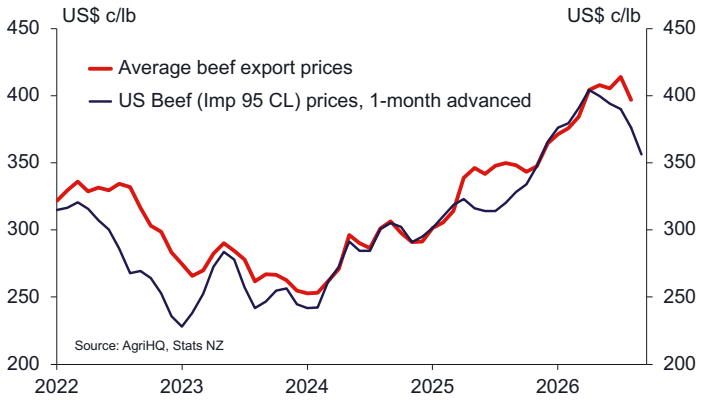


BEEF

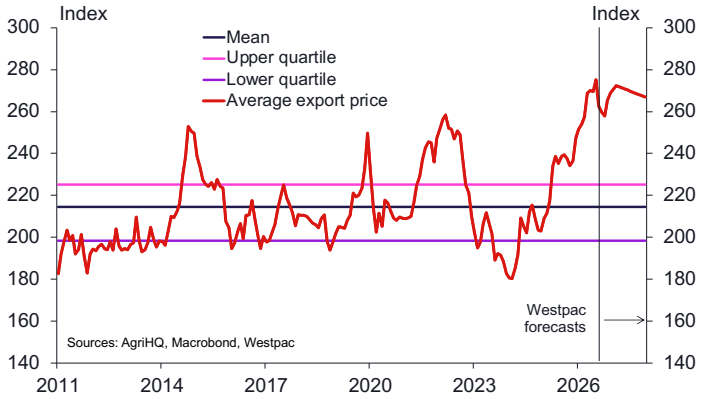
Export beef prices to remain elevated over the next year.

- Beef export prices remain well supported but have softened in recent months. The weakness has been concentrated in lean beef trimming prices, which have eased since April as high US prices attracted additional imports, particularly from South America, while tariff-free quotas temporarily boosted product availability.
- In contrast, premium beef prices have remained firm, supported by tight global supplies of high-quality beef, constrained US cattle numbers, and resilient demand in higher-end retail and foodservice channels.
- We expect that lean trimming prices will reverse recent declines in coming months as temporary increases in supply begin to fade and underlying shortages, including the historically small US beef herd, re-emerge.
- In 2027, lean trimming prices should remain elevated but broadly flat as strong US demand and a small US cattle herd are largely offset by rising global production. From 2028 onwards, expanding global beef production gradually eases market conditions, putting pressure on prices.
- Meanwhile, favourable supply/demand fundamentals to support premium beef prices in 2027, with expanding global production to weigh on prices from 2028.
- Overall, beef export prices are likely to remain high, although both nominal and real prices are expected to moderate over the medium term.

Average monthly beef export prices - nominal



Average monthly beef export prices - real

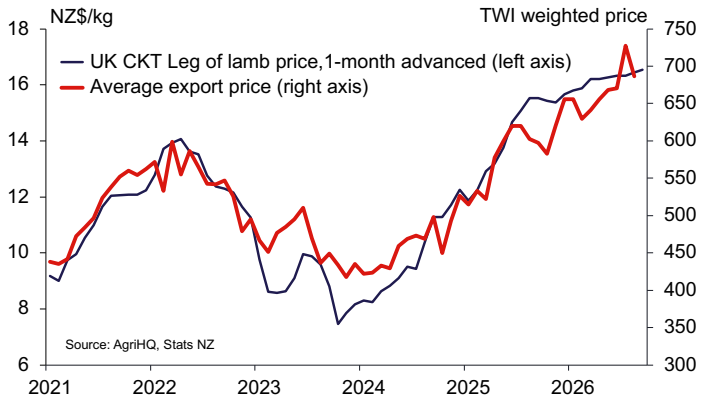


SHEEP MEAT

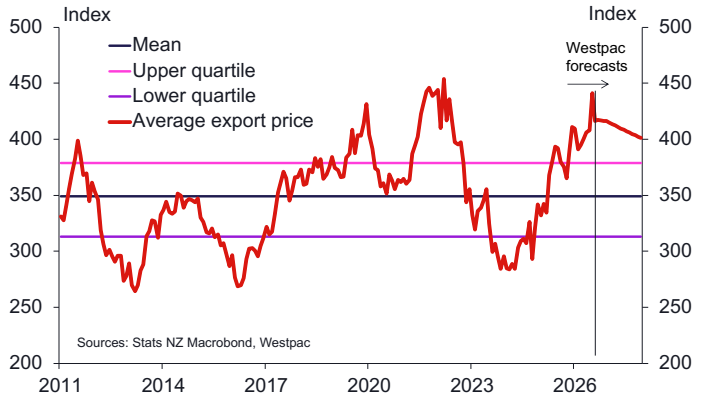
Lamb export prices to remain firm, but off recent highs.

- NZ sheepmeat export prices remain near record highs, supported by constrained global supply and resilient demand from premium markets in Europe, the UK and North America. Export values rose strongly through 2025/26 despite only modest growth in export volumes, highlighting the strength of underlying prices.
- Global supply remains tight due to declining sheep flocks and lower slaughter numbers in New Zealand, the UK and parts of Europe. However, rising Australian production and exports are expected to gradually lift global supply and increase competition in key export markets, limiting further price gains.
- Meanwhile, stronger demand from the UK, EU and North America has improved export returns and reduced New Zealand's reliance on China, where economic weakness has made consumers more price sensitive and encouraged a shift towards cheaper proteins and cuts.
- The outlook remains positive but more balanced. Tight supply should keep prices above historical averages over the coming year, although rising Australian exports, softer demand growth, affordability pressures, signs of buyer resistance and (eventually) a stronger NZ dollar could see prices ease modestly from current elevated levels into 2027.

Average monthly lamb export prices - nominal



Average monthly lamb export prices - real

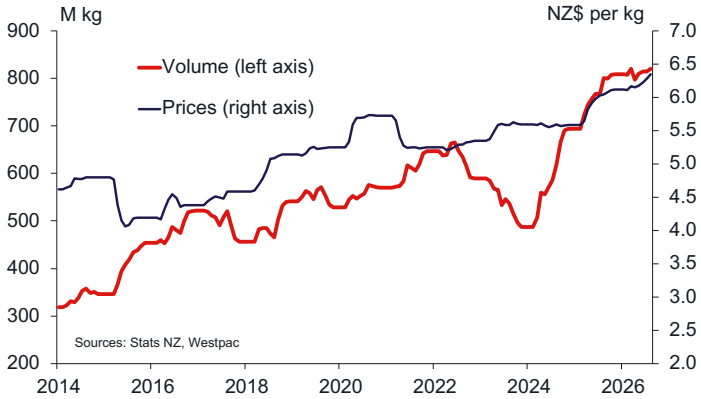


HORTICULTURE

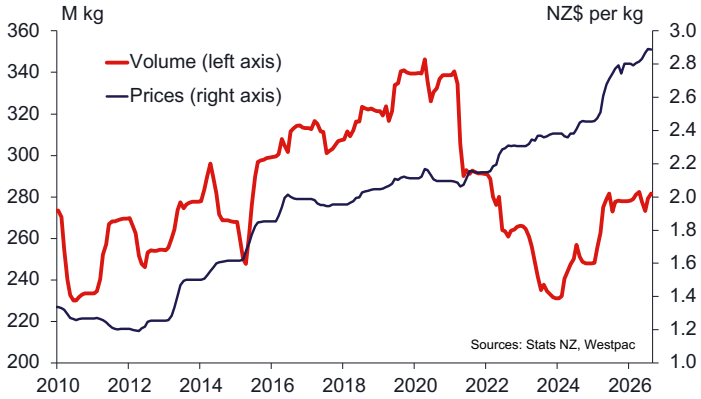
Capacity is catching up with demand, limiting further price gains.

- NZ kiwifruit export prices have pushed to record highs, supported by strong demand in North America, Europe, Japan and Korea, as well as continued consumer preference for premium varieties such as SunGold.
- Export prices continue to edge higher even as a record crop and larger fruit volumes are helping to reduce market tightness. Zespri notes increased competition from summer fruit, pricing pressure in parts of Asia and a larger-than-expected crop.
- Kiwifruit export prices are set to remain high but mostly flat over the next year, as strong demand for premium varieties such as SunGold and RubyRed is increasingly offset by rising production and price pressures in Asia.
- Apple export prices are also at record highs, supported by strong demand in Asia, North America and India, alongside a continued shift towards higher-value cultivars and premium varieties.
- These factors should keep export prices elevated over the next 12 months, supporting grower revenues and profitability.
- However, further gains could be limited. Rising New Zealand production, recovering supplies from key growing regions and larger global apple crops are expected to increase supply availability, reducing market tightness and keeping prices broadly stable.

Kiwifruit – average export prices and volumes



Apples – average export prices and volumes

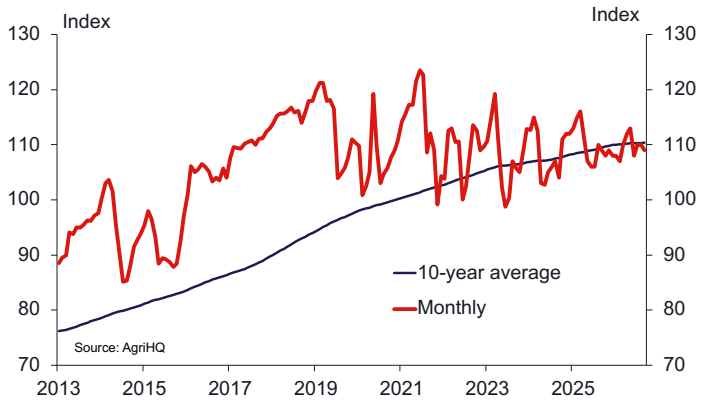


FORESTRY

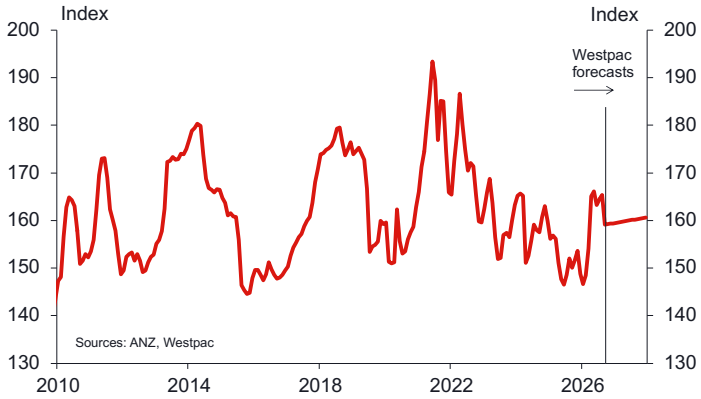
Log prices look moribund.

- China remains the dominant market for New Zealand logs, with prices highly sensitive to construction activity, sawmill demand and daily log offtake. In that regard, weak housing and furniture demand continue to weigh on prices.
- Chinese softwood log inventories are estimated at around 2.2 to 2.5m m³, equivalent to roughly 40 to 45 days of inventory cover at current offtake rates. This suggests inventory levels are broadly balanced and exerting little pressure on log prices.
- At the same time, reduced New Zealand log supply, including lower harvesting volumes and the wind-down of salvage logging, is providing some support to prices. Freight costs also remain an important driver of at-wharf-gate returns, with currently high shipping costs crimping returns to forest owners.
- NZ log export prices are expected to remain broadly stable to modestly firmer over the next 12 months, supported by lower domestic supply, balanced Chinese inventory levels and tentative signs of stabilisation in log demand.
- However, any recovery is likely to be gradual, with weakness in China's property sector, uncertainty around shipping costs and softer global growth continuing to constrain demand and cap upside potential.

Average log export prices



World forestry prices



FORECASTS

New Zealand commodity prices (end of period)

	Latest	Dec-26	Mar-27	Jun-27	Sep-27	Dec-27	Mar-28	Jun-28	Sep-28	Dec-28
NZ commodities index	**390**	**392**	**397**	**400**	**401**	**403**	**404**	**405**	**406**	**406**
Dairy price index	319	323	329	333	337	342	345	347	348	350
Whole milk powder USD/t	3,605	3,650	3,730	3,780	3,830	3,880	3,920	3,960	4,000	4,040
Skim milk powder USD/t	3,847	3,720	3,600	3,600	3,630	3,680	3,720	3,760	3,800	3,830
Lamb price index	686	681	678	674	670	666	660	652	644	636
Beef price index	397	402	416	417	417	417	415	413	410	408
Forestry price index	168	159	160	160	160	161	161	162	163	164

New Zealand commodity prices (annual averages)

	Levels				% change			
	2025	**2026f**	**2027f**	**2028f**	**2025**	**2026f**	**2027f**	**2028f**
NZ commodities index	**390**	**396**	**400**	**405**	**9.2**	**1.5**	**1.1**	**1.3**
Dairy price index	348	327	336	347	9.7	-6.3	2.7	3.6
Whole milk powder USD/t	3902	3623	3804	3982	13.5	-7.1	5.0	4.7
Skim milk powder USD/t	2702	3387	3627	3778	0.7	25.3	7.1	4.2
Lamb price index	587	671	672	648	27.0	14.4	0.1	-3.6
Beef price index	337	424	416	411	19.1	25.6	-1.7	-1.2
Forestry price index	152	160	160	162	-4.9	5.5	0.1	1.4

Forecasts as at 7 October 2026.

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Westpac Banking Corporation.

Week beginning 05 October 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: RBA hikes in September, November follow-up now expected.

The Week That Was: Searching for signal.

Focus on New Zealand: Resilient activity and simmering inflation.

For the week ahead:

Australia: Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment, MI Inflation Gauge.

New Zealand: GlobalDairyTrade auction, NZIER Survey of Business Opinions, ANZ Commodity Prices.

Japan: Current account balance, household spending.

China: Foreign reserves, M2 money supply.

Euro Area: Sentix investor confidence, retail sales.

United States: FOMC Meeting Minutes, ISM Services PMI, University of Michigan Sentiment Index.

Global: S&P Global PMIs.

Information contained in this report current as at 05 October 2026.

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RBA hikes in September, November follow-up now expected

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

As was universally expected, the RBA Monetary Policy Board (MPB) lifted the cash rate by 25bps to 4.6% at its September 2026 meeting.

This is quite the turnaround from the 11 August meeting, where an extended period on hold looked to be the base case. At that time, the data had broken against the RBA's more hawkish view, and its published forecasts did not support further hikes. But the MPB can now point to the emergence of some of the upside risks to inflation it warned of in August.

The post-meeting statement was notable for its emphasis on the Middle East conflict, noting that "global energy prices are now much higher than had been assumed in the August forecasts" – "much higher" is stronger language than one normally sees in an RBA statement. The RBA's liaison indicates that firms are passing this on or planning to do so. The pass-through was characterised as partial, and additional to domestically driven inflation arising from capacity pressures. We read this as implying that the RBA is concerned about upside risks to underlying inflation in Q4 of this year, as well as Q3.

The RBA is also wary about pressure on both construction costs and retail prices of IT goods arising from the AI/data centre boom, although in the media conference, the Governor clarified that risks there were building rather than materialising. The broader background highlighted in the Governor's opening statement to the media conference, is of demand outstripping supply. The statement evidenced this by noting the stronger July CPI and June quarter GDP results than expected.

The accompanying statement was notable for the absence of language about the labour market being a little tight, despite this being the inter-meeting message from the Governor and other staff (see, for example, the Governor's opening statement on 18 September) and the language in the post-meeting media conference. Views clearly differ on this: we note that the Treasury forecasts underlying the May budget and the recent Intergenerational Review imply both more spare capacity in the labour market (a lower NAIRU) and faster growth in potential from wherever the starting point is (higher productivity growth and trend increase in participation). Instead, the post-meeting statement characterised the labour market as easing "broadly as expected", despite the unemployment rate already rising higher than the August SMP forecast of 4.5% for the December quarter.

The decision was unanimous, suggesting that any qualms external MPB members might have had about the RBA's downbeat view of supply capacity were overruled by resurgent oil prices and the stronger than forecast CPI and GDP data.

With upside risks being seen to have emerged, the post-meeting statement language included that the Board "will continue to do what it considers necessary to bring inflation sustainably back to target, including increasing the cash rate target further if needed", a small but meaningful change from the "if upside risks materialise" language from the previous meeting, and back to the tone of the language at the June meeting.

The bar for a follow-up hike in November is low. Indeed, judging by the post-meeting rhetoric, a November hike is now the base case, absent a lasting resolution of the Middle East conflict beforehand, or some other event that significantly lowers the outlook for energy-related costs in Australia. The bar for hikes beyond that is much higher, given the cumulative rise in interest rates, and noting that the labour market is easing and the housing market will likely weaken further.

The August inflation data released the day after the meeting was in line with our expectations. We therefore continue to expect Q3 trimmed mean inflation around 0.9%qtr, too high for the RBA's comfort, and upside risks for Q4. Likewise, there are no implications for our rates view from this week's inflation data.

Forecast changes

- We have updated our financial forecasts to reflect the change in our rate view.
- Our labour market forecasts are unchanged on the first decimal place, but there is some modest upside risk to our unemployment forecast.
- Our updated GDP profile can be found on page 9.

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Cliff Notes: searching for signal

Sian Fenner, Head of Business and Industry Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist
Illiana Jain, Economist

In Australia, this week's main event was the RBA Monetary Policy Board's (MPB) decision to raise the cash rate by 25bps to 4.60%. This outcome was universally expected given Governor Bullock had already communicated that upside risks to inflation had materialised – the conditionality established by the MPB back in August for considering another rate hike.

Governor Bullock made explicit note of three upside risks. The Middle East conflict was emphasised as the risk that had "materialised", given the re-escalation and renewed surge in crude oil and refined product prices over recent months. The RBA's liaison warns this could lead to further pass-through of costs and more persistent inflation pressures. On top of this, domestic capacity pressures and the data centre/AI investment boom were also noted as upside risks that the MPB remain alert to.

In a video update mid-week, Chief Economist Luci Ellis explains why the bar for a follow-up rate hike in November is low. We now expect a 25bp increase in November, provided there is no sudden resolution of the Middle East conflict beforehand, or some other event that significantly lowers the outlook for energy-related costs.

Subsequently, the August CPI revealed that underlying (trimmed mean) inflation rose 0.2% (3.4%yr), which was slightly below the market's expectation but spot on Westpac's forecast. As usual, the monthly detail was mixed, but the key drivers of underlying inflation remain centred on housing-related components, particularly rents and new dwelling purchases. Headline inflation remained volatile, with the unwind of the fuel excise cut causing another spike in fuel prices. We have maintained our forecast for a 0.9% lift in trimmed mean inflation in Q3, and with upside risks building for Q4, a follow-up rate hike in November appears most likely.

Regarding the current growth pulse, household spending surprised with a flat reading in August. Services spend fell back following recent strength that was driven by major sporting events, but this was offset by an increase in goods spend, particularly in fuel and electric vehicles. Together with our latest card data for early September, the consumer spending pulse is shading a touch softer. However, another solid outcome for business investment could once again be on the cards for Q3. August's goods trade data showcased another significant spike in data centre-related equipment imports, up $4.3bn, similar in scale to Q1. While clearly import-driven, our modelling suggests that the local economic impact of such investment is likely to be around half of the total investment.

Before moving offshore, a final note on housing. Cotality's latest update revealed that dwelling prices fell another 1.1% nationally in September. While Sydney and Melbourne have led the correction to date, the fact that the other capitals are also reporting price declines clearly indicates that the correction is deepening and broadening, as higher interest rates collide with the tax policy changes announced in May's budget. Sentiment effects indeed remain at play, as evinced by the continued pull-back in investor credit growth. Westpac anticipates a peak-to-trough decline of around 7%, with tight on-market supply limiting the extent of the correction. For more, see our latest Housing Pulse.

Offshore, there was plenty of data to dissect.

In the US, inflation eased in August despite ongoing strength in household demand and higher energy prices. Headline PCE inflation rose 0.3%mth and 3.4%yr, while core PCE increased 0.2%mth and 3.0%yr. Encouragingly for the FOMC, the share of PCE components rising by more than 3% over the past year, a measure frequently cited by Fed Chairman Kevin Warsh, declined to 45% from 49%, suggesting some easing in broad-based inflation pressures. At the same time, household spending remained robust, increasing 0.9%mth, equivalent to around 0.6%mth in real terms. That said, personal income growth was soft, rising 0.2% in the month, signalling households opted to draw down savings.

The ISM manufacturing survey was stronger than the headline suggested. While the index edged down 0.1pt to 54.5, manufacturing has now expanded for nine consecutive months. There were some signs of capacity constraints emerging, with production softened in the month but backlogs up 4.6pts to 56.4, suggesting that firms struggled to keep pace with demand. New orders rose 1.6pts to 55.3, primarily due to domestic demand as new export orders eased, backlogs increased. Firms responded by lifting employment, 1.5pts to 52.7. Against this backdrop manufacturers saw a renewed acceleration in cost pressures, with the prices paid index jumping 6.8pts to 77.9. Firms cited higher steel and aluminium prices, elevated energy costs, rising freight charges and ongoing semiconductor shortages, with every major industry reporting higher input costs during the month.

The past week's data will have done nothing to bridge the clear divide across the FOMC, as evident in this week's busy Fedspeak. Some participants argued for further rate hikes, citing strong inflation, diminished supply capacity and policy that is not yet restrictive. Others counselled patience, pointing to progress on inflation and that September's hike buys time to assess upcoming data. The one thing both agree on is that inflation will be the primary determinant of the timing and extent of further rate hikes. Our view remains that one further hike is likely this cycle to bring policy closer to neutral.

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In China, policymakers announced another round of targeted support measures aimed at stabilising growth and supporting the struggling property sector. The PBOC lowered rates on its Pledged Supplementary Lending facility by 25bps to 1.5% and expanded quotas for targeted lending programs. Authorities also introduced subsidies for eligible first-home buyers. The subsidy applies to homes with a floor area of 120m² or less and a value below CNY1.5mn, with support capped at 1ppt of mortgage costs, up to CNY10,000 and for a maximum term of five years. The measures complement reforms announced in August to improve developer financing conditions and support housing completion. However, weak credit demand and confidence remains a significant constraint, suggesting policy transmission is still limited.

The September PMI data pointed to a modest improvement in activity, although the details were less convincing. Manufacturing returned to expansionary territory, rising 0.9pts to 50.1, supported by stronger production and new orders. Much of the improvement, however, reflected a rebound in prices, with the raw materials price index rising 7.6pts and producer prices increasing 6.2pts. Labour market conditions remained weak, with the employment index falling a further 0.6pts and remaining below 50 for almost four years. Conditions in the non-manufacturing sector also improved, with the services PMI lifting from 49.0 to 50.2, driven largely by stronger construction activity. Input and output prices moved higher, selling prices returned back above 50, export orders improved to 48.5 and employment increased 0.5pts, although at 45.9 it remains firmly in contractionary territory. Overall, the surveys suggest activity is stabilising and policy support is gaining some traction, but weak labour demand, subdued credit growth and soft domestic demand indicate the recovery remains fragile.

In Japan, the September Tankan survey delivered another constructive signal on the economy and reinforced the case for further policy normalisation. Business conditions improved by 2pts for large manufacturers and 5pts more broadly, while profitability indicators strengthened and capital expenditure intentions remained elevated. Large manufacturers expect fixed investment to increase by 11.6% in FY2026, while large non-manufacturers expect investment growth of 11.2%, pointing to continued confidence in the medium-term outlook.

Capacity indicators improved further across both manufacturing and non-manufacturing sectors, with measures of excess production capacity becoming less negative and indicating that demand remains sufficiently strong to keep pressure on existing capacity. Labour shortages also intensified, with employment conditions becoming more negative across most industries and firm sizes, pointing to a progressively tighter labour market. Inflation expectations remained anchored around 2%, providing further evidence that Japan is moving towards a more sustainable inflation environment. Overall, the survey was consistent with an economy operating close to capacity and supports the view that a December rate hike remains a realistic possibility.

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Resilient activity and simmering inflation

Satish Ranchhod
Senior Economist

While bumpy and uneven, New Zealand's economic recovery has continued over the past few months, with activity showing resilience in the face of continued global headwinds. Under the surface, however, inflation pressures are bubbling away, with much of that pressure centred on parts of the economy that aren't sensitive to interest rates.

Economic activity getting back on firmer footing

Looking first at recent activity data, the economy has been finding its feet again after taking a knock in the wake of the Middle East war. That has been seen most clearly in the jobs market, with the number of filled jobs rising by 0.9% in the year to August. While not shooting the lights out, that is still a noticeable improvement from the early part of the year, when filled job numbers were falling.

Under the surface, it's still a very mixed picture. Agriculture remains the main engine of growth, with the strength in commodity export earnings helping to boost incomes, confidence and spending in regions with strong rural backbones. That's supported firm job growth in regions like Canterbury (where filled job numbers are up 1.9% over the past year), Otago (+1.5%) and Southland (+3.1%). In contrast, jobs growth remains much more moderate in Auckland (up 0.6%) and Wellington (up just 0.4%). That town-and-country split is likely to remain a feature of the economic landscape for some time yet.

Looking ahead, businesses expect trading conditions to remain resilient through the final months of the year. That was reflected in September's Business Outlook survey. While the survey's gauges of expected business activity and general business confidence eased over the past month, they remain at firm levels, consistent with continued moderate growth through the latter part of the year. That resilience has also been evident in the household sector, with consumer confidence largely steady through September.

The resilience in household and business sentiment is notable, as fuel prices have taken a big step higher over the past month. The average price of 91 unleaded has risen by around 49c/litre – albeit late in the month and likely not fully reflected in surveyed confidence – taking it back to the levels seen during the early stages of the Middle East conflict. Those higher fuel prices have taken a bite out of household disposable incomes, with spending on fuel up about 22% compared with this time last year, even though the volume of fuel sold is down around 11%.

But even with the lift in fuel prices, we haven't seen the same degree of pessimism as earlier in the year, when fuel prices first spiked. Notably, those higher fuel prices haven't spilled over into a broader lift in output price pressures either (at least at this stage). Inflation expectations were steady in September's household and business surveys. Similarly, the number of firms planning to raise prices fell back despite a lift in wage and cost expectations. However, while that stability in pricing gauges is welcome, measures of inflation pressure remain elevated.

Taken together, recent data reinforce indications that the economy is shaking off the impacts of the Iran war.

Persistent inflation drivers and the RBNZ

Turning to inflation, the spike in oil prices earlier this year saw annual inflation climb to 4.1% in the year to June. With local fuel costs rising again in recent weeks, we continue to expect inflation to remain above 3% until at least mid-2027.

However, even before the recent rise in fuel costs, inflation had been running hot for an extended period. Excluding the rise in food and fuel prices, inflation in the year to June was 2.9%, and it's been running close to or above 3% for five years now.

As we discuss in our recent report, much of the strength in inflation over the past year has been related to administered costs, such as local council rates, or to sectors that are less exposed to competitive pressures, such as electricity and insurance. Those increases have persisted for an extended period, and we expect further sizeable increases in many of these costs.

This ongoing firmness is a key reason why we expect domestic (non-tradables) inflation to be higher than the RBNZ expects over the longer term. It's also part of the reason why we expect the RBNZ will ultimately need to raise the OCR by more than it assumed in its September policy statement. We are forecasting a 25bp rate rise at the RBNZ's December meeting and expect the OCR to peak at 4% next year.

This is a tough environment for the RBNZ. With ongoing increases in administered prices boosting core inflation at a time when energy prices are driving headline inflation well above the target range, it's hard for the RBNZ to look through them. The RBNZ had little headroom to absorb upside inflation surprises, even before the recent spike in oil prices.

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But getting inflation back to target in the face of an oil price spike and high administered prices will not be easy and involves some tough trade-offs. Administered prices tend to be less responsive to changes in economic conditions. As a result, interest rate hikes are likely to have a bigger impact on parts of the economy that are not the main drivers of inflation. Tighter policy will also weigh on the labour market and near-term growth, while increasing households' debt-servicing costs.

This is an uncomfortable but necessary trade-off. Looking through, or not responding to, these sorts of large and persistent cost increases would still leave households facing significant increases in overall living costs. In the long run, it would be more damaging for households and the economy if generalised inflation were to become embedded in price setting behaviour.

The Kiwi has lost its wings

Adding to near-term inflation risks has been the drop in the NZ dollar. On a trade-weighted basis, the Kiwi has fallen around 4% since the start of September, and it's begun the December quarter around 4% below the level the RBNZ assumed in its September policy statement.

The slide in the Kiwi is mainly due to the strength of the US dollar, with NZD/USD down nearly 5% since the start of September to sit just below 0.56 at the time of writing. Moves against other currencies have been more modest. For example, NZD/AUD is down 2% over the same period.

Technically, NZD/USD seems oversold. In the short term, trends in the US dollar will dominate, including any response to the US labour market report due on Friday evening. Any turnaround in the USD would likely see NZD/USD trade back towards the top of the 0.5580–0.5680 range that is governing the pair for the time being.

NZD/AUD will continue to be driven by changing views on interest rate differentials between the RBNZ and RBA. This week, NZD/AUD corrected higher from around 0.8070 to as high as 0.8110 as RBA cash rate expectations were repriced following the RBA Board meeting and Australian CPI. In the short term, the bias for NZD/AUD could be lower, given our view that the RBNZ will pause at its late-October meeting and that the market is under-pricing the risk of an RBA rate hike in November.

Next week's QSBO, due on Tuesday, will be the key event risk, with the inflation and growth gauges closely watched for signs that might prompt the RBNZ to pause or hike. Markets had previously priced in a high chance of a hike at the RBNZ's October meeting, but in recent days appear to be reassessing that view. Pricing for a 25bp hike in New Zealand could be pared back towards a 50:50 call. The 0.8030–0.8150 range is likely to contain the pair in the immediate period ahead. Our medium-term view is for NZD/AUD to rise as the RBNZ increases the OCR to 4% by the second half of 2027. We'll update our views on the NZD and other currencies in our next *Market Outlook*, out Wednesday 14 October.

Fiscal update

The big uncertainty on the domestic horizon is, of course, November's general election, and at this stage the polling looks tight. Neither the established left nor right bloc has a clear majority.

Ahead of the election, the Treasury has released its Pre-election Economic and Fiscal Update (PREFU), updating the Budget 2026 (BEFU) fiscal forecasts to reflect the latest economic and fiscal information and a revised economic outlook. This allows the public to assess the state of the Government's finances. It also provides other parties with a baseline against which to calibrate their spending and taxation policies.

The PREFU revealed a stronger starting point for the Government's finances than had been expected in the Budget.

- A deficit of $8.6bn is estimated for 2025/26, down from the Budget estimate of $11.9bn.
- Similarly, the forecast deficit for 2026/27 has been revised down significantly to $6.8bn from $11.4bn.
- Thereafter, the OBEGALx deficit is expected to continue declining gradually, moving to a surplus of $4bn in 2028/29. This broadly follows the Budget profile, but is stronger across the forecast period.
- Net core Crown debt is forecast to peak at 43.9% of GDP in 2027/28, below the 46.1% peak forecast in the BEFU. It's then forecast to decline to 39.5% of GDP by the end of the forecast period in 2030/31, in line with the Government's goal of reducing debt below 40% of GDP over the medium term.

Given the improved outlook, NZDM announced a $4bn reduction in the 2026/27 bond programme to $30bn and a $15bn reduction in the forecast programme across the whole period through to 2029/30.

The medium-term forecasts in the PREFU should be treated with caution. The economic forecasts underpinning the PREFU were finalised on 21 August, when both oil prices and, especially, bond yields were materially lower than they are today. Had the forecasts been finalised more recently, the fiscal projections presented today would have been weaker, at least in the near term. Indeed, the Treasury is upfront in acknowledging that, while the risks are two-sided, the balance is skewed to the downside.

Aside from the obvious uncertainty surrounding the economic outlook because of unpredictable developments in the Middle East, the approaching General Election, and the possibility of a change in the composition of the Government, means the assumptions underpinning the PREFU forecasts could quickly become invalidated.

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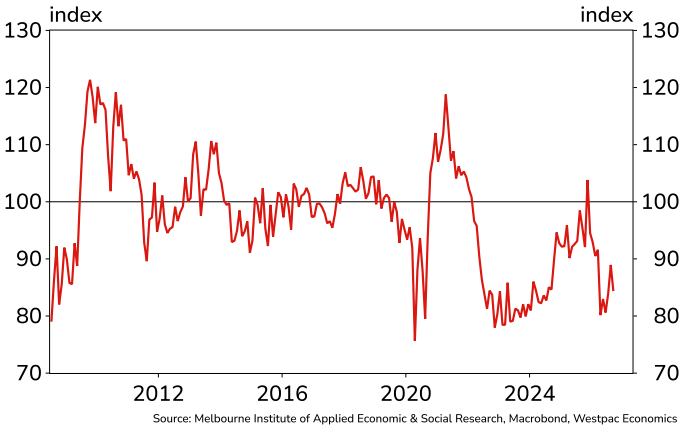
AUS: Oct Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment (index)

Oct 6, Last: 84.4

Consumer sentiment declined 5.2% to 84.4 in September, taking the index back towards the deeply pessimistic levels seen earlier in the year. Rising fuel prices and fears of an imminent interest rate rise drove the move with a continued weakening in housing markets likely adding to unease in some quarters.

Developments over the last month would have added to these concerns with: the RBA raising the cash rate by 25bps to 4.6% during the survey week; average pump prices pushing above $2.36/litre nationally and no end in sight to global supply disruptions; and more weak updates on the housing market.

Consumer Sentiment Index



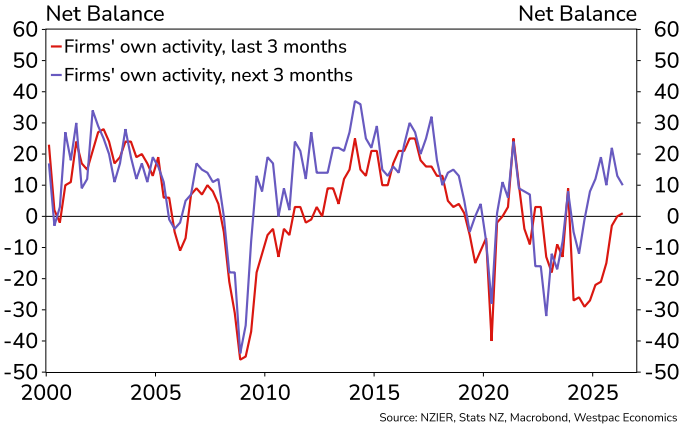
Source: Melbourne Institute of Applied Economic & Social Research, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Q2 NZIER Survey of Business Opinion (index)

Oct 6, General business confidence last: 12.3

Business conditions picked up modestly in the June quarter as concerns about the war in the Middle East eased. However, cost and pricing gauges remained firm. The September quarter survey will be closely watched ahead of the RBNZ's 28 October meeting. Recent weeks have seen signs that activity is firming. However, fuel prices have also risen sharply, and we (along with the RBNZ) will be watching for signs of a broader lift in inflation pressures. The timing of survey responses within the sample period will also warrant scrutiny, given that oil prices rose late in the quarter.

QSBO past vs expected activity



Source: NZIER, Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Mon 05							
Aus	Sep	MI Inflation Gauge	%ann	4.8	–	–	Lead indicator for CPI inflation shows price pressure rising.
		Labour Day Public Holiday	–	–	–	–	NSW, ACT, SA, Qld (King's Birthday). Markets open.
NZ	Sep	ANZ Commodity Prices	%mth	–0.4	–	–	Agriculture product prices at or near record levels
Eur	Oct	Sentix Investor Confidence	index	5.1	–	–	Sitting at the highest level since February 2022.
	Aug	PPI	%ann	5.8	–	–	Recent strength driven by energy inputs, ex-energy at 3.1%yr.
US	Sep	ISM Services	index	55.4	55.2	–	Regional surveys suggest a milder expansion than last month.
Wrld	Sep	S&P Global Services PMI	index	–	–	–	Final estimate for Japan, UK, Eurozone and the US.
Tue 06							
Aus	Oct	Westpac–MI Consumer Sentiment	index	84.4	–	–	Consumers react to rate rise and softer inflation print.
	Sep	ANZ–Indeed Job Ads	%mth	2.5	–	–	Has been trending higher since end-2025.
NZ	Q3	NZIER Survey of Business Opinion	index	12.3	–	–	Watching for resilience in activity, but upside risks for prices.
Eur	Aug	Retail Sales	%mth	–0.6	–	–	Consumers pulling away from non-food related spending.
US	Aug	Trade Balance	US$bn	–88.6	–89.8	–	Trade deficit widening amid surging AI-related imports.
Wed 07							
NZ	Sep	GlobalDairyTrade auction	%	–1.1	–	–	WMP and SMP prices up on previous GDT Pulse auction.
Chn	Sep	Foreign Reserves	US$bn	3438.33	–	–	Weaker dollar and growing trade surplus drives reserves up.
US		FOMC Meeting Minutes	–	–	–	–	Focus will be on assessments on the stance of policy.
	Aug	Consumer Credit	$bn	18.062	15.000	–	Some consumers may be leaning on credit to fund spending.
Thur 08							
Aus	Oct	MI Inflation Expectations	%ann	4.9	–	–	Higher fuel prices seeing near-term expectations lift.
Jpn	Aug	Current Account Balance	¥bn	2988.9	3194.6	–	Rise driven by higher inbound tourism and dividend inflows.
US		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	197	–	–	Has been easing in recent weeks.
	Aug	Wholesale Inventories	%mth	0.7	–	–	Final estimate.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Fed's Musalem speaks at Bloomberg event.
Fri 09							
Jpn	Aug	Household Spending	%ann	–3.6	–3.6	–	Discretionary spending falters in the face of higher prices.
Chn	Sep	M2 Money Supply	%ann	7.5	–	–	Credit demand slows as households and firms hold-off.
US	Oct	Uni. Of Michigan Sentiment	index	48.1	48.0	–	Consumers' outlook on the economy souring.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (2 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.60	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.76	4.95	4.95	4.80	4.55	4.30	4.10	3.95	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.92	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.89	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.34	5.20	5.10	5.00	4.90	4.85	4.80	4.80	4.80	4.80
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	10	40	35	30	25	15	5	0	-5	-10
United States										
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	5.24	4.80	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.70	4.75	4.80	4.85	4.90
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.22	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	4.04	3.95	4.10	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	5.07	4.75	4.90	5.00	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–16	–5	15	30	40	35	30	25	20	15

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (2 Oct)	Dec-26	Mar-27	Jun-27	Sep-27	Dec-27	Mar-28	Jun-28	Sep-28	Dec-28
AUD/USD	0.6941	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5607	0.59	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.65
USD/JPY	157.71	155	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146
EUR/USD	1.1259	1.17	1.18	1.19	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3217	1.35	1.36	1.37	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40
USD/CNY	6.7060	6.70	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2357	1.22	1.19	1.16	1.14	1.12	1.12	1.11	1.11	1.11

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.4	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.1	1.4	1.5	1.4	1.4	1.6	2.6	1.4	1.6	2.5
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	0.5	0.7	0.6	0.7	0.4	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	3.7	3.0	3.0	2.5	2.4	3.6	3.7	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	0.9	0.7	0.8	0.7	0.6	0.6	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.5	3.3	3.2	3.1	2.8	2.7	3.3	3.3	2.7	2.3

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.8	1.1	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.5	2.7	2.8	2.9	0.3	2.4	2.9	3.1
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.2	5.1	4.9	5.4	5.4	4.9	4.4
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	0.6	0.4	0.4	0.6	0.3	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	3.7	3.2	2.1	2.0	1.7	3.1	3.7	1.7	2.1

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2 OCTOBER 2026

WESTPAC–DATAX CARD TRACKER

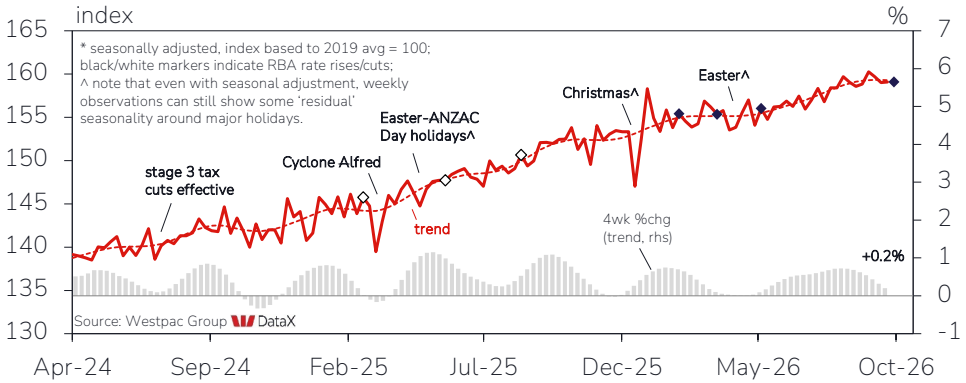
Powered by DataX

Card activity: soft finish to a strong quarter

- The **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index*** has edged up slightly since late August, rising 0.2pts to 159.1.
- Quarterly growth momentum has seen a further lift and is now tracking towards a 1.7% gain for the September quarter which would mark the strongest quarterly rise since June 2025.
- However, both the monthly and weekly reads show momentum has faded over the course of the quarter. After posting 0.7-0.9%mth gains through May, June and July, the Index rose just 0.2% in August and is tracking a similarly subdued 0.3% pace for September. Weekly reads are also tracking a more moderate trend pace of 0.2%mth.
- On a quarterly basis, the detail shows discretionary services and international transactions have led the pick-up. While some of this looks to be catch-up from travel disruptions in the June quarter, gains have been consistent and broadly based. Likewise, there is little evidence that the pick-up is coming from a lift in prices with recent CPI updates suggesting services inflation has been steady rather than accelerating (see here).
- On the apparent loss of momentum over the course of the quarter, the detail suggests this is a re-run of the fuel price squeeze in March-April-May with the essentials spend gain rising strongly. So far the spillover effects are showing up mainly as a dampening in discretionary goods spend with the slowing in discretionary services largely confined to hospitality.
- Overall, the card tracker data suggests the Q3 spending data will still come in as a relatively solid gain, even allowing for a firmer gain in prices in the quarter. However, the fade in momentum is notable with the impact of further fuel pricer increases and this week's RBA rate rise still to come. Add what now looks more likely to be a follow-on interest rate hike in November and the December quarter is shaping as a significant slowdown in card activity.

"... both the monthly and weekly reads show momentum has faded over the course of the quarter."

1. Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index*



The **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker** presents indicators based on the millions of credit and debit card transactions processed by Westpac every day. The measures are a timely guide to shifts in spending. See p9 for a detailed explanation.

This report is produced by Westpac Economics.
Matthew Hassan, Head of Australian Macro-Forecasting
Email: economics@westpac.com.au
This issue was finalised on 2 October 2026.

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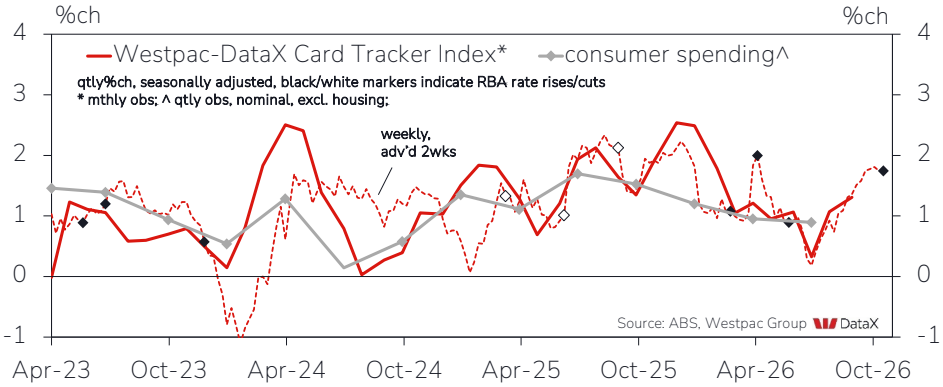
Card activity points to ~0.7%qtr gain in Q3 in real, inflation adjusted terms

- Chart 2 shows how quarterly growth in the **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index** compares to growth in nominal consumption as reported in the quarterly national accounts. All estimates are adjusted for regular seasonal variations. Quarterly growth momentum is now tracking around 1.7%, the strongest pace since the fuel price spike in March, and pior to that, since the turn of the year.
- Notably, growth ex fuel has slowed since the start of September, tracking a slower 1.4% quarterly pace in the latest week. This reflects both the end of the temporary halving in fuel excise tax and the latest resurgence in energy prices globally.
- Recall that Q2 national accounts showed nominal spending (excluding housing costs, which are not covered in our card tracker indicators) rose 0.9%qtr, similar to Q1's 1%qtr gain but with annual growth slowing to 4.7%yr from 5.5%yr. Growth in real, inflation-adjusted terms was more subdued at +0.4%qtr, 1.8%yr (near flat in per capita terms). The detail was 'messy' with significant disruptions from the Middle East conflict (see here).
- The card tracker data now has 12 of the 13 weeks of Q3. As such, the 1.7%qtr rise in nominal terms and price rise in the 1%qtr range points to a real, inflation adjusted gain of around 0.7%qtr, in line with Westpac's current forecasts.

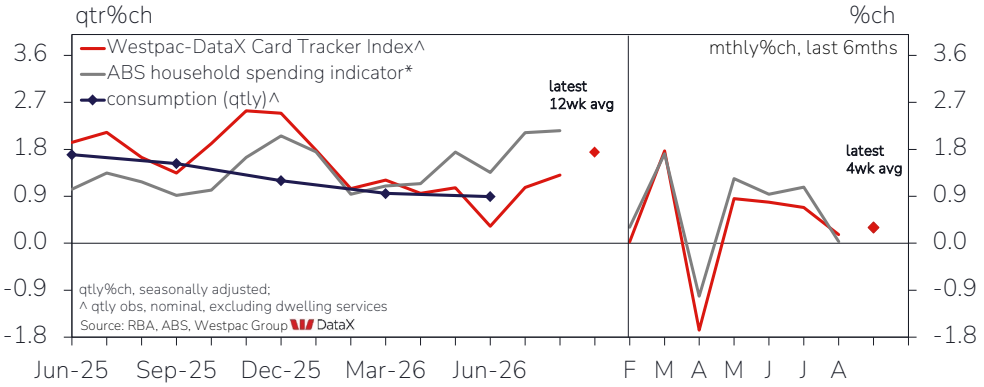
qtly%ch	Q4	Q1	Q2	latest^
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker	**2.5**	**1.2**	**0.3**	**1.7**
ABS monthly household spending indicator*				
Nominal	2.1	1.1	1.4	2.2
Real*	0.9	0.8	0.7	n.a.
ABS consumer spending (qtly)#				
Nominal	1.2	1.0	0.9	n.a.
Real	0.5	0.4	0.4	n.a.

All series seasonally adjusted. Latest is either the latest weekly obs (12wks %ch on previous 12wks) or latest monthly obs (3mths %ch on previous 3mths). See p9 for more details.
* ABS monthly household spending indicator based on domestic card transaction and new vehicle sales data. Real estimates are quarterly.
# Consumer spending excludes housing costs. Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

2. Card activity and spending: growth momentum



3. Consumer spending: selected indicators



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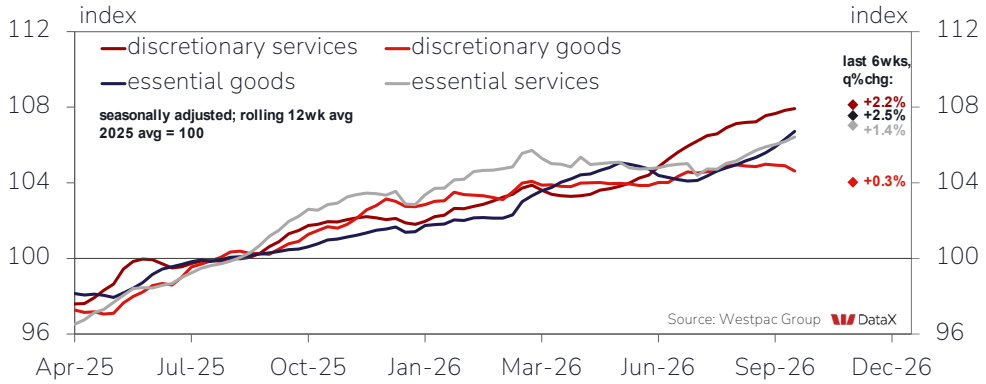
Fuel spend rises, discretionary momentum fades

- Chart 4 shows quarterly growth in card activity across broad categories. The year has been marked by rotations between essentials and discretionary categories as fuel price shocks have washed in and out. The switch from essentials to discretionary categories – services in particular – in the early part of Q3 is again reversing with the main drag coming in discretionary goods.
- In quarterly growth terms, essential goods is now leading, running at 2.5%qtr, with discretionary services still relatively strong at 2.2%qtr, essential services tracking more slowly at 1.4%qtr and discretionary goods much weaker at just 0.3%qtr (flat to down in per capita terms).
- Digging into the more detailed discretionary services segments, the initial quarterly pickup came from a big turnaround in transport services, which look to be partly a rebound from air travel disruptions in Q2 with a similar pattern evident in 'international transactions' (which are not included in discretionary services category, as they include some goods purchases, but are presented here as corroborating evidence). The charts on p6-7 provide some more detail on the other categories. Notably the weakening in discretionary goods momentum looks to be broad-based.
- Regionally, the softening is a little more evident in Vic than in other states.

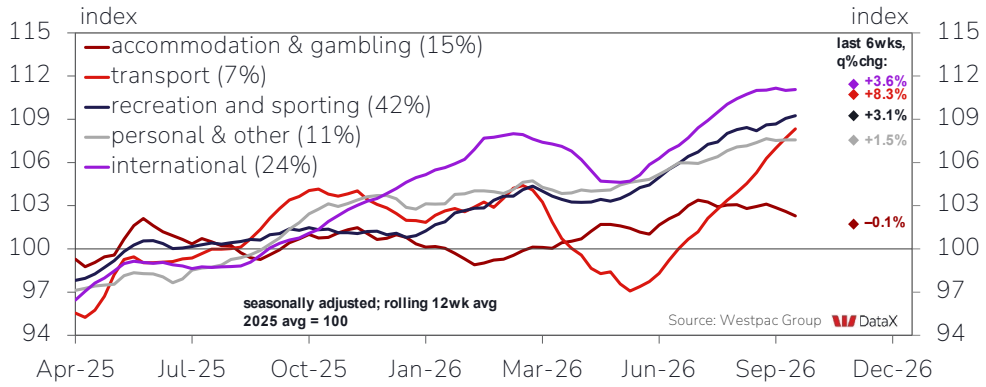
	Jun	Jul	Aug	26/9
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker	**157.0**	**158.1**	**158.4**	**159.1**
By category				
– discretionary*	159.2	160.4	159.9	159.7
– essential*	151.6	152.7	153.6	156.6
By state				
– NSW	149.8	151.2	151.0	154.4
– Vic	147.7	148.9	149.7	151.1
– Qld	171.8	174.1	172.6	174.8
– WA	173.9	175.7	176.7	178.6
– SA	163.6	165.0	166.3	166.3

All indexes based on the value of spending–related transactions, seasonally adjusted, 2019 avg=100, see p9 for more details including classifications.
* indexes revised due to re-classification.
Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

4. Card activity by broad category



5. Card activity: discretionary services & international



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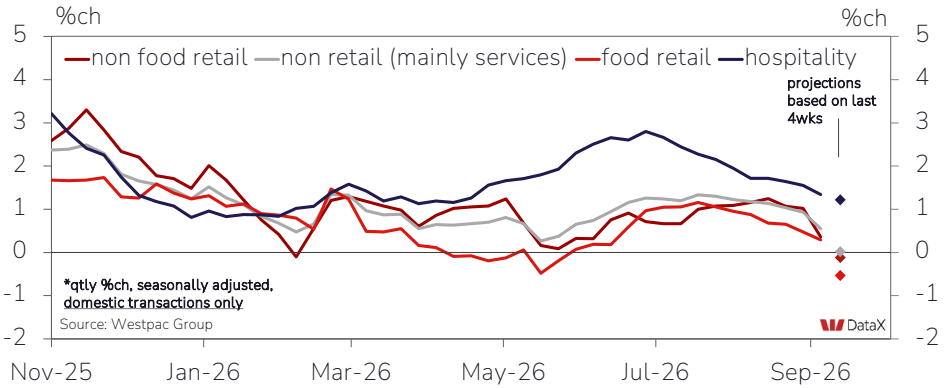
Retail retreats

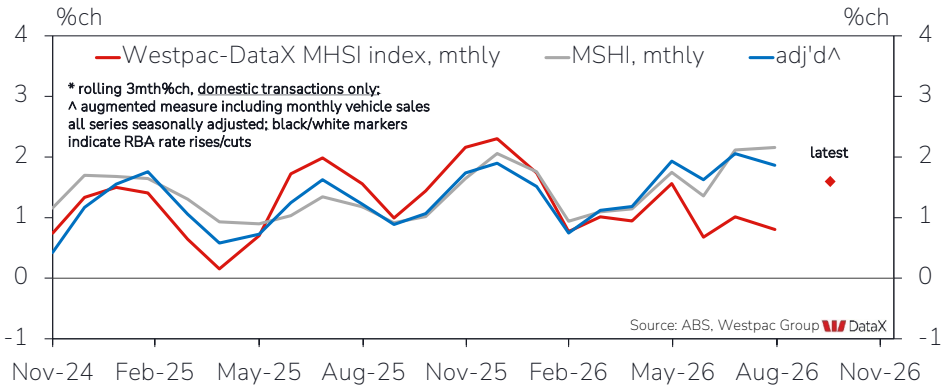
- Our MHSI and retail card indexes are composite measures based on transactions in categories that are in scope for the ABS monthly household spending indicator (MHSI) and retail sales estimates (which have been based on the MHSI detail since the ABS retail survey was discontinued in June 2025).
- As noted previously, the retail and MHSI index measures significantly outperformed the broader WCTI in Q2 but with the gap narrowing in July-August. The latest weekly signals now show both more in line at 1.6%qtr and 1.7%qtr respectively.
- The retail card index measure is a narrower subset of spend that excludes fuel and most services except hospitality. Chart 6 shows a sharp weakening in non food retail in recent weeks with food retail also stalling but hospitality tracking a firmer, albeit slowing pace.
- The ABS MHSI was a little firmer than we expected but came in below market expectations in August with a flat result, the 3mth growth rate ticking up to 2.2%qtr. Note that a significant part of the quarterly strength is coming from vehicle sales which surged through the middle of the year (see here for more).

	Jun	Jul	Aug	26/9
MHSI card index	**153.7**	**155.1**	**155.2**	**157.3**
– qtly%ch	0.7	1.0	0.8	1.6
– qtly, ann%ch	5.1	5.2	5.4	5.3
ABS MHSI				
– %ch	0.9	1.1	0.0	n.a.
– qtly%ch	1.4	2.1	2.2	n.a.
– qtly ann%ch	5.5	5.3	5.5	n.a.
Retail card index	**154.6**	**155.6**	**155.2**	**154.2**
– qtly%ch	1.1	1.8	1.3	0.5
– qtly, ann%ch	5.3	5.6	5.3	4.6
ABS retail sales				
– %ch	0.2	1.0	-0.2	n.a.
– qtly%ch	1.4	1.8	1.5	n.a.
– qtly ann%ch	5.2	5.5	5.6	n.a.

6. Card activity: retail segments and non-retail



7. Card activity: ABS MHSI index vs WCTI measures



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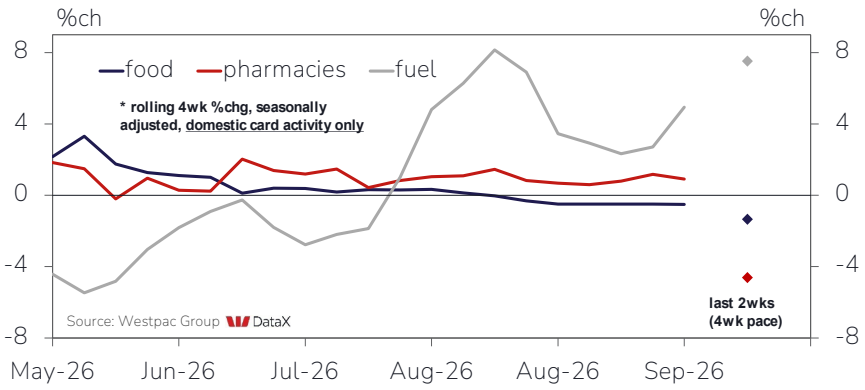
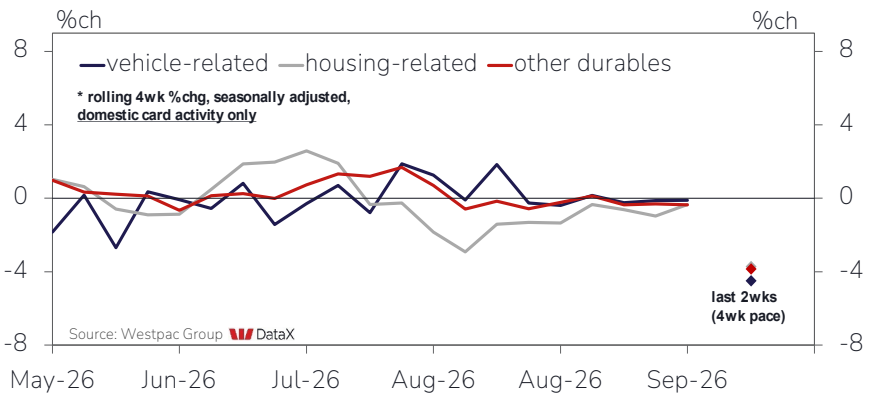
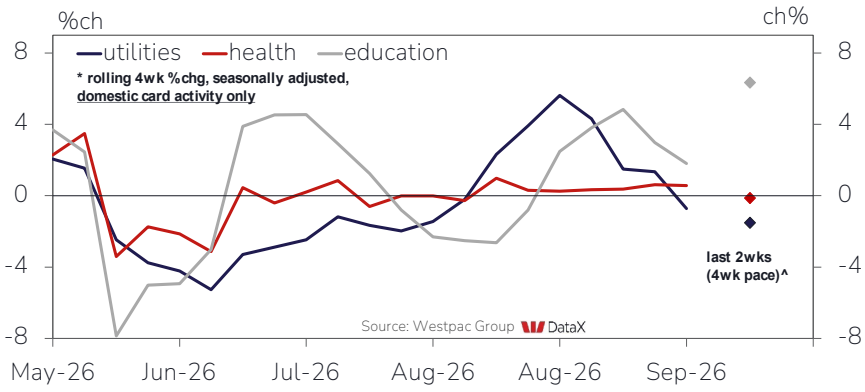
8. Card activity: essential goods



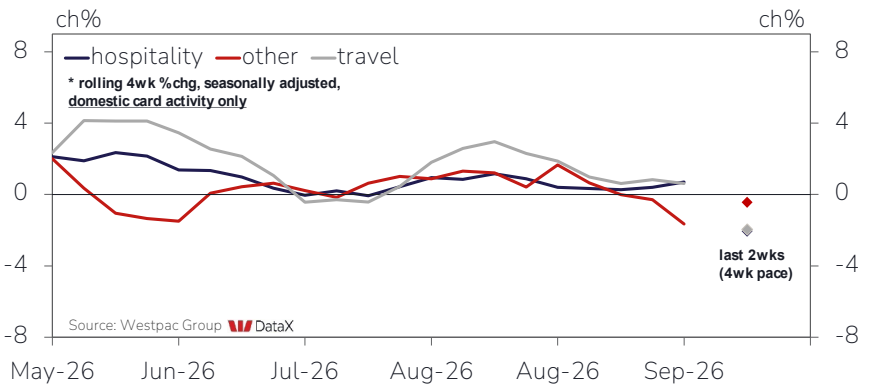
9. Card activity: discretionary goods



10. Card activity: essential services



11. Card activity: discretionary services



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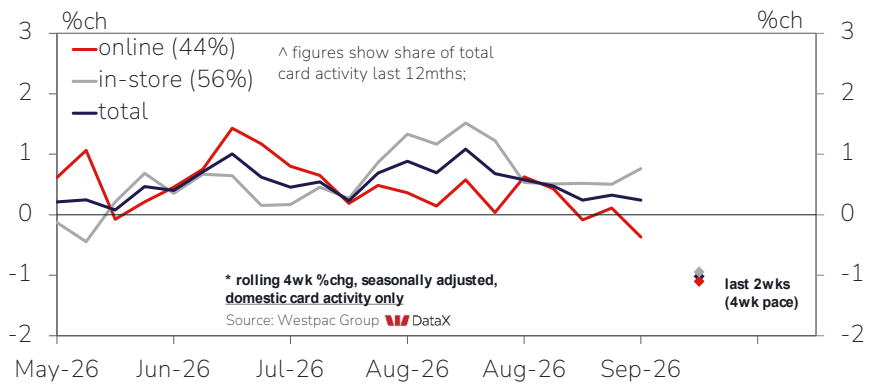
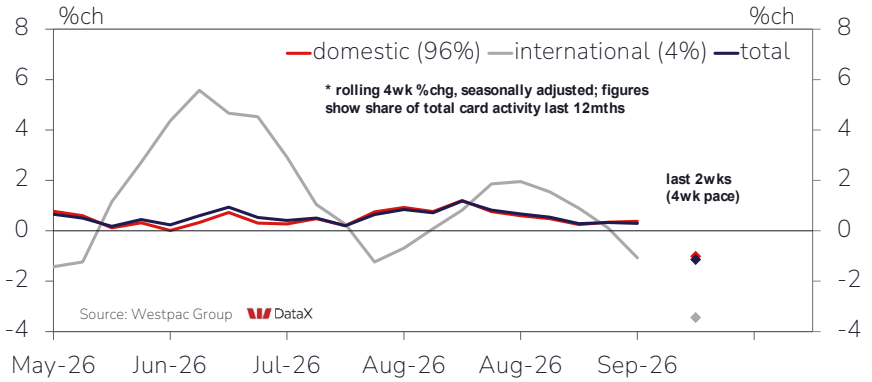
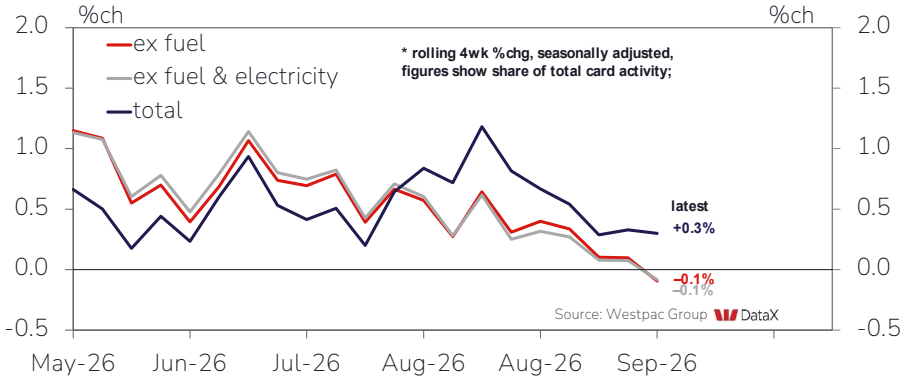
12. Card activity: online and in-store



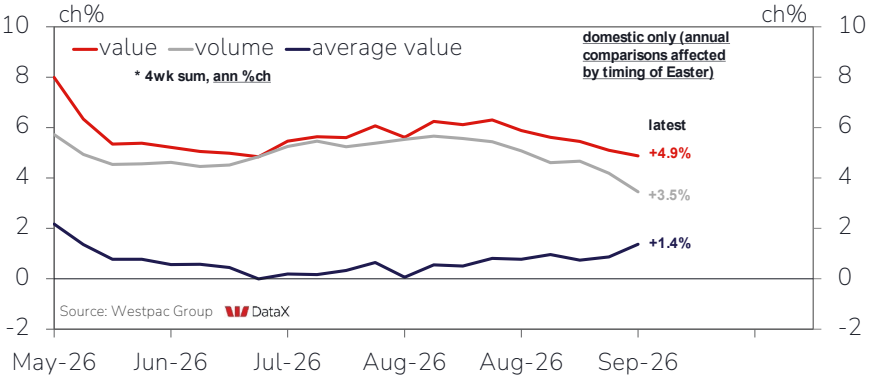
13. Card activity: food and non-food



14. Card activity: total, ex fuel and electricity



15. Card activity: value and volume



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WESTPAC CARD INDICATORS*

	2024		2025				2026					week ending:			
	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2	Jun	Jul	Aug	5/9	12/9	19/9	26/9
Westpac–DataX Card Tracker Index	**140.9**	**143.0**	**144.9**	**147.7**	**149.7**	**153.4**	**155.3**	**155.8**	**157.0**	**158.1**	**158.4**	**160.3**	**159.7**	**159.0**	**159.1**
qtly%ch	0.4	1.5	1.3	1.9	1.3	2.5	1.2	0.3	0.3	1.1	1.3	1.7	1.8	1.8	1.7
qtly, ann%ch	3.9	5.3	4.0	5.2	6.2	7.2	7.2	5.5	5.5	5.8	6.1	6.0	5.9	5.8	5.6
By category															
– discretionary	142.9	145.6	146.2	149.3	151.3	155.1	155.9	157.1	159.2	160.4	159.9	163.1	161.8	160.6	159.7
– essential	137.7	138.6	141.4	143.7	145.8	148.5	151.3	151.6	151.6	152.7	153.6	155.3	155.4	155.5	156.6
services	147.4	150.3	152.8	156.6	159.6	163.1	164.9	165.4	167.9	169.2	169.2	171.8	170.2	170.1	170.2
– discretionary services	150.6	154.4	155.0	158.8	160.4	164.7	165.5	167.1	170.4	171.6	171.0	175.1	173.6	173.1	172.1
– essential services	142.8	144.5	149.6	153.5	158.5	160.9	164.1	163.1	164.2	165.6	166.6	167.0	165.3	165.7	167.6
goods	134.6	135.5	136.5	138.3	139.6	142.7	144.5	145.3	145.3	146.4	146.7	149.0	149.2	148.3	148.3
– discretionary goods	134.7	136.2	136.7	139.2	141.6	144.9	145.7	146.5	147.2	148.5	148.1	150.1	149.0	147.1	146.3
– essential goods	134.6	134.9	136.3	137.6	137.8	140.8	143.4	144.3	143.7	144.5	145.4	148.0	149.3	149.3	149.9
MHSI card index*	140.6	142.4	143.4	145.8	147.3	150.7	152.2	153.2	153.7	155.1	155.2	158.2	158.2	157.5	157.3
qtly%ch	0.4	1.3	0.6	1.7	1.0	2.3	1.0	0.7	0.7	1.0	0.8	1.4	1.5	1.6	1.6
qtly, ann%ch	3.0	4.6	2.7	4.1	4.8	5.8	6.2	5.1	5.1	5.2	5.4	5.5	5.5	5.5	5.3
retail card index*	141.0	142.7	143.4	146.1	147.9	151.3	152.1	153.8	154.6	155.6	155.2	156.6	156.2	154.5	154.2
qtly%ch	0.8	1.2	0.5	1.8	1.2	2.3	0.5	1.1	1.1	1.8	1.3	1.1	1.0	0.9	0.5
qtly, ann%ch	2.8	4.2	2.0	4.3	4.8	6.0	6.0	5.3	5.3	5.6	5.3	5.3	5.2	5.0	4.6
By state															
– NSW	136.6	138.6	139.4	142.4	144.4	148.2	148.4	149.1	149.8	151.2	151.0	155.6	155.4	154.7	154.4
– Vic	135.5	136.6	138.5	140.3	142.2	144.7	146.0	146.9	147.7	148.9	149.7	153.2	151.7	151.3	151.1
– Qld	150.7	153.0	155.1	159.4	161.9	167.7	169.0	170.1	171.8	174.1	172.6	175.4	175.6	175.4	174.8
– WA	151.1	153.7	156.7	159.4	163.0	167.9	170.8	171.6	173.9	175.7	176.7	181.5	180.3	179.9	178.6
– SA	147.7	150.1	152.0	154.5	157.3	160.2	162.2	162.9	163.6	165.0	166.3	168.4	167.8	166.5	166.9

All indexes based on the value of spending–related transactions, seasonally adjusted by Westpac, 2019 avg=100. See p9 for more details.
* composite based on transactions in categories in scope for ABS monthly spending indicator and ABS retail sales surveys respectively.

Sources: ABS, Westpac Group

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About the Westpac card data indicators

The indicators presented in this report are based on the millions of credit and debit card transactions processed every day. Transactions covering over ten million merchants are classified into over 700 categories. These are in turn grouped into higher level aggregates that provide a timely guide to wider economic trends.

The main focus of these indicators is consumer spending. Where possible, we have sought to exclude 'non spending' transactions such as: money transfers; tax payments; loan repayments; charitable donations; and superannuation contributions.

It should also be noted that these indicators will also be affected by shifts between card and non-card transactions. This was a significant factor during the COVID–19 pandemic – health concerns about the use of physical cash leading to significantly higher use of cards vs cash, particularly where contact–less transactions are available. Transaction flows also include reversals/refunds which were also a significant phenomenon during the onset of COVID, especially in areas such as travel.

All transaction data is compiled at a highly aggregated level so that individual customer or merchant data is never revealed.

Index construction

The key metrics used in this report are indexes of spending–related card activity where the base of 100 is average activity in 2019. As an example, if transaction flows are 5% above their average level in 2019, the index read for the period is 105. If flows in a subsequent period are 8% above the average level in 2019, the index read for this period is 108. Growth between the two periods can be calculated simply as the change between the two index reads, i.e. 2.9%.

All measures are adjusted for regular seasonality. Weekly estimates are generated using the US Bureau of Labor's MoveReg weekly seasonal adjustment program. Note that in some cases, high levels of volatility during the COVID period mean it is not possible to produce seasonally adjusted estimates for some historical periods.

Also, note that previous versions of this report used different approaches to seasonal adjustment and measurement more generally. This means Index reads are sometimes not directly comparable. See the 'About the Westpac card data indicators' sections from earlier reports to more detail.

Classifications

Note that the measures used for card data and in this report do not align completely with the those used in official ABS statistics, including the ABS household spending indicator, ABS retail trade survey and ABS estimate of consumer spending published in the national accounts. There are a range of differences including around both coverage and classification. As such, the card data should be treated as broadly indicative.

The transaction data is grouped into 26 categories that are then combined into four main as follows:

Discretionary goods: alcoholic beverages, tobacco, clothing & footwear, furnishings & household equipment, household appliances, vehicle–related, recreational & cultural goods, newspaper, books & stationery, and other personal effects.

Discretionary services: transport services (part), recreational & cultural services, gambling, catering services, accommodation services, other personal care, insurance & financial services, other services.

Essential goods: food & non alcoholic beverages, medical products, appliances & equipment, and operation of personal transport equipment.

Essential services: electricity, gas & other fuels, health services, transport services (part), communications and education.

The report also uses two additional classifications:

MHSI/Retail: based on the extent to which categories cover activity that is in scope for the ABS monthly household spending indicator and ABS retail trade survey.

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Economic Calendar

October 2026

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
			1 **AUSTRALIA** Cotality Home Value Index Sep exp –1.0% prev 0.9% (12:01am) RBA – Financial Stability Review (11:30am) Goods Trade Balance Aug exp $2.3bn prev $1.9bn (11:30am) Job Vacancies Q3 exp 3.5% prev –2.1% (11:30am) **EURO ZONE** Unemployment Rate Aug exp 6.4% prev 6.4% (7:00pm) **JAPAN** Tankan Large Manufacturers Index Q3 exp 25 prev 22.0 (9:50am) **NEW ZEALAND** Building Permits Aug prev –4.3% (7:45am) **UNITED STATES** Fedspeak – Goolsbee (7:15am) Fedspeak – Barkin, Collins & Schmid (11:05pm) ISM Manufacturing Sep exp 55.0 prev 54.6 (12:00am) Construction Spending Aug exp 0.1% prev –0.5% (12:00am) **GLOBAL** S&P Global Manufacturing PMI Sep (F)	**2** **EURO ZONE** CPI Sep y/y (P) exp 4.5% prev 3.2% (7:00pm) **JAPAN** Tokyo CPI Sep y/y prev 1.9 (9:30am) Jobless Rate Aug prev 2.4% (9:30am) **NEW ZEALAND** ANZ Consumer Confidence Sep prev 98.0 (7:00am) **UNITED STATES** Fedspeak – Logan (8:45am) Employment Report Sep (10:30pm) Nonfarm Payrolls Chg exp 100k prev 162k Unemployment Rate exp 4.1% prev 4.1% Avg Hourly Earnings exp 0.3% prev 0.3% Factory Orders Aug exp –0.1% prev 0.9% (12:00am) Durable Goods Orders Aug (F) (12:00am)
5 **AUSTRALIA** MI Inflation Gauge Sep y/y prev 4.8% (11:00am) **EURO ZONE** Sentix Investor Confidence Oct prev 5.1 (7:30pm) PPI Aug y/y prev 5.8% (8:00pm) **UNITED STATES** ISM Services Sep prev 55.4 (1:00am) **GLOBAL** S&P Global Services PMI Sep (F)	**6** **AUSTRALIA** Westpac–MI Consumer Sentiment Oct prev 84.4 (10:30am) ANZ–Indeed Job Ads Sep prev 2.5% (11:30am) **EURO ZONE** Ger. Factory Orders Aug prev 2.5% (5:00pm) Retail Sales Aug prev –0.6% (8:00pm) **JAPAN** BoJ Governor Ueda – Speech **UNITED STATES** Trade Balance Aug prev –US$88.6bn (11:30pm)	**7** **CHINA** Foreign Reserves Sep prev US$3438bn **EURO ZONE** Ger. Industrial Production Aug prev –1.1% (5:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Consumer Credit Aug prev US$18.1bn (6:00am) NY Fed 1-Yr Inflation Expectations Sep y/y prev 3.85% (2:00am) FOMC Minutes (5:00am) Consumer Credit Aug prev US$18.1bn (6:00am)	**8** **AUSTRALIA** MI Inflation Expectations Oct y/y prev 4.9% (11:00am) **JAPAN** Current Account Aug prev ¥2988.9bn (10:50am)	**9** **CHINA** Credit & M2 Data Sep (9–15 Oct) New Loans ytd prev CNY10440bn M2 Money Supply y/y prev 7.5% **JAPAN** Household Spending Aug y/y prev –3.6% (10:30am) **UNITED STATES** UoM Consumer Sentiment Oct (P) (1:00am)

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Economic Calendar

October 2026

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
12	**13**	**14**	**15**	**16**
UNITED STATES Fedspeak – Hammack (3:10am)	**AUSTRALIA** RBA Minutes (11:30am) NAB Business Survey (11:30am) Conditions prev –1 Confidence prev –8 **UNITED STATES** NFIB Small Business Optimism Sep prev 98.7 (9:00pm) Existing Home Sales Sep prev –2.0% (1:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Westpac–MI Leading Index Sep ann'd prev –0.09% (10:30am) **CHINA** CPI Sep y/y prev 0.8% (12:30pm) PPI Sep y/y prev 3.8% (12:30pm) Trade Balance Sep prev US$119.1bn **NEW ZEALAND** Net Migration Aug prev 3010.0 (8:45am) **UNITED STATES** CPI Sep prev 0.4% (11:30pm) Federal Reserve's Beige Book (5:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Labour Force Survey Sep (11:30am) Employment Change exp 20k prev 39.5k Unemployment Rate exp 4.6% prev 4.6% Participation Rate exp 67.1% prev 67.0% **EURO ZONE** Industrial Production Aug prev –0.1% (8:00pm) **JAPAN** Core Machinery Orders Aug prev –3.7% (10:50am) Industrial Production Aug (F) (3:30pm) **UNITED KINGDOM** Monthly GDP Aug prev 0.4% (5:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Retail Sales Sep prev 1.2% (11:30pm) Phily Fed Manufacturing Index Oct prev 37.8 (11:30pm) PPI Sep y/y prev 0.4% (11:30pm) Business Inventories Aug prev 0.8% (1:00am)	**EURO ZONE** Trade Balance Aug prev €5.0bn (8:00pm) CPI Sep (F) (8:00pm) **NEW ZEALAND** BusinessNZ Mfg PMI Sep prev 53.1 (8:30am) **UNITED STATES** Import Price Index Sep prev 0.7% (11:30pm) Industrial Production Sep prev 0.0% (12:15am)
19	**20**	**21**	**22**	**23**
AUSTRALIA RBA's Kent – Fireside Chat (10:05am) **CHINA** GDP Q3 y/y prev 4.3% (1:00pm) Activity Data Sep ytd y/y (1:00pm) Retail Sales prev 1.1% Industrial Production prev 5.3% Fixed Asset Investment prev –7.2% **NEW ZEALAND** Trade Balance Sep prev NZ$–1349mn (8:45am) **UNITED KINGDOM** Rightmove House Prices Oct prev 0.7% (10:01am) **UNITED STATES** NAHB Housing Market Index Oct prev 32 (1:00am)	**EURO ZONE** EU ZEW Expectations Oct prev 25.8 (8:00pm) **UNITED KINGDOM** ILO Unemployment Rate Aug prev 4.9% (5:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Housing Starts Sep prev –2.6% (11:30pm) Building Permits Sep (P) prev –2.1% (11:30pm) Pending Home Sales Sep prev 0.3% (1:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** RBA's Hauser – Appearance (9:30am) **UNITED KINGDOM** CPI Sep y/y prev 3.1% (5:00pm) Public Sector Borrowing Sep £18.3bn (5:00pm)	**EURO ZONE** EC Consumer Confidence Oct (P) (1:00am) **NEW ZEALAND** CPI Q3 prev 1.5% (8:45am) **UNITED STATES** Leading Index Sep prev 0.0% (1:00am) Kansas City Fed Manufacturing Index Oct prev 14 (2:00am)	**JAPAN** CPI Sep y/y prev 1.9% (10:30am) **UNITED KINGDOM** GfK Consumer Sentiment Oct prev –13 (10:01am) Retail Sales Sep prev 0.5% (5:00pm) **UNITED STATES** UoM Consumer Sentiment Oct (F) (1:00am) **GLOBAL** S&P Global PMIs Oct (P)

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Economic Calendar

October 2026

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
26	**27**	**28**	**29**	**30**
AUSTRALIA RBA's Jones – Panel (8:40am) **EURO ZONE** IFO Business Climate Survey Oct (8:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Chicago Fed Nat Act Index Sep prev –0.04 (11:30pm) Dallas Fed Manufacturing Index Oct (1:30am)	**CHINA** Industrial Profits Sep y/y (12:30pm) **EURO ZONE** M3 Money Supply Sep y/y (8:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Durable Goods Orders Sep (P) (11:30pm) FHFA House Prices Aug (12:00am) S&P CoreLogic CS House Prices Aug (12:00am) Richmond Fed Manufacturing Index Oct prev –2 (1:00am) New Home Sales Sepprev 6.4% (1:00am) Conf. Board Consumer Confidence Index Oct (1:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** CPI Q3 (11:30am) Headline exp 1.3% prev 0.6% Trimmed Mean exp 0.9% prev 0.8% **NEW ZEALAND** RBNZ Policy Decision prev 2.75% (12:00pm) **UNITED KINGDOM** Autumn Budget (11:30pm) **UNITED STATES** Wholesale Inventories Sep (P) (11:30pm) Building Permits Sep (F) FOMC Policy Decision prev 3.875% (5:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Trade Price Indices Q3 (11:30am) Export Prices prev 1.1% Import Prices prev 5.7% **EURO ZONE** EC Economic Confidence Oct (9:00pm) EC Consumer Confidence Oct (F) (9:00pm) ECB Policy Decision (Deposit Rate) prev 2.50% (12:15am) **NEW ZEALAND** ANZ Business Confidence Oct (11:00am) **UNITED STATES** Personal Income Sep (11:30pm) Personal Spending Sep (11:30pm) PCE Deflator Sep (11:30pm) GDP Q3 (P) (11:30pm)	**AUSTRALIA** PPI Q3 prev 1.3% (11:30am) Private Sector Credit Sep (11:30am) **CHINA** NBS PMIs Oct (12:30pm Sat 31 Oct) Manufacturing Non–Manufacturing **EURO ZONE** GDP Q3 (P) prev 0.6% (9:00pm) Unemployment Rate Sep (9:00pm) **JAPAN** Tokyo CPI Oct y/y (10:30am) Jobless Rate Sep (10:30am) Industrial Production Sep (P) (10:50am) BoJ Policy Decision prev 1.25% **NEW ZEALAND** ANZ Consumer Confidence Oct (8:00am) **UNITED STATES** Employment Cost Index Q3 prev 0.9% (11:30pm) Chicago PMI Oct (12:45am)

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ECONOMIC BULLETIN

Forecast update, October 2026.

9 Oct 2026 | **Kelly Eckhold**, Chief Economist | +64 9 348 9382 | +64 21 786 758 | kelly.eckhold@westpac.co.nz

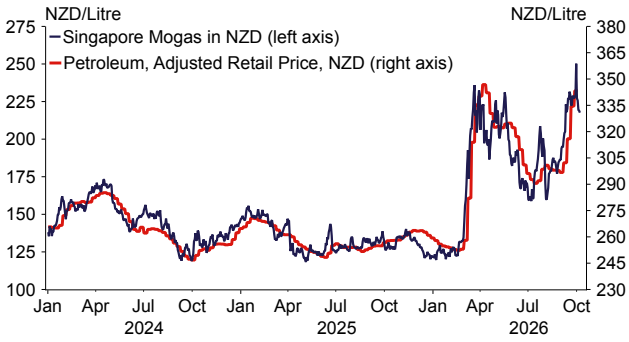
- **Higher oil and refined fuels prices, a lower exchange rate, higher long term interest rates and weak house price trends justify a review of our 2026 forecasts.**
- **We continue to see CPI inflation falling to 3.7% y/y in the September quarter, but now think inflation will rise to 4.2% in the December quarter. Higher global fuel prices and a weaker New Zealand dollar are driving these trends.**
- **Commodity export prices remain robust and are reflected in a rise in our forecast for the 2026/27 Fonterra Milk Price to $9.75/kg. Our opening bid for the Milk Price in 2027/28 is a solid $9.50/kg.**
- **House prices have not stabilised as expected in recent months. As a result, we have revised down our 2026 house price forecast from a small rise to a 1.4% decline.**
- **The combination of high fuel costs and a weak housing market will likely crimp consumer demand running into Christmas.**
- **We have modestly revised down our GDP forecasts for the December quarter, which reduces our 2026 growth forecast to a still solid 2.5%. Risks appear skewed to the downside given higher energy prices and long-term interest rates.**
- **We will look at our 2027 forecasts in the coming week.**
- **Our OCR forecasts remain unchanged. We see a pause at the October meeting and a hike to 3% at the release of the December *Monetary Policy Statement*.**

Inflation – All gas, no brakes.

We've updated our near-term inflation forecasts in response to recent global developments.

We continue to estimate that consumer prices rose by 0.7% in the September quarter, consistent with recent monthly prices updates from Stats NZ. That would see annual inflation ease to 3.7% in the year to September, down from 4.1% in the year to June. We'll confirm that figure next week, when the final monthly prices update for the September quarter is released on 16 October.

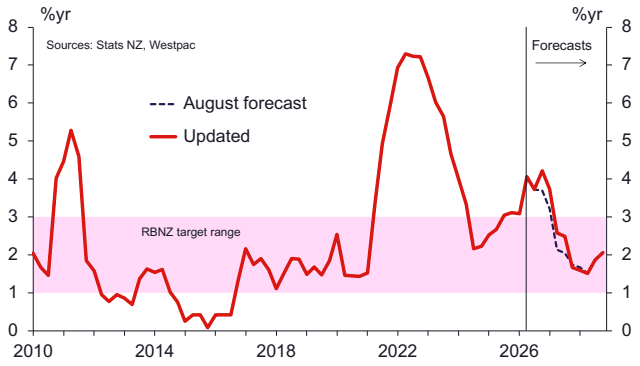
Drivers of NZ petrol prices



Sources: Macrobond, MBIE, RBNZ, Westpac

However, that easing in inflation appears set to be only a temporary reprieve. We now expect consumer prices to rise 1.1% in the December quarter. That would see annual inflation rising to a three-year high of 4.2% by the end of this year. The main driver of this revision are sharply higher global fuel prices, compounded by a more than 4% fall in the New Zealand dollar since the start of September. Together, those developments have already pushed local petrol prices up around 50 cents / litre over the past month, with the nationwide average price of 91 unleaded reaching a record $3.53 / litre earlier this week.

Consumer price inflation forecasts



Our updated year-end inflation forecast is above the RBNZ's September projection of 3.9%. In a recent presentation, **Governor Breman noted** that the rise in oil prices meant the risks to the RBNZ's near-term inflation forecast were to the upside. However, she also noted that the RBNZ's focus was on the medium-term outlook.

We haven't changed our quarterly inflation forecasts for 2027 at this stage. However, the upward revision to our forecast for the December quarter means annual inflation is set to remain firm through most of 2027, consistent with the RBNZ's forecasts. We will review our 2027 forecasts for inflation and growth more comprehensively next week when we will also review our financial forecasts with the release of the Westpac Market Outlook.

Inflation forecasts

		Westpac		RBNZ
		Previous	Updated	
2026	Mar (a)	3.1	3.1	3.1
	Jun (a)	4.1	4.1	4.1
	Sep	3.7	3.7	3.9
	Dec	3.7	4.2	3.9
2027	Mar	3.2	3.7	3.7
	Jun	2.1	2.6	2.6
	Sep	2.0	2.5	2.4
	Dec	1.7	1.7	2.1

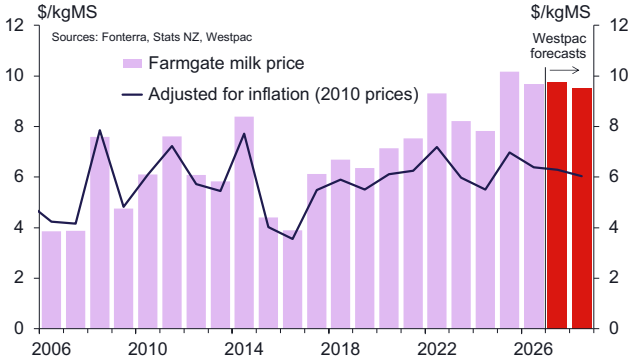
A more tepid housing market.

We had expected the housing market to stabilise through the second half of 2026. However, recent trends have disappointed. House sales volumes continue to weaken, and the median number of days required to sell a house has lengthened to 48 days. Not surprisingly, therefore, average house prices have continued to nudge lower despite more robust conditions in those areas – mostly in the South Island – that are most exposed to the well-performing export sector. The latest indicators suggest no imminent change in this trend.

Given these weak trends, our previous forecast for essentially flat house prices through the September and December quarters now looks too optimistic. We have revised down our house price forecast for the 2026 year from a rise of 0.6% y/y to a fall of 1.4% y/y on a national basis. This is consistent with quarterly falls in house prices of 0.5% and 0.8% q/q over the September and December quarters.

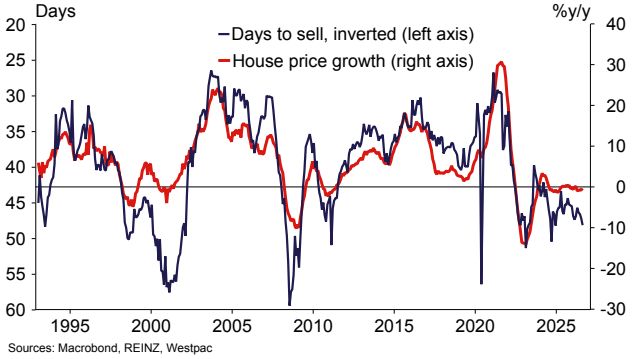
The still weak labour market, higher mortgage rates and still moderate employment growth all point to a weak housing market for the foreseeable future. Risks remain tilted towards another weak year in 2027. This would especially be the case if increased taxation of capital gains on investor housing were to occur as a result of the outcome of the 2026 General Election.

Farmgate milk price

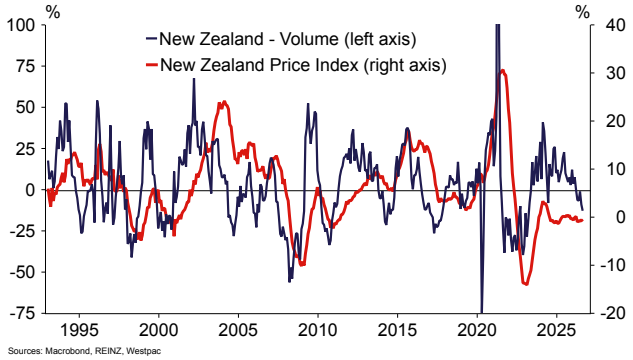


It's likely to be the case that there will be divergent trends in the housing market across the country. Income and employment trends in tourism and agriculture dominated regions are expected to remain robust. Our upgrade to the 2026/27 Milk Price released in our recent **Agri Bites report** emphasises this point. But it looks like it will be a while before investors and homeowners in the major metropolitan areas in the North Island will be feeling wealthier through a rising home value. On balance this is likely to crimp consumer spending attitudes through the end of 2026 and might moderate the recovery in the construction sector that is underway.

Annual house price growth and Median days to sell



Annual house price growth and house sales volumes



Sources: Macrobond, REINZ, Westpac

Growth forecasts moderated a touch.

Our short-term growth forecasts still appear to be in the ballpark of what seems likely given recent trends. Recent consumer and business confidence surveys have suggested resilience of the economy to recent rises in energy prices and long-term interest rates. However, it's likely the rise in energy prices in particular will eat into consumer spending appetites towards the end of 2026 should current levels of fuel prices be sustained.

We have knocked off a modest amount off our forecast for consumer spending in the December quarter to reflect these risks and will look more closely at the implications for 2027 growth in coming weeks. Certainly, the large rise in long term interest rates may be relevant for 2027 growth trends. The election outcome introduces two-sided risks to the 2027 growth outlook that are hard to quantify at this early stage. We currently expect 2.5% y/y growth for the 2026 year.

We don't see a need to change our labour market forecasts for 2026 at this point. Signs continue to accumulate suggesting strengthening employment growth – although it will be a while before a noticeable drop in the unemployment rate is evident.

Implications for the OCR.

We are leaving our forecasts of the OCR unchanged. Since the July 2026 Monetary Policy Review, we have anticipated the RBNZ will slow the pace of OCR increases now the 3% neutral level (in the RBNZ's view) is coming into view.

The RBNZ sent a clear signal that they expected to pause in October and raise the OCR just one more time in December. We still think this is the most likely scenario. The recent data has boosted the short-term inflation profile but at this stage there is little evidence of rising inflation expectations or more persistent inflationary pressures. There are some risks to the growth outlook – albeit two sided – to consider. Taking the time to assess the impact of the OCR rises to date and the strategy going forward makes sense to us. We don't see a shift in the MPC's strategy in October.

We continue to think it most likely that the RBNZ will have more work to do in 2027. However, there is a lot of water to go under the bridge before then. The OCR increases that have occurred to date, and the one further expected increase in December will position the MPC well to respond to conditions in 2027 as they unfold. The unexpected rise in long term interest rates that has occurred in the last 6 weeks or so has tightened monetary conditions and has at least offset the easing in conditions coming from the weaker exchange rate over the same period.

Economic and financial forecasts

Economic indicators	Quarterly % change				Annual % change			
	Jun-26	Sep-26	Dec-26	Mar-27	2025	2026	2027	2028
GDP	0.2	0.6	0.7	1.1	1.6	2.5	3.0	3.4
GDP (annual average)	-	-	-	-	0.3	2.4	2.8	3.1
Consumer price index	1.5	0.7	1.1	0.4	3.1	4.2	1.7	2.1
Employment change	0.5	0.6	0.6	0.6	0.2	1.9	2.5	2.3
Unemployment rate	5.6	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.4	5.4	4.9	4.4
Labour cost index (all sectors)	0.6	0.6	0.6	0.5	2.0	2.3	2.3	2.3
Current account balance (% of GDP)	-3.2	-3.9	-4.1	-4.1	-3.0	-4.1	-4.0	-4.0
Terms of trade	-4.5	-0.6	1.8	2.7	3.3	-4.6	5.7	1.5
House price index	-0.3	-0.5	-0.8	0.3	-0.1	-1.4	1.8	4.1

Financial forecasts	End of quarter				End of year			
	Jun-26	Sep-26	Dec-26	Mar-27	2025	2026	2027	2028
Official Cash Rate	2.25	2.75	3.00	3.50	2.25	3.00	4.00	3.75
90 day bank bill	2.63	2.99	3.40	3.75	2.52	3.40	4.20	3.95
2 year swap	3.47	3.72	3.95	4.10	2.71	3.95	4.20	4.10
5 year swap	3.88	4.07	4.20	4.30	3.27	4.20	4.40	4.35
10 year bond	4.61	4.75	4.75	4.90	4.27	4.75	5.05	5.05
TWI	66.5	66.1	65.7	67.4	66.4	65.7	71.1	70.5
NZD/USD	0.58	0.58	0.59	0.61	0.57	0.59	0.65	0.65
NZD/AUD	0.82	0.82	0.82	0.84	0.87	0.82	0.89	0.90
NZD/EUR	0.50	0.51	0.50	0.51	0.49	0.50	0.54	0.54
NZD/GBP	0.44	0.43	0.43	0.44	0.43	0.43	0.47	0.46

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Week beginning 28 September 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: When your assumptions have only upside risk.

The Week That Was: The importance of supply.

Focus on New Zealand: Along for the ride.

For the week ahead:

Australia: RBA policy decision, CPI, private sector credit, Cotality home value index, household spending indicator, Q3 job vacancies, trade balance, dwelling approvals, RBA financial stability review.

New Zealand: Building permits, business confidence, consumer confidence.

Japan: CPI, jobless rate, industrial production, Tankan large manufacturers index.

China: NBS PMIs, RatingDog PMIs, industrial profits.

Euro Area: CPI, unemployment rate, economic confidence.

United States: nonfarm payrolls, unemployment rate, personal income and spending, PCE deflator.

Global: S&P Global Manufacturing PMIs.

Information contained in this report current as at 25 September 2026.

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When your assumptions have only upside risk

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

- **Any forecast rests on assumptions. Each might be individually reasonable, but if they all tilt in the same direction, they look less plausible in combination.**
- **Different assumptions can also drive different conclusions, as can be seen in Treasury and RBA views on trend growth in supply capacity. Treasury's long-term view on both productivity growth and labour force participation trends is systematically less downbeat than the RBA's (shorter-term) view. Treasury's estimate of the stable-inflation rate of unemployment is also lower than the RBA's estimate.**
- **We consider the risks around the RBA's view to be asymmetric. The RBA's assumptions implicitly require a repeat of the factors that dragged recent productivity outcomes down, despite strong global investment, policy changes domestically and the possible benefits of AI. Some observers appear to extrapolate this weakness beyond the RBA's forecast horizon. But this would be hard to square with the reasonable belief that the global interest rate structure will be higher in future than it was pre-pandemic. A systematic tilt, even if unintentional and understandable, may point to the likely direction of future surprises.**

Any forecast rests on assumptions, and the further out you forecast, the harder it is to ground those assumptions in something real. Add the uncertainty about AI, where predictions range from "unbounded prosperity without needing to work" to "we will all be dead in a couple of years", and you can see why assuming the future looks like the past is an attractive fall-back position.

How much of the past, though? This is the context for the debate about the Intergenerational Review (IGR) released this week. In one corner, Treasury assumes that future productivity growth will average 1.2%yr over the next 40 years, in line with the 30-year average, and that labour force participation will continue to trend up, as it has for the past five decades, until 2040. In the other corner, the RBA assumes that productivity growth will average 0.7%yr, in line with the past 20 years – essentially the post-GFC and pandemic period – and that participation rates will be flat to down in the near term.

Both productivity assumptions have limitations: round-number-of-year averages might be distorted by capturing a downturn without the matching upturn, or vice versa. Peak-to-peak or trough-to-trough is always preferable. Even that calculation cannot escape the weakness of recent years, though.

To be fair, the RBA's productivity assumptions relate only to the short term and are not strictly comparable to the IGR, as the Governor has emphasised this week. By contrast, the near-term divergence in forecasts for the participation rate, which my colleague Ryan Wells first highlighted in May, is a genuine divergence.

The RBA's more downbeat set of assumptions could be unwittingly contributing to a self-fulfilling talking-down of Australia's prospects that clearly appeals to some commentators outside the public sector. Many in this group view productivity growth as stemming wholly or mostly from policy "reforms", harking back to the halcyon Hawke–Keating era of deregulation. Proponents point to the lack of reform recently to justify this downbeat view of growth capacity. We think this misses the global nature of that slowdown.

> **"RBA assumptions collectively imply a downbeat view of supply growth."**

Part of the trouble with the downbeat view of future productivity is that it implicitly assumes that the factors weighing on productivity growth in the past will continue. But there are good reasons not to expect the same post-GFC weakness in risk appetite, and so investment and capital accumulation, decades later and absent another crisis. The AI boom and associated resurgence of risk appetite make it hard to argue that we will see the same lack of new productivity-enhancing technologies and general malaise as that period.

For Australia specifically, assuming the same low average productivity growth as the past 20 years would require assuming a compositional drag similar to a repeat of the run-up of the care economy and decline in measured mining production over the past 15 years. To be fair, decarbonisation does imply further declines in (capital-intensive, high-productivity) coal production, dragging mining productivity down further. It would be a stretch, though, to assume expansion in critical and transition minerals provides no offset.

We can grant that AI's impact on productivity will take a while to come through and still expect some boost in coming years – at least by the end of the RBA's forecast horizon in 2028. Indeed, some observers already see an AI-induced boost to service-sector activity in the recent upside surprise in UK GDP. Some productivity pessimists might want to argue that the

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rest of the world will benefit from the AI boom, but somehow not Australia, or not until later. Such an extraordinary claim requires a mechanism explaining that divergence, though.

The Productivity Commission estimated back in December that AI could boost multifactor productivity by 2.3%pt over the course of the next decade, or roughly a quarter-point per year extra growth on average – a big difference in the scheme of usual growth rates in output and productivity. Labour productivity growth would be boosted a little more; the data centre boom is expanding the capital stock. But an estimate published in December is unlikely to adequately capture the step change in capability of the main models, especially the coding and agentic harnesses, that emerged over the summer of 2025/26. Given what we understand to be limited adoption of AI in the Australian public sector, policymakers might also be systematically underestimating both the technology's capabilities and the breadth of uptake in the private sector.

As an illustration of how downbeat you need to be to extrapolate the RBA's near-term assumption further out, suppose that all AI does is make about 10% of the economy 10% more productive over four years. This extra 1% of economy-wide productivity is well below most estimates of the impact. It would nonetheless add a quarter-point on annual productivity growth for four years, bringing a downbeat 0.7% assumption up to almost 1%.

A deeper challenge is that, beyond the RBA's near-term horizon, low productivity growth is hard to square with a higher future average for interest rates globally.

We note, for example, recent comments by RBA Deputy Governor Hauser, pointing to 700 years of bond yield data to suggest that the post-GFC period of low interest rates was an anomaly, something we noted two years ago. The global structure of interest rates emerges to balance global saving and investment, and stronger investment for AI and other purposes is clearly in evidence. We find it implausible to assume that all that investment happens, pushing up global yields, and none of it delivers higher productivity. Even increased defence spending has historically had productivity payoffs, as Ukraine's drone manufacturing ecosystem has exemplified recently.

It is understandable that when inflation is above target, a central bank would rather err on the side of caution than techno-optimism. They know that being downbeat, and running policy a little too tight, means a faster return of inflation to target, which is no bad thing for an inflation-targeting central bank.

It matters, though, when those understandable assumptions are systematically one-sided. If there are arguments that productivity growth over the next few years will be even lower than the 0.7%yr 20-year average, we are yet to see them. In contrast, there are reasonable arguments for it to be a bit higher.

Similarly, the RBA's participation rate assumptions are low given near-term demographic trends, and out of step with Treasury's revised projections. Today's labour market data for August shows the participation rate rising again, to just 12½ basis points below the January 2025 all-time high. This supports the idea that RBA's view on participation trends is too downbeat. The IGR's NAIRU (stable-inflation rate of unemployment) assumption is a quarter-point or so below RBA estimates revealed in various FOI requests and the Governor's comments this week.

Together, the three RBA assumptions imply weaker growth in supply capacity and thus more inflationary pressure for any given level of demand. If every one of your assumptions seems individually plausible, but all skew in the one direction, it starts to look like a pattern. The thumb on the scale is unlikely to be intentional, but it does suggest the likely direction of future surprises in the medium term.

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Cliff Notes: the importance of supply

Elliot Clarke, Head of International Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist
Illiana Jain, Economist

Australia's only data release this week was the August Labour Force Survey. Employment surprised to the upside, rising 39.5k. But, once again, new labour demand was more than offset by supply as the participation rate bounced 0.2ppts higher to 67.1%, just shy of January 2025's 115-year high of 67.2%. As a result, the unemployment rate increased from 4.5% to 4.6% and was close to rounding up to 4.7% (4.65% to two decimal places).

There may be some residual seasonality in August's print related to the new survey collection model. However, the underlying trend is still consistent with a gradual easing in the labour market, seeing the unemployment rate drift higher. We expect this to continue through to the first half of 2027.

The strength in labour force participation also speaks to the broader issue of Australia's supply capacity. As discussed by Chief Economist Luci Ellis, the RBA's assumptions around participation, productivity and the NAIRU collectively skew towards a weak assessment of supply capacity. For participation in particular, the RBA's near-term assumptions are downbeat compared to recent demographic trends and also sit below Treasury's longer-term projections as set out in the 2026 IGR. As above, the August LFS emphasises that slack could emerge more quickly than the RBA's forecasts imply without an outright fall in employment.

Ahead of next week's RBA meeting and inflation data, our latest state-level analysis provides perspective on the persistence of underlying price pressures, particularly the importance of housing-related components. For a broader assessment of the fiscal backdrop and the implications for the states, our latest state fiscal update explores how the housing market correction and changes to NDIS funding arrangements are pressuring state finances.

Before turning to this week's events offshore, it is important to highlight that last Friday the Bank of Japan raised its policy rate by 25bp to 1.25%. Policymakers maintained a constructive assessment of the economy, pointing to resilient consumption, ongoing labour market tightness, and solid investment spending. More importantly, the Bank expressed growing confidence that inflation is increasingly being sustained by domestic wage and demand dynamics rather than imported cost shocks alone.

In our view, the emphasis placed on improving underlying inflation dynamics suggests policymakers are becoming increasingly comfortable that inflation is able to be sustained by domestic demand and wage growth. Normalisation is likely to remain gradual, but the Bank appears firmly on a path towards further tightening, with rates likely to reach 1.5% by mid-2027.

This week, market participants have focused on discussions between the US and China on trade, security and technology as President Xi visits Washington.

Preliminary discussions between US Treasury Secretary Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng ahead of President Xi's arrival in Washington were characterised by both sides as productive, and Treasury Secretary Bessent subsequently announced that discussions in Washington would leave trade negotiations for upcoming meetings between the two leaders in Shenzhen and Miami. To allow room for this deferral, the current trade truce will be extended until January 2027. President Trump subsequently outlined that discussions during President Xi's Washington visit would instead focus on security, technology and AI.

A more constructive tone was also seen between the US and Iran overnight, if press reports are accurate. According to Bloomberg and Reuters, sources suggest the US and Iran are again exploring a staged deal which would see Iran re-open the Strait of Hormuz and the US lift its blockade of Iranian ports. Negotiations are occurring on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly, with Qatari officials mediating.

President Trump continues to show little interest in a deal before November's mid-term elections, but the global economy is under increasing pressure as the price of Brent oil hovers between USD100 and USD110 while refining spreads add additional impetus to refined product prices. The mooted consideration of a potential US diesel export ban this week makes clear that the US is not immune from this pressure despite having significant domestic energy supply and refining capacity, relative to their own demand.

The consequences of the current energy supply shock and other disruptions the US have experienced over the past year remain front of mind for FOMC members. Those speaking this week such as NY and Cleveland Fed Presidents Williams and Hammack highlighted the risk to inflation expectations from a series of supply shocks when the economy is fully employed, and the likelihood of an additional hike(s) being required to rein in current inflation momentum and risks. Williams noted that expectations of another hike by year end are "reasonable" and that the FOMC have "a lot of work to do". Debt market's concern remains acute, having now almost priced in four hikes over the coming year and taken the US 10-year above 5.00%, currently 5.20%.

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Along for the ride

Michael Gordon
Senior Economist

There was plenty of action in the markets this week, as global interest rates continued to move higher, and New Zealand was taken along for the ride. In the US, strong economic data and resurgent oil prices have led the market to believe that the central bank will need to get on with the job and hike its policy rate further in the months ahead. Longer-term US interest rates have continued to lift sharply, driving both a rise in domestic interest rates and a fall in the New Zealand dollar, with the trade-weighted index already 4% below what the RBNZ assumed in its September Monetary Policy Statement.

While the September MPS worked to dampen market expectations about the pace of future rate hikes, offshore developments have seen market pricing for the OCR bounce back and exceed previous levels. Interest rate markets are currently pricing around a 75% chance of a hike at the 28 October policy review, with a high chance of another hike on top of this at the 9 December review. We'd question whether the RBNZ's thinking has really shifted to that degree in the last few weeks though.

Notably, the RBNZ provided some unscheduled comments on the monetary policy outlook this week, in what was otherwise a very light local news week. In connection with a visit to Dunedin by Governor Breman and other RBNZ leaders, the RBNZ put out a media release that included the following:

"If higher oil prices persist, they are expected to result in somewhat higher near-term inflation than we assumed in the September Statement... As always, we will assess incoming data and global developments ahead of our next decision in October and remain focused on the outlook for inflation over the medium term."

Both of these statements are fairly benign and factual in themselves. What's more notable is that the RBNZ felt the need to make a public comment at all; the occasion didn't require one. (The Governor's presentation at a business lunch was originally billed as being based on material from the September MPS, with no new insights.)

If the intention was to guide market expectations for the October meeting lower, it wasn't entirely successful. Indeed, the market initially fixated on the first part of the statement – higher near-term inflation – and pushed pricing for an October hike even higher on the day. While this was unwound the following day, market pricing for OCR hikes remains higher than it was at the start of the week.

As it stands, that leaves the RBNZ with the prospect of rattling the market if it follows through with the October pause that it signalled in September MPS. However, it's possible that the local and offshore economic data, together with geopolitical developments, could shift market pricing in the meantime. Domestically, the NZIER's quarterly survey of business opinion (6 Oct) and the September quarter CPI (22 Oct) will be especially important in that regard.

Turning to the data, the only release this week was our Employment Confidence Index, produced in conjunction with McDermott Miller. Compared to our consumer confidence survey, there was a relatively weak bounce in employment confidence in the September quarter. The index rose by 3.2 points to 86.3, leaving it at the second-lowest level on record for this survey going back to 2004.

Perceptions of current job opportunities were unchanged at a net -60%. This is the component of the survey that seems to have the most predictive power for near-term labour market conditions and is broadly consistent with the unemployment rate holding at its current 11-year high of 5.6%. Hiring has remained soft to an unusual degree for this stage of the economic cycle, and those who are out of the workforce have been finding it increasingly difficult to get in.

It's clear that there is still substantial slack in the labour market and little upward pressure on wages, which would push back somewhat against the market's view that the RBNZ will need to pick up the pace and deliver two more OCR hikes before Christmas. The RBNZ doesn't need to have employment formally in its mandate for it to be attentive to the signals coming from the labour market.

The data flow picks up again next week, with monthly releases for employment, building activity, and business and consumer confidence – see our previews on the following page. The other release of note is the Pre-Election Fiscal and Economic Update (PREFU) on Tuesday. This 'book opening' exercise is designed to create a level playing field, allowing parties outside the current Government and the public more generally to judge to the state of the public finances in the leadup to the General Election on 7 November. In the case of the opposition parties, it will also allow them to calibrate the spending and taxation policies on which they will campaign. See our preview for the details on what we expect from this release.

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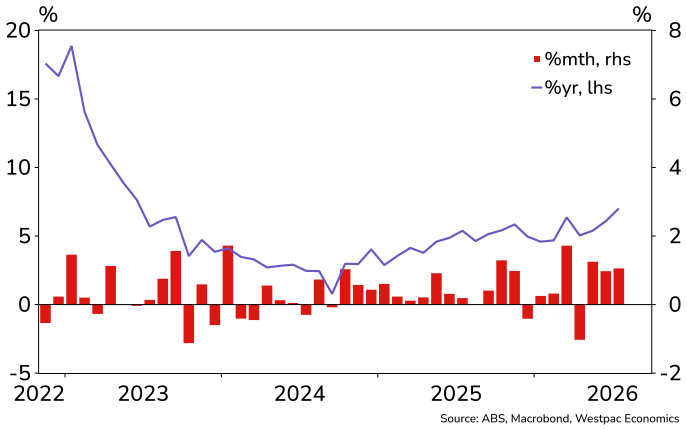
AUS: Aug Household Spending Indicator (%mth)

Sep 29, Last: 1.1%, WBC f/c: –0.5%
Mkt f/c: 0.3%, Range: –0.5% to 0.7%

The household spending indicator rose 1.1%mth in July, comfortably exceeding expectations and extending the strong momentum evident through the middle of the year. Annual growth accelerated to 7.0%yr, the fastest pace since early 2023.

Our Westpac-DataX Card Tracker points to softer spending conditions through August and early September, with higher fuel prices increasingly driving spending growth and, at the margin, squeezing spending elsewhere. The detail suggests a modest rotation away from discretionary categories, with hospitality spending easing and vehicle sales also likely moderating after a strong June quarter. Together with a softer read from our MHSI-aligned card measure, we anticipate the household spending indicator will decline 0.5%mth in August.

Monthly household spending indicator



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: RBA Policy Decision (%)

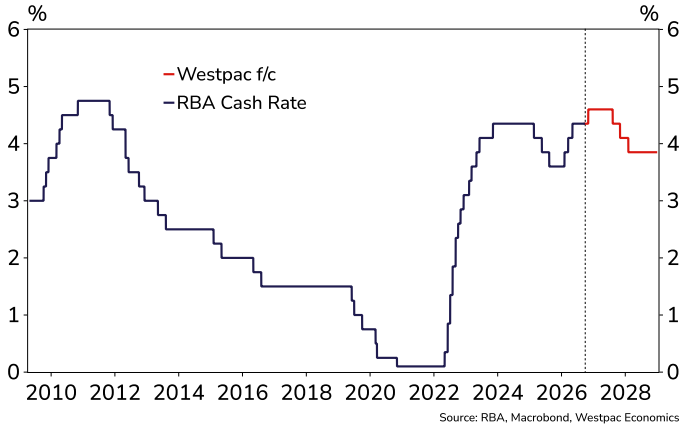
Sep 29, Last: 4.35, Westpac f/c: 4.60
Market f/c: 4.60, Range: 4.60

Westpac anticipates the RBA Monetary Policy Board will raise the cash rate by 25bps to 4.60% at its September meeting.

As discussed by Chief Economist Luci Ellis recent rhetoric from the RBA have escalated, particularly with Governor Bullock flagging that upside inflation risks appear to be "materialising" – the conditionality set in August for further rate hikes.

There is a risk of a follow-up hike, though it crucially depends on the data flow after the meeting. For September, we continue to expect a split vote at the meeting, with material differences in opinion about trend growth in supply capacity, as discussed on Page 2.

RBA rate hike expected in September



Source: RBA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: Aug Headline CPI (%mth)

Sep 30, Last: 1.0, Westpac f/c: 0.4
Market f/c: 0.5, Range: 0.4 to 0.9

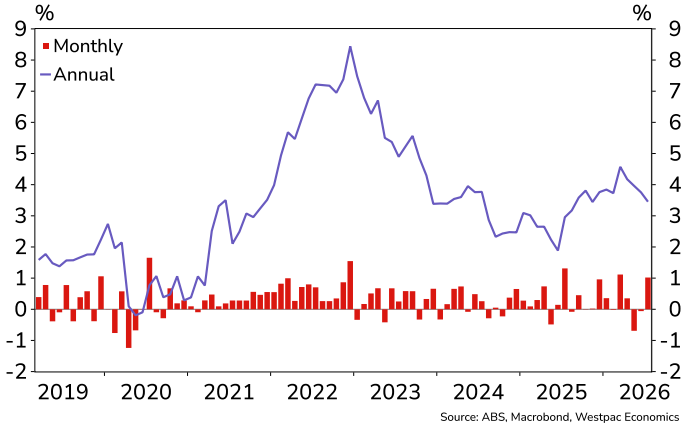
The July CPI reversed May and June weakness with a larger than expected 1.0% increase. This was stronger than Westpac's expectation of 0.8% and market's expectation of 0.9%. The annual pace eased to 3.5%yr from 3.8%yr.

We are looking for a 0.4% increase in the August CPI. Food & non-alcoholic beverages to rise 0.2%mth with solid gains for bread & cereal products (0.4%), meat & seafood (0.5%) and food products n.e.c. (0.4%) partially offset by falling non-alcoholic beverages (–0.6%) and a soft print for meals out & take away food (0.1%).

At two decimal points it is a 0.43% increase in August so the risk this month is to the upside.

For more details please see "August CPI Preview".

Monthly Headline Inflation



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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AUS: Aug Trimmed Mean CPI (%mth)

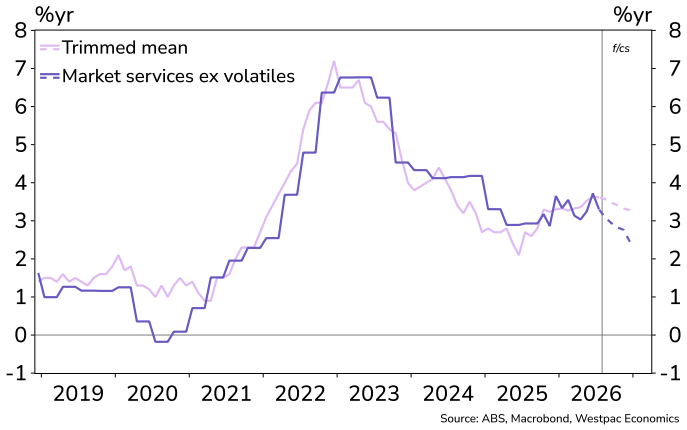
Sep 30, Last: 0.5, Westpac f/c: 0.2
Market f/c: 0.3, Range: 0.2 to 0.4

The Trimmed Mean (TM) lifted 0.5%mth/3.5%yr, on par with last July which was the strongest monthly read in the series' short history. The result was stronger than both our and the market's expectation of 0.4%mth.

August TM is expected to rise 0.2%mth lifting the annual pace to 3.6%yr. For market services excluding volatiles and holiday travel we have pencilled in a step down to 0.1%mth, this series lifted 0.8% in July possibly due to the larger-than-expected increase in minimum wages.

The distribution of the August TM is from a low of –0.32%mth to a high of 0.53%mth. Remembering the TM is seasonally adjusted, with rents (+0.17%mth) and dwellings (+0.20%mth) mostly locking in the TM. See "August CPI Preview".

Monthly Underlying Inflation Indicators



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

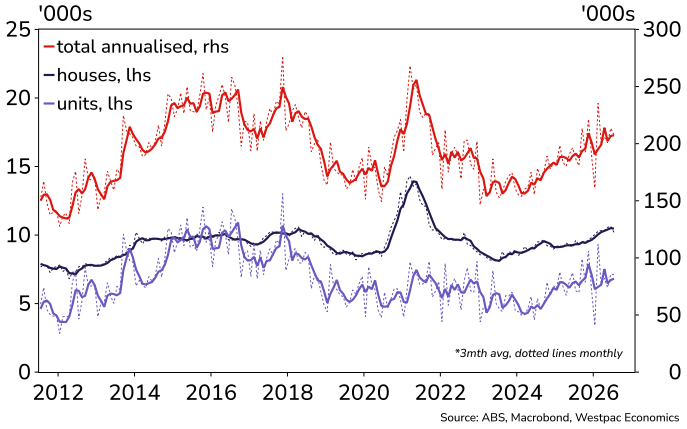
AUS: Aug Dwelling Approvals (%mth)

Sep 30, Last: –3.6, Westpac f/c: –5.0
Market f/c: –1.0, Range: –6.0 to 1.0

Dwelling approvals fell 3.6%mth in July, with annual growth easing to 9.0%yr. The decline was driven primarily by detached dwellings, although unit approvals also edged lower. The result suggests higher interest rates may be starting to weigh on new housing demand.

We expect a similar story to play out in August, with elevated interest rates continuing to weigh on detached dwelling approvals, while the unit segment holds broadly steady. Overall, dwelling approvals are expected to decline 5%mth. While risks remain tilted to the downside, residential construction should remain relatively resilient through 2026, supported by the strong lift in approvals through the first half of the year and a sizeable pipeline of work yet to be done.

Building approvals



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

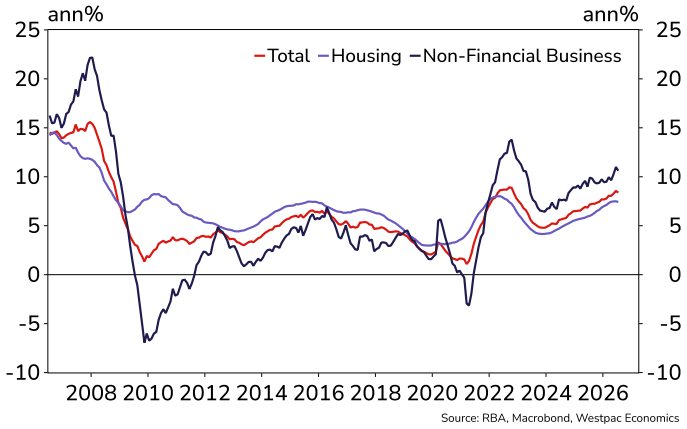
AUS: Aug Private Sector Credit (%mth)

Sep 30, Last: 0.6, Westpac f/c: 0.5
Market f/c: 0.5, Range: 0.3 to 0.6

Growth in private sector credit growth appeared unsustainable over May-Jun, especially given the slowing in the housing market. Come July, the pace now dropped from 0.8%mth to 0.6%mth. Housing credit the main source of weakness, with investor credit growth beginning to adjust lower in response to higher interest rates, lower house prices and, most importantly, tax changes for investment properties. Meanwhile, business borrowing continued to rise rapidly.

For August, we have pencilled in a 0.5%mth increase, and we look for continued divergence between housing and business segments.

Private sector credit growth



Source: RBA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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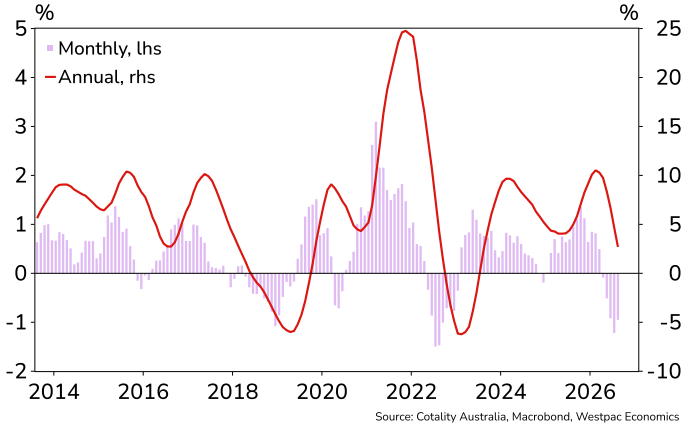
AUS: Sep Cotality Home Value Index (%mth)

Oct 1, Last: –0.9, Westpac f/c: –0.9

The Cotality home value index – covering all of Australia – fell 0.9% in August following downwardly-revised 1.2% and 0.9% declines in July and June. Annual growth slowed to 2.7%yr. Prices nationally are now 3.6% below their peak in March.

The September update is set to see more of the same with the daily measure (covering the five major capital cities rather than all of Australia) tracking a 1.2% decline in line with this measure's August move. Annual growth looks like to stall about flat. The detail suggests monthly declines have accelerated in Brisbane, Perth and Adelaide but moderated a touch in Melbourne, noting that there is a seasonal element to price moves in Sep. Markets are still adjusting to higher interest rates and the tax policy changes introduced in the May Federal budget with more weakness likely into year-end.

Dwelling price correction deepening



Source: Cotality Australia, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

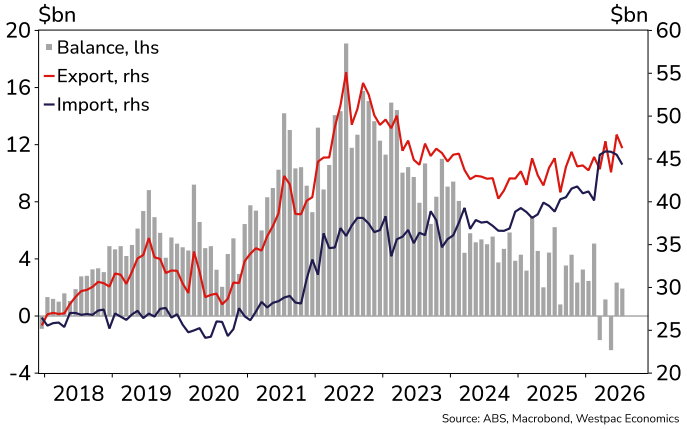
AUS: Aug Goods Trade Balance ($bn)

Oct 1, Last: 1.9, Westpac f/c: 2.3
Market f/c: 2.2, Range: 1.5 to 2.5

The goods trade surplus narrowed slightly to $1.9bn in July but remained above our and consensus expectations. This was down from an upwardly revised surplus of $2.3bn in June. Underneath the modest headline change was considerable volatility among components, especially in flows of non-monetary gold, remain the chief culprit.

For August, we have pencilled in a slight widening of the trade surplus to $2.3bn. Port data points to a bounce-back in coal and iron ore export volumes, and prices looked to have edged higher. However, volatility in non-monetary gold trade and other hard-to-predict sub-categories (like ADP equipment) remain a wildcard.

More volatility in goods trade to be expected



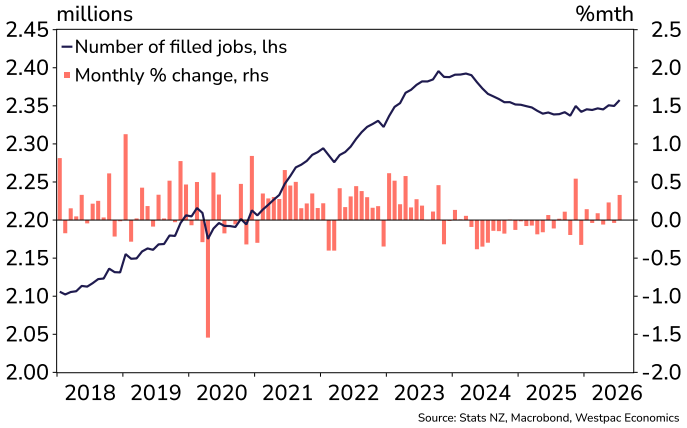
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Aug Monthly Employment Indicator (%mth)

Sep 28, Last: 0.3, Westpac f/c: 0.3

The MEI has continued to tick higher in recent months, showing that the jobs market has held its ground through the Iran conflict and the consequent surge in fuel prices. The weekly snapshots provided by Stats NZ have been running ahead of year-ago levels and suggest another solid result for August – we've pencilled in a 0.3% increase, following a similar rise in July. However, the history of this indicator suggests that both months are likely to be revised down a bit from their initial release.

Monthly Employment Indicator



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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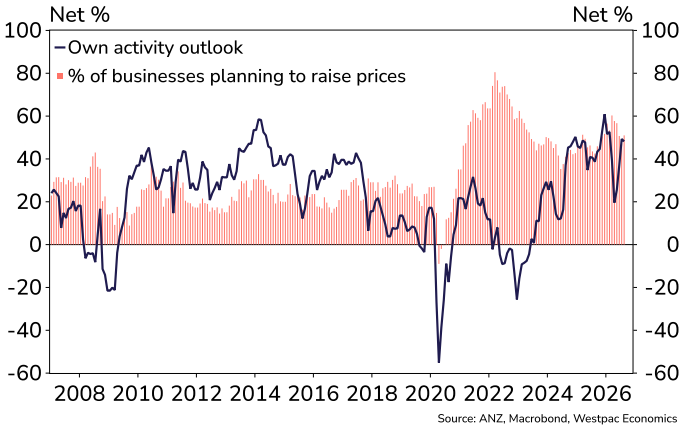
NZ: Sep ANZ Business Confidence (index)

Sep 30, Last: 53.7

Business confidence was steady in August, after having rebounded to around pre-conflict levels in the previous month. The renewed pressure on global oil prices is likely to challenge that confidence in the coming months, although we likely won't see the full impact in the September survey as the largest gains in fuel prices at the pump occurred in the later part of the month. The pricing measures of the survey will be of particular interest to the RBNZ ahead of the 28 October OCR review, particularly given their concerns about the possibility of firms using fuel prices as cover to increase their own margins.

ANZ Business Outlook survey



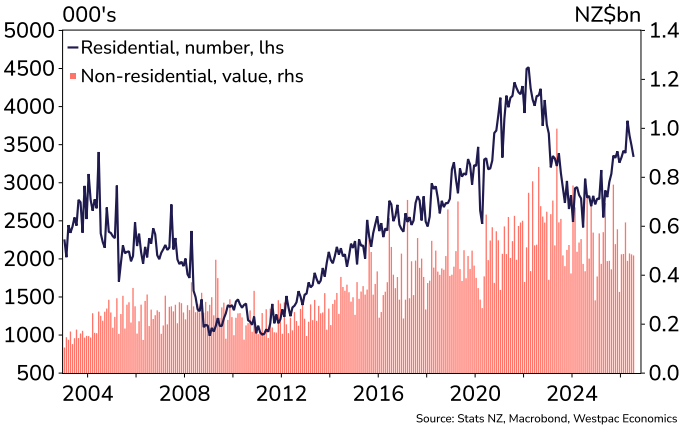
Source: ANZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Aug Building Consents (%mth)

Oct 1, Last: -4.3, Westpac f/c: Flat

While residential building consent numbers remain firm, they have been flattening off. Consents fell 4.3% in July, the third decline in a row. We expect that consents will be flat in August but with the risk tilted towards a small dip. Stepping back and looking at the longer-term trend, annual consent issuance is at a three-year high and we expect it will nudge higher again this month. However, there are questions about how long that momentum will be sustained given the softness in the housing market. We suspect the peak is getting close. In the non-residential space, we've seen softness in the number of retail and office developments, but greater resilience in the industrial segment.

NZ building consents



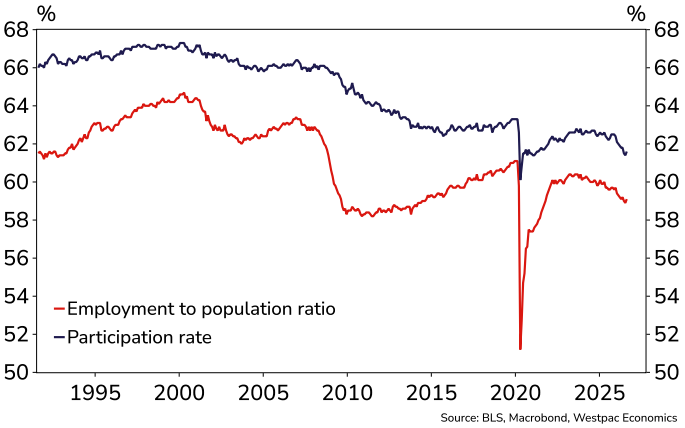
Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

US Sep employment report

Oct 2, payrolls, Last: 162k, Mkt f/c: 100k, WBC f/c: 80k
Oct 2, U/E rate, Last: 4.1%, Mkt f/c: 4.1%, WBC f/c: 4.2%

Nonfarm payrolls surprised to the upside in August, registering a gain of 162k with 55k in back revisions to June and July. The report left the 3-month average at 71k, near the top of the estimated range consitent with balance between labour demand and supply. Come September, the trend is expected to remain in place with a 80k gain forecast. With inflation risks paramount, upward revisions will have a greater impact on market variables than a negative revision.
The decline in the participation rate over the past year has capped the unemployment rate. Participation is likely to edge higher in September and take the unemployment rate up to 4.2% with it. There is little available slack in the labour market, but plenty just outside if demand lifts.

Participation masks emerging slack



Source: BLS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Mon 28							
NZ	Aug	Employment Indicator	%mth	0.3	–	0.3	Both Jul and Aug likely to be revised down from initial prints.
Chn	Aug	Industrial Profits	%ann	11.2	–	–	Profit growth solid but slowing amid elevated oil prices.
US	Sep	Dallas Fed Manufacturing	index	11.6	7.3	–	Jump into expansion welcome, persistence will be key.
Tue 29							
Aus	Aug	Household Spending Indicator	%mth	1.1	0.3	–0.5	Higher fuel prices are squeezing discretionary spending.
	Sep	RBA Policy Decision	%	4.35	4.60	4.60	Rate hike expected, with a split vote the likely outcome.
NZ		Pre-Election Economic & Fiscal Update	–	–	–	–	Required update of forecasts ahead of the 7 Nov election.
Eur	Sep	EC Economic Confidence	index	98.4	98.8	–	Confidence recovery taking holding, both business and consumer.
US	Jul	S&P/CS Home Price Index	%mth	0.24	0.20	–	Price growth moving past trough, but constrained by rates.
	Aug	JOLTS Job Openings	000s	7271	7225	–	More-or-less stable job openings points to balance.
	Sep	Conf. Board Consumer Confidence	index	89.4	90.0	–	Continues to bump around deeply pessimistic lows.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Goolsbee, Williams.
Wed 30							
Aus	Aug	Monthly CPI	%ann	3.5	4.1	4.0	The risk remains to the upside.
	Aug	Private Sector Credit	%mth	0.6	0.5	0.5	Housing and business credit growth trends diverge.
	Aug	Dwelling Approvals	%mth	–3.6	–1.0	–5.0	Elevated interest rates are likely to continue to weigh.
NZ	Sep	ANZ Business Confidence	index	53.7	–	–	Rising fuel prices could dent confidence again.
Jpn	Aug	Industrial Production	%mth	–0.2	1.4	–	Likely lifted in August supported by car manufacturing and AI.
Chn	Sep	NBS Manufacturing PMI	index	49.8	50.1	–	Official gauges point to a more benign picture for activity ...
	Sep	NBS Non-Manufacturing PMI	index	49.0	49.3	–	... downtrend in services reflective of cautious consumers ...
	Sep	RatingDog Manufacturing PMI	index	51.5	51.6	–	... unofficial RatingDog gauges paint a more positive picture ...
	Sep	RatingDog Services PMI	index	51.4	51.1	–	... which may reflect their more export-oriented nature.
US	Aug	PCE Deflator	%mth	0.2	0.4	–	Persistent inflation pressures continue to chip away ...
	Aug	Personal Income	%mth	0.4	0.5	–	... nominal gains in household incomes, putting pressure ...
	Aug	Personal Spending	%mth	0.2	0.9	–	... on real spending volumes, which are closer to flat.
	Q2	GDP	%ann'd	1.5	1.5	–	Final estimate.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Barkin, Cook, Goolsbee, Kashkari.
Thu 01							
Aus	Sep	Cotality Home Value Index	%mth	–0.9	–	–0.9	Declines likely to have accelerated in Brisbane, Perth, and Adelaide.
		RBA Financial Stability Review	–	–	–	–	Half-yearly update on risks in the financial system.
	Q3	Job Vacancies	%qtr	–2.1	–	3.5	Partial indicators point to a bounce-back in vacancies.
	Aug	Goods Trade Balance	$bn	1.9	2.2	2.3	A bounce-back in coal and iron ore export volumes to support.
NZ	Aug	Building Permits	%mth	–4.3	–	Flat	Annual total elevated, but are we approaching a peak?
Jpn	Q3	Tankan Large Manufacturers	index	22	25	–	Another solid improvement anticipated, but details will be key.
Eur	Aug	Unemployment Rate	%	6.4	6.4	–	Broadly stable near its record low level.
US		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	197	–	–	Will remain low, even after bouncing back post-holidays.
	Sep	ISM Manufacturing	index	54.6	55.0	–	Robust expansion across vast range of sub-industries.
	Aug	Construction Spending	%mth	–0.5	0.1	–	High mortgage rates a clear drag; data centres an exception.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Barkin, Collins, Schmid, Cook, Williams, Logan.
World	Sep	S&P Global Manufacturing PMI	index	–	–	–	Final estimate for Japan, Europe, UK and US.
Fri 02							
NZ	Sep	ANZ Consumer Confidence	index	98.0	–	–	Picking up recently, but vulnerable to resurgent fuel prices.
Jpn	Sep	Tokyo CPI	%ann	1.9	2.5	–	Expected to foreshadow a lift in nationwide inflation pressures.
	Aug	Jobless Rate	%	2.4	2.4	–	Still indicative of a fairly tight labour market.
Eur	Sep	CPI	%ann	3.2	3.5	–	Subdued core inflation gives little need for excessive tightening.
US	Sep	Nonfarm Payrolls	000s	162	100	80	Likely to hold around recent trends ...
	Sep	Unemployment Rate	%	4.1	4.1	4.2	... while a rise in participation may see unemployment gain.
	Sep	Average Hourly Earnings	%mth	0.3	0.3	–	To hold at a stable level.
	Aug	Factory Orders	%mth	0.9	–0.1	–	Choppy but broadly indicative of firmer investment.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (25 Sep)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.35	4.60	4.60	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.76	4.70	4.70	4.55	4.30	4.05	3.85	3.95	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	5.03	4.65	4.60	4.50	4.40	4.30	4.25	4.20	4.15	4.10
3 Year Bond	5.03	4.65	4.60	4.50	4.40	4.30	4.25	4.20	4.15	4.10
10 Year Bond	5.38	5.20	5.10	5.00	4.90	4.85	4.80	4.80	4.80	4.80
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	21	40	35	30	25	15	5	0	-5	-10
United States										
Fed Funds	3.625	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	5.17	4.80	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.70	4.75	4.80	4.85	4.90
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.23	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	4.12	3.95	4.10	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	5.10	4.75	4.90	5.00	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	-9	–5	15	30	40	35	30	25	20	15

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (25 Sep)	Dec-26	Mar-27	Jun-27	Sep-27	Dec-27	Mar-28	Jun-28	Sep-28	Dec-28
AUD/USD	0.7016	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5665	0.59	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.65
USD/JPY	158.15	155	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146
EUR/USD	1.1374	1.17	1.18	1.19	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3218	1.35	1.36	1.37	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40
USD/CNY	6.7129	6.70	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2401	1.22	1.19	1.16	1.14	1.12	1.12	1.11	1.11	1.11

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.4	0.4	0.4	0.5	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.1	1.5	1.7	1.6	1.6	1.7	2.6	1.5	1.7	2.5
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	0.5	0.7	0.6	0.7	0.4	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	3.7	3.0	3.0	2.5	2.4	3.6	3.7	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	0.9	0.7	0.8	0.7	0.6	0.6	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.5	3.3	3.2	3.1	2.8	2.7	3.3	3.3	2.7	2.3

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.8	1.1	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.5	2.7	2.8	2.9	0.3	2.4	2.9	3.1
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.2	5.1	4.9	5.4	5.4	4.9	4.4
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	0.6	0.4	0.4	0.6	0.3	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	3.7	3.2	2.1	2.0	1.7	3.1	3.7	1.7	2.1

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RETAIL SPENDING PULSE

7 October 2026

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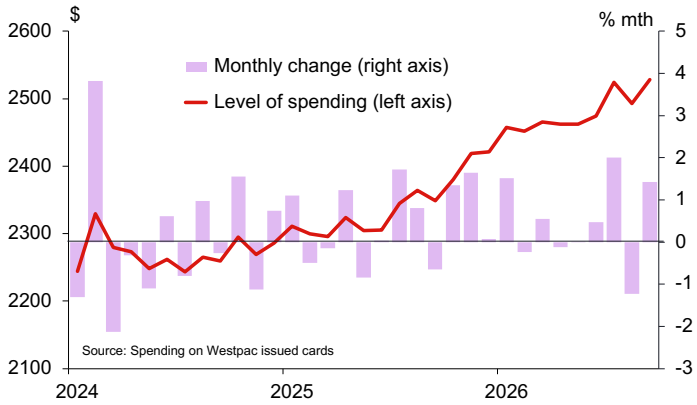
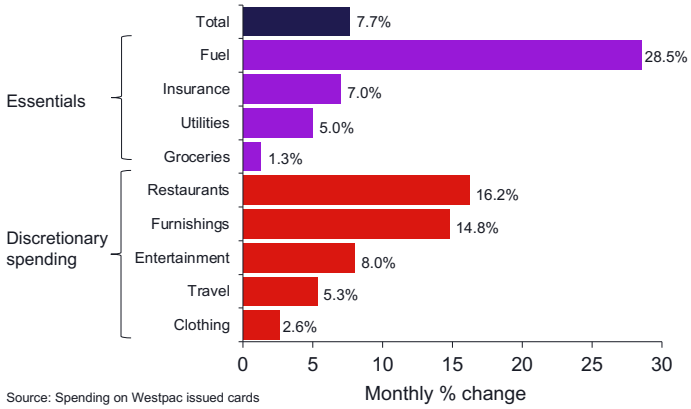
Spending holding up (for now) as fuel prices rocket higher

- Per-person spending on Westpac issued credit and debit cards was up 1.4% in September and is up 7.7% compared to this time last year.
- Part of the reason for the lift in spending over the past month was the large increase in fuel prices. That saw spending on fuel rising 3.8% over the past month, even as the volume of petrol purchased fell. Fuel spending is up 28% compared to this time last year.
- However, even excluding spending on fuel, spending levels have continued to climb.
- Looking under the surface, we are spending more on essentials and in non-discretionary areas. Notably, spending on utilities (like electricity) is up 5% over the past year, while spending on insurance is up 7%. Those are both areas where we have seen big cost increases.
- But there's also been a sizeable lift in discretionary spending categories, like furnishings (up 15%yr) and dining out (+16%). That points to resilience in spending appetites in the face of cost of living pressures and other headwinds.
- Spending on travel has also held up in the wake of the Middle East war, though many of us are choosing to travel to more budget-friendly destinations or those that are viewed as less risky.

Monthly retail spending (per person, seasonally adjusted)



Annual spending growth (per person)



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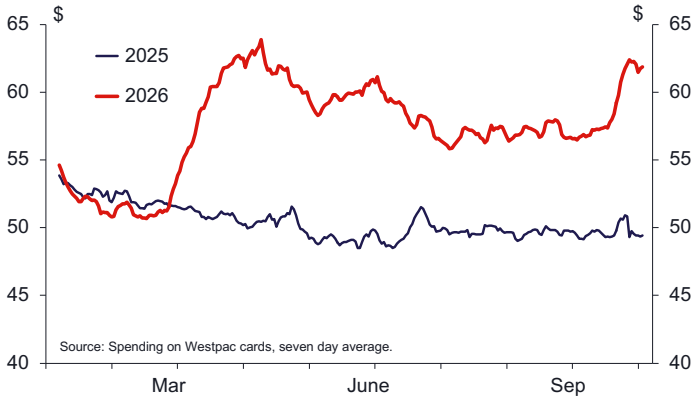
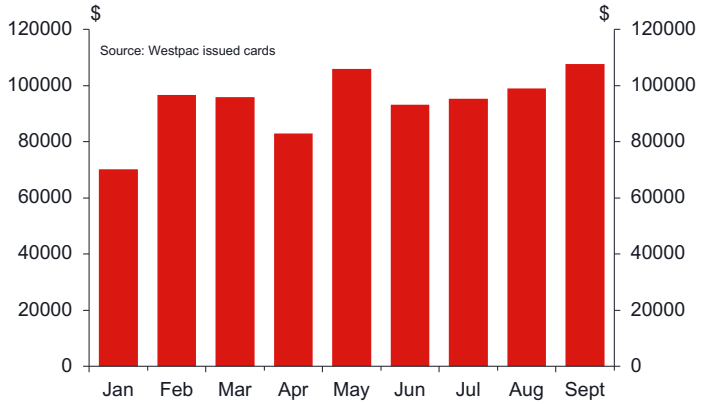
Continued pain at the pump

- Fuel prices have rocketed higher over the past month, with the nationwide average price for 91 unleaded reaching $3.53/litre in recent days. That's higher than we saw in the early stages of the Middle East war.
- That sharp rise in fuel costs is draining money from households' wallets, with spending on fuel up 28% compared to this time last year.
- In response to those higher prices, New Zealanders are driving less and filling up less often. That has seen the volume of fuel sold drop by around 9% compared to this time last year.
- Higher fuel prices have prompted other changes also. Daily spending on public transport is up about 12% since the end of February.
- Households have also told us that they've been more cautious about their discretionary spending since fuel prices have risen. Even when it comes to spending on essentials like groceries, many households have said they're now purchasing fewer or cheaper items.

Average fuel spend per transaction



Average daily spending on public transport



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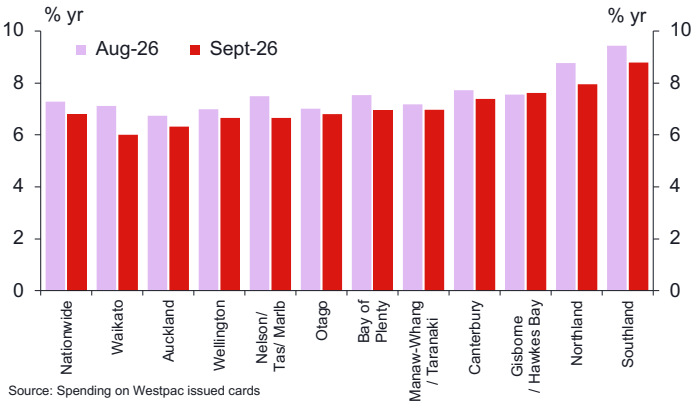
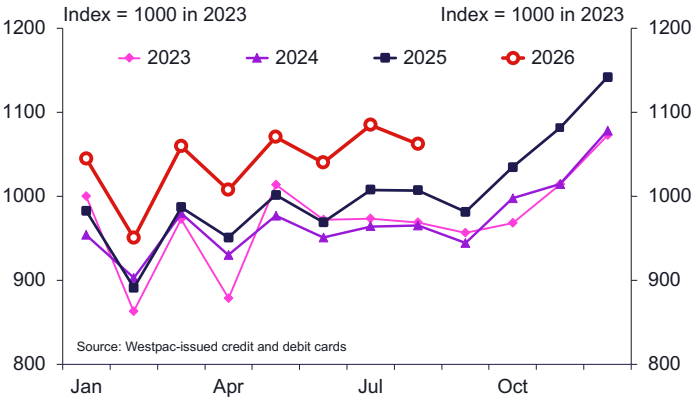
Regional breakdown

- The impact of higher fuel prices and increases in other living costs is being felt right across the country. That has seen spending growth slowing in every region over the past month.
- Southland has continued to record the strongest spending growth in the country. However, the strength in commodity export earnings is helping to support earnings, confidence and spending in many areas with strong rural backbones.
- In contrast, spending growth in Auckland and Wellington is continuing to trail most other parts of the country, consistent with the softness in their labour markets.

Annual spending growth - past three months compared to same time last year



Spending on Westpac credit and debit cards (per person)



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Westpac Banking Corporation.

First Impressions: NZ business confidence, September 2026

#businessconditions #newzealand

By Satish Ranchhod
Senior Economist, Westpac NZ

10:43 September 30 2026

Share

The recovery is continuing but it remains bumpy. Inflation gauges have not increased despite the recent rise in oil prices.

Key results, September 2026

Business confidence: 51.9 (Prev: 53.7)

Expectations for own activity: 47.9 (Prev: 48.2)

Activity vs same month one year ago: 10.8 (Prev: 16.4)

Inflation expectations: 3.25% (Prev: 3.26%)

Pricing intentions: 48.4 (Prev: 51.0)

There was a modest easing in September's business confidence survey. However, gauges of past and expected business activity, as well as business confidence remain at firm levels, consistent with the recovery continuing in the latter part of the year.

While that's welcome news, most of the responses were received prior to the recent spike in oil prices. Those responses that came through later in the month were softer, but in most cases, we're still left with a relatively resilient picture of business conditions. Indeed, the ANZ noted that we haven't seen the same sort of pessimism we saw earlier in the year when fuel price first spiked. That's consistent with our recent theme of the economy shaking off the impacts of the Iran war.

There was one notable exception – hiring intentions did take a noticeable step down following the fuel spike, and this will be a key area to watch over the coming months.

Notably, gauges of inflation pressure didn't rise despite the recent fuel price spike. Expectations for inflation were steady (3.25% this month vs 3.26% in August), while the number of firms planning on raising prices fell back. That's notable given the lift in wage and cost expectations. However, even with today's easing, the surveys measures of inflation pressure remain elevated.

Overall, we're left with a picture of fairly resilient activity and contained (but not low) inflation pressures. That very modest response to the fuel spike will help to calm nerves at the RBNZ ahead of October's policy review. We'll we watching to see if sort of message is reflect in next week's closely watch Quarterly Survey of Business Opinion (out 6 October) and in the upcoming inflation reports (16 and 22 October).

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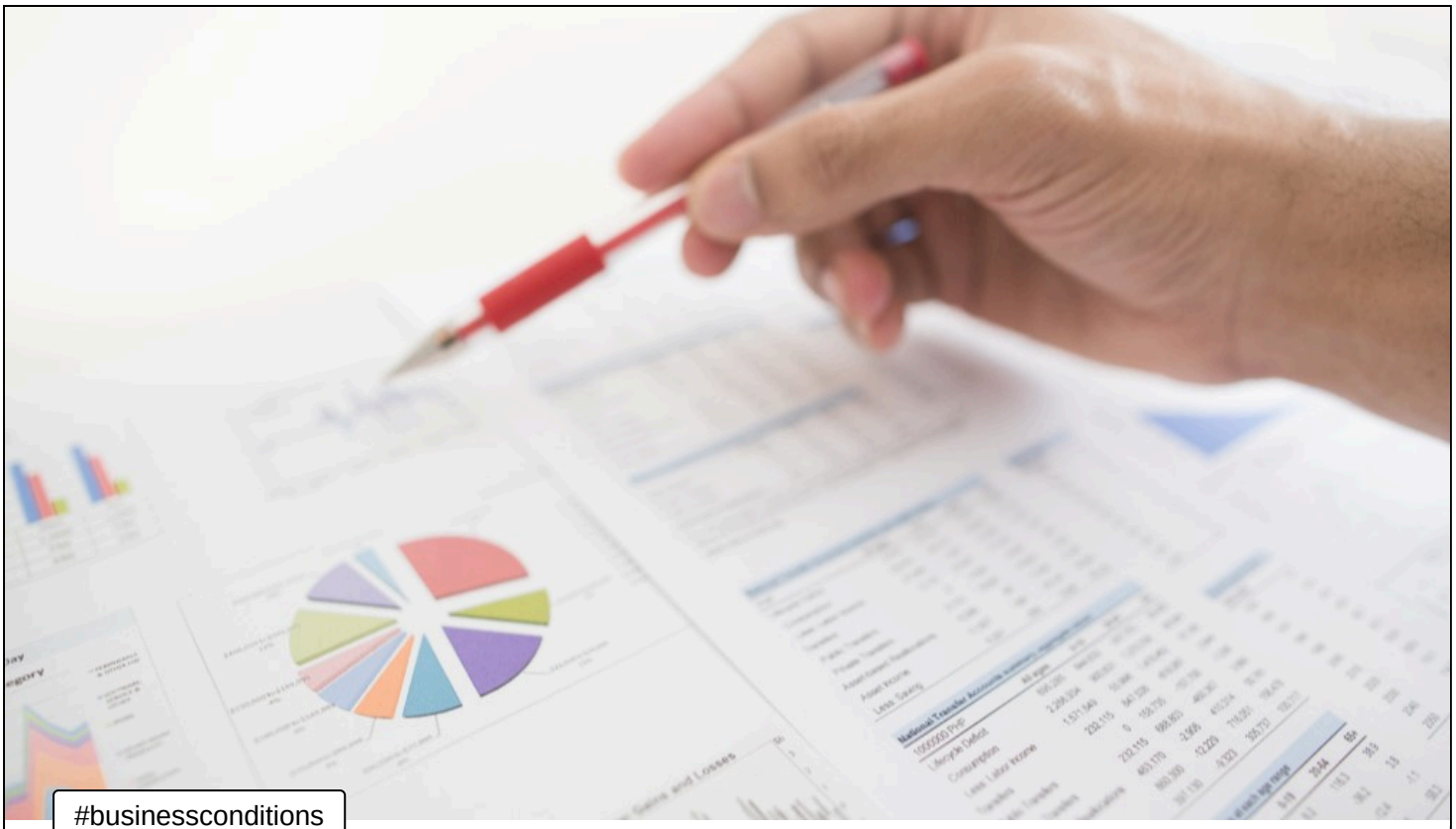

#businessconditions

Australian Business Conditions and Confidence, September

October 13 2026 • 5 mins

By Luka Belobrajdic

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First Impressions: NZIER Quarterly Survey of Business Opinion, September quarter 2026

October 06 2026 • 2 mins

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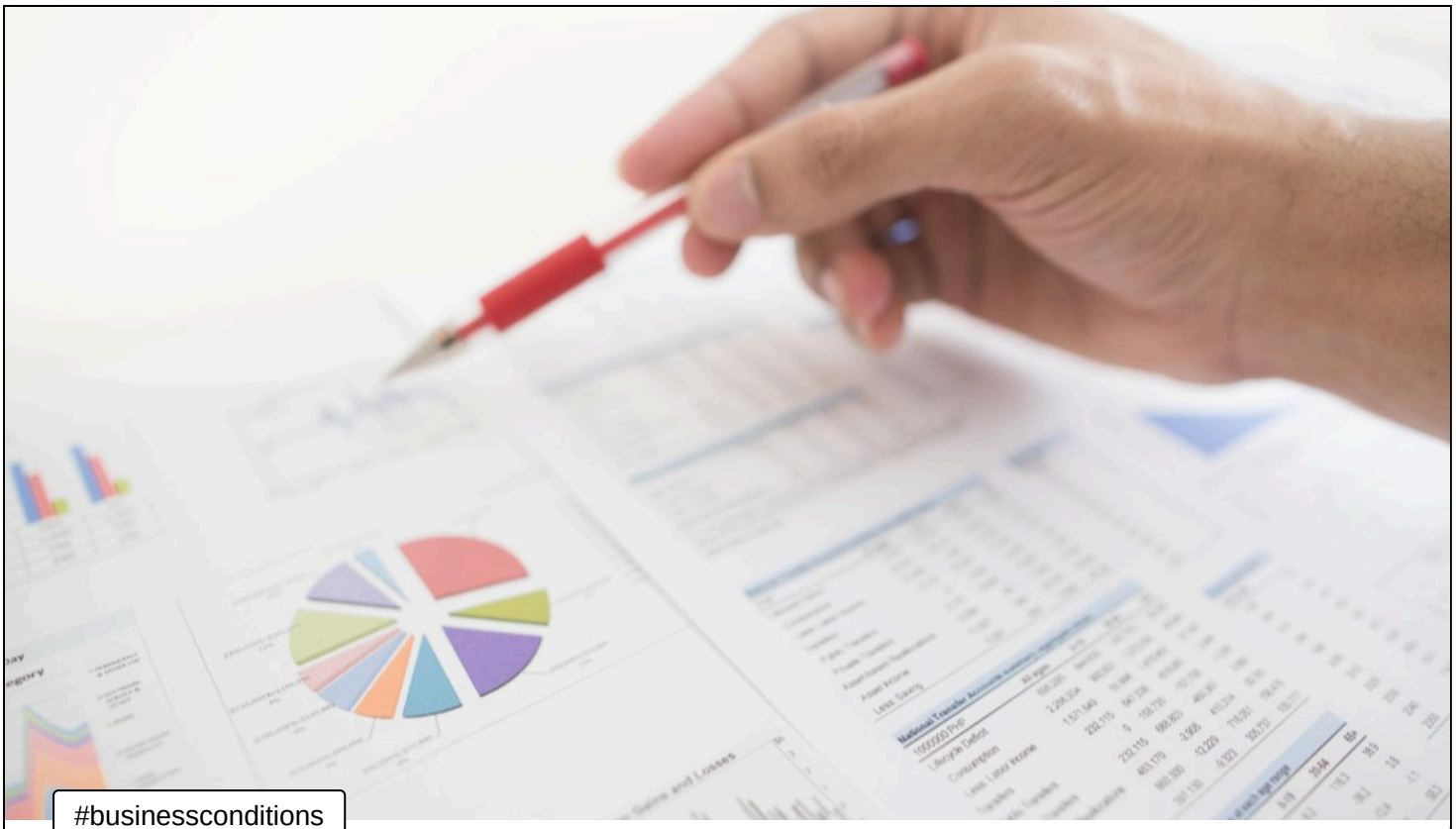

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September 21 2026 • 5 mins

By Pat Bustamante

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